Episode Δ — With All My Strength

Earth's aria reverberates through the ground, dispersing across the hills and valleys. It breaks into a flood that surges through the streets of New York City, tearing the cityscape apart like a sea forced open.

Faults split open as the song tears through the city, swallowing the skyscrapers ahead of Daleth whole. The skyline shatters into the streets, leaving dust to dust, and **Ashes** in its wake.

"*SHOOT*!" Daleth yelps, his chest tightening.

He ducks and sprints in the opposite direction, dodging the debris as it scrapes his skin. He stares up and scowls, cursing the song. The blood blends into his clothes—'like I'm clad in my own mortality.' He trips on a splintered beam and crashes into the concrete. A tooth snaps loose. He spits it out—then scrambles back into a sprint.

"Sigiward, status report?!" he roars into his phone as it trembles in his right hand.

"The Terminal is offline, so I'm a lil' busy right now!" Sigiward shouts.

Daleth grunts, shaking his head. "Daedalus, what's the plan?!"

"There *IS* no plan," Daedalus declares. "The defense systems are down, so keep stalling, and we'll improvise."

"Fine! And where are the others?"

“Still evacuating the city. ~~*Vf*~~ ~~*Ghil*~~ g~~*eSB*~~ ~~*3aWx*~~h, t~~*sIH*~~ ~~*RyeSB*~~ h~~*0by*~~ ~~*Bz*~~ e~~*YXZlIGV*~~ ~~*2ZX*~~ ~~*J5b25*~~ ~~*lLg==*~~r#.”

“Huh? Your mic is glitching!”

“F##k, wh@tev€r! The¥’ll b€ fine, but *you* need to.. er... not die!”

Daleth huffs out a chuckle—then flinches into silence as a street light slams down in front of him. “...Damn! We graduated high school for this? Guess—”

“Shut up and *FOCUS*!” Daedalus demands.

Daleth rolls his eyes but nods. “Got it.”

The phone falls into his pocket; he snaps into stride.

As he leans into his sprint, shock waves peel off his outline. Shattered glass spreads through the sky like a crystal cascade. The air around him ionizes into blue-white distortion bands, and the asphalt fractures beneath each impact.

“Aodh!” Daleth roars.

A red haze flares across his body, cutting through the blue-white light.

[TBC; main project moved to a different document]

Authors' Note

I've been told to trust the reader, so I will ***try*** to write as if I do.

To be fair, everyone else wrote this with me, so I'll be writing here for them. ¯_(ツ)_/¯

I don't NEED to add this part, but since every author has one for some reason, I might as well.

I took *SO* much inspiration from everything we've ever read, watched, and played, that you could call it some sort of unsung plagiarism. Catcher in the Rye, Omniscient Reader's Viewpoint, Lord of the Mysteries, One Punch Man, Evangelion, Aobuta, Undertale, Roblox, Minecraft, etc.

The foundation for everything, though, was Aidan's idea to dress up as a red junkbot on Roblox. Then, Gabriel joined in on the bit. The two of them convinced me to get in on it, and I felt like making a written story out of it as well. Zachary thought it was cool too, and went to make a game for it. Zach kidnapped his son, Colin, for the role of Purple, who went "happily" along with it. Finally, Orange was found once we convinced the biggest blunder, Shawl, to finish us off.

The main story of the Colored Crusaders has been done for a very *long* time. The story of the entire world, however, took longer to come up with. I wanted it to be the perfect balance of fun and serious, but I also couldn't mess up the overall structure of the story. On top of that, I had to somehow mix those two stories together to make this!

As I'm writing this, I still have yet to finish it. I do have the entire story in my mind; even then, there's simply SO MUCH TO *WRITE*, the thought turning me into a couch potato. Still, I'll finish everything soon (no I won't)!

Anyways, this is all you need to know while reading this: this is a fun story with serious metaphors, meant for one reader. Who? I'm not telling you!

Episode 0 — Primary Protocol

【The Calamity "[redacted]" gazes at the outside world.】

Monochrome mars the myriad worlds of the Somnium. It stains what was once overflowing with dynamism, now with an unmatched emptiness. Colors themselves are nonexistent. The Somnium remains as only sorry shapes and feckless figures.

Even so, something stands against it.

「The Regalia」revels in the world-ending cataclysm caused by the「Thought Machine.」The end of times is nigh, though one hero—the man conceived by the very concepts of「Milieu」and「Resin」—stands between Earth and its destruction. Many struggle to remember his real name, however.

Most of The Somnium's remaining Sovereigns have gathered in the world farthest from the spread of mortals, or what they would refer to as amelioration. All in attendance are those Sovereigns amongst the Regalia's ranks, coincidentally.

"This world has lost its viability with veritability," a Sovereign, whose figure resembles that of a sycamore, sighs.**【Princep "_Acting Overseer of Creation_" expresses his genuine disappointment.】**

«What has become of this world?» another, short, serious, military-decorated, and six-armed Sovereign laments. «Desolation, in its utmost absolute form.»**【Princep "_Extol of Exertion_" lacks any motivation to carry on.】**

«It is fortunate that The Swepnos' power has become so sparse,» remarked a bespectacled, eight-piece suited Sovereign. «Though, our positions as postulates of their powers have consequently run rather dry.»**【Princep "_Unyielding Heart_" cogitates their potential ruin in the near future.】**

«The flow of Sol is controlled by them too! Not our fault most of 'em lost their powers,» one hot-headed Sovereign, with an appearance akin to a circus ringleader, haughtily spews. **【Princesa "_Champion of the Industry_" roars out in frustration at their creations.】**

«Control your venom, Lucretia,» a literal and metaphorical Sovereign of angelic purity preaches. «Some still possess the righteous ways of us; and even without them, we'll continue to control the circulation of force throughout the cosmos.»**【Princesa "_Mourning Morningstar_" smiles at the impregnable image of the Regalia.】**

«What about those abnormalities that draw on others' strength?» a curious Sovereign, often an opposer to the angelic being, queries whilst scratching his lion-like mane.**【Princep "_Formality at Its Finest_" tilts his head in playful defiance.】**

[…]

The Defender of Dreams shifts uncontrollably as his very own creation strives to be the only real problem in his path.

"Jeez, why'd this all have to turn out so badly..?"

He'd rather this be reduced back to the same problem years ago that mismanaged only his mind. Much to his dislike, it consumes much more than *him*, however.

The Thought Machine roars with power, its presence being felt by every ameliorite across the cosmos. Surging from the depths of the Earth, the little ball of green and blue struggles to hold onto its already loose grip on the「Continuity Construct」, as the eyes of「Enthalpy」and「Entropy」direct their attention towards the commotion.

«A once-in-an-eternity sight, is it not?» huffs the faltering voice of an arrogant scientist. His trench coat, completed by a glitching scarf flows flauntingly from the surge of power. «The end of days, and the finalization of the Fall of Foundation.»

A rugged man, the Defender of Dreams as they call him, grumbles on the ground with utter contempt for the scientist standing beside him. The scarf of the scientist bluntly smacks his face amidst the violent whirlwind.

"You little…" His teeth clench before they can chatter with anger.

«Don't blame me for something neither of us are strong enough to combat. 'Twas simply the catalyst for an inevitable process.»

The Defender of Dreams grimaces, off-put by how pretentious the man sounds. He puts on a fake voice to mock him, speaking in a similar manner.

"*Ha*! Don't think it's over yet, though," he grins, as if he's remembered something.

«Hm? What could possibly be up your sleeve this time, Delta? Admit it. You were bested in this final, most pivotal moment of ***truth***.»

The machine ardently continues its wailing of mechanical whirring. It grows louder by the second, both of their ears bleeding from their proximity to the intense sound waves.

“I wouldn’t be so sure of that, Exar,” Delta proudly proliferates, weakly shaking his head with disdain.

A low rumbling independent of the machine can be heard slowly approaching from a considerable distance—miles away, from the sound of it.

«..And what could I have possibly forgotten to take into account?» Exar hesitantly interrogates, trying to ignore the sound of a potential interloper.

“Did you ever think about why the rest of the Regalia never physically entered Earth?”

In tandem with the machine, the roaring from the opposite direction has become just as tumultuous.

«Because it was never of any interest to them in them first place.»

“We both know that they keep tabs on everything,” Delta declares, his grin elevating. “They wouldn’t be lazy about a singular planet, bozo.”

Exar halts his hubris for a moment, turning around towards Delta.

«…It couldn’t be.»

“It is!”

«B-but on a lowly planet such as this?!»

“Civilization’s pretty rare across the multiverse. It’s why there’s life here and nowhere else in the galaxy.”

«You couldn’t be serious…» Exar denies.

“Somehow, I am.”

Behind Delta and in front of Exar stood a massive, humanoid monster; not necessarily of the grotesque type, but more as some slim, sinister demon shrouded in darkness.

„ሠኽዐ ፏዐቹነ ፕኽቕዪቕ?“ the demon booms, eyeing the two of them. Delta could feel its eyes burning into the back of his head. „□ኽ, □ክ ል□ር□-□ዐ♡ቹ□ቹ□ፏ□ □ክ□ □—“

«O’ Great Wonder of Estranged Evil, Erebus!” he says ceremoniously, putting on airs like his life depends on it. “What a pleasure to meet a fellow enemy of the Regalia—”

Exar exclaims, in an uproar, «Quiet! You know not what you spout—»

The demon, some eight meters tall, swatted the Sovereign scientist aside, knocking his body into a momentary unconsciousness with an effortless flick of the wrist. ‘The same, sick guy that used dying multiverses as his toys just got sent flying by this… beast!’ Delta cogitates.

The scientist slowly rises from the dust, coughing up a sum of the viscous, esoteric liquid that keeps his host body’s machinery running.

«System, commence Combat Protocol #12.»

In an instant, Exar's knee appears inches from Erebus's temple. Erebus takes hold of Exar's knee, holding their entire body up with a singular hand.

Surprised, the scientist extends his other leg forward with blinding speed. The darkness mindlessly shifts his torso away from the kick, grabbing the scientist's face with his free hand and slamming it into the ground.

Before Exar's head can reach the cavern floor, his lower half bends and exerts an ungodly amount of force to oppose the push on his upper half. His elbows plant themselves in the crystalline sod, then, as his legs spring forth to deliver a tenacious thrust to Erebus's gut.

The darkness grins as it's blown away towards the wall behind it, cackling a senile cackle. As it crashes into the cavern wall, a gaping wound is left by an enormous crystal, leaving the darkness dry coughing for a moment before regaining its composure.

„As expected of ‚The Engineer of Calamity.'"

«My epithet is not to be used by the likes of *you*.»

Glorious sparks fill the crystal cavern, each reflected in the multicolor view of Delta's pristine eyes. He can't detect any movement visibly, though the air around him shifts uncontrollably with their power.

Only a minute passes, but the fatigued fighters feel as if they've been battling for ceaseless years.

«System, commence Retreat Protocol #1,» Exar spews out spitefully.

Exar's body begins to dissipate into nothingness, pixels rising from his being. «I'll only compromise for now. This planet means nothing, anyhow,» he grunts as he swiftly takes his leave.

Erebus, panting heavily, walks over to Delta. He crosses his arms and dares not look directly at his company, as if to hide his own shame for his weakened state.

„□o□ፕ□ክᗡቹ."

Delta gulps, visibly constrained by the fear of this encounter with the agent of an ancient god. He, trying to match the spiritual pressure situated before him, humbly arises from the ashen terrain. "I only wanna protect this planet, Great One, nothing else."

As the demon's eyes examine the rugged, yet resolute man, he can feel the sensation of each individual blood vessel—each blood cell—in his body quivering, each on the verge of rupturing or exploding. His body tightens, the authority of the demon squeezing at the ***truth*** present within. The demon, sentimentality quietly winning him over, gives Delta a strange look.

„□ □ቹ□. ሃ□ᕮ ል□ቹ... □ዪ□ፚ□ነ□ክ□."

His breath hitches; then, it flows back into order. "More than promising! I can fix you, fully!"

Finally beginning to resemble something human, Erebus began to smile, almost taken in by Delta's bravery. It continued to stare into Delta's soul, listening to his impromptu speech.

“I’m cool with giving you my support for your life, Great One. I can use your power for both of our benefits—”

„□ □ᚷᚱᛋ ርᚢᚠᚹᚪᚽᚱ □ᛎᚢᚠ ᛋᚱᚷ ርᚳᚢᛟᚱ □ᚠᚱᚽ. ᚹᚢᚠ ᛔᛎᛎᚳᚽ□ ᚷᛏ ᚹᛎᛎ □ᚪᚱᚳᚽᚳᚽ□′□ Ꮤᛎ□ጋ, □ᚠᚱ □ረᚳᚢ□ Ꮤᴏ□ጋ□ᚽ.“

“..My friend begs to differ.”

The creature falls silent. He can sense what “friend” Delta is referring to. ‘□ □ᚠ□ᚠ ጮ□ᚽ.□ል□ □ᛎ□ᚠ ᚺᚽᚸ, □ᚳ□ᛔ□ᚳ□ □ 「ᚴᴏD」?’ Erebus can’t help but ponder what lays before his eyes. He didn’t anticipate anything this interesting in eons, but now…

Delta lightly sighs as an air of confidence wafts in the waves of light slowly glowing about him. ‘I didn’t want to mention my leading principle, but…’

“You can see right through me too,” he smiles. “You were planning to make me your harbinger, right? Well, I promise you…”

An esoteric power begins to faintly emit from Delta’s body, illuminating the entire cavern. Erebus is almost too stunned to see it, but he truly does hail from the「Arbiter of All」. The Authority is unmistakable.

“I could be much more than that.”

„□ □ᚠ□. □ᚺᚽᚳ, ᗯᚺᚽᚹ ,ጋ□ □ᴏᗡ □ᚷᚱᚽᚹ□ᚾ□ □ᴏᗡ′□ረ ,ጋ□ Ꮤᛎ□ᚺᚽ ጮ□ □ᴏᗯᚠ□ᚾ? □ᴏ□ᚾ□ጋ□ᚽ.□ᚳ□ □ᚺᚽ□ □ᚠ□ᚱᚽ□ᛎ□, ᚹᚠ□ Ꮤᛎ□ረ ᚳ□ᚹ ᚹ□ᚣ□ □ᴏᗡᚽ. ,ጋ□ርᚢᚾ□ᴏ□ □ᛎ□ᚺᚽᚳᚽᚽ□, ᚠᚱᚽ□ Ꮤᛎ□ረ ᚳ□ᚹ ᚹ□ᚣ□ ᚾᗡᚽᚱᴏ□ᚹ ᴏ□ □ □ᴏ□.“

Delta didn’t find any importance in the “god” comment. “I can handle the backlash, but—”

The uproarious rumbling of the mechanical madness heightens, its deep tremors splitting the cavern apart.

"—what I can't handle is my world blowing up..!"

„ᎯᏂᏫᏦ, ᎤᏂᏫᏲᎴᎤᏂᏫᏲᎴᏩᎮᎤᏂᏫᏲᎴᏩᎮᎤᏂᏫᏲᎴᏩᎮ

A presence from inside Delta reaches out to speak through him, to him. „No man has stood to gain from me, for fervent fear of me was only natural. You, however, are… *different*."

"Then, are you saying..?"

„Yes, I shall silently settle in your body. However, a small promise would be satisfactory."

Delta's breath hitches as he exasperatedly listens to the Wonder of Estranged Evil—whose title he began to quietly question.

„Destroy the Regalia, and [redacted]."

Delta thinks to himself, perplexed. '[redacted]..? I was already planning on the first part, but what the yell was that censored second part…'

„I can hear your thoughts, ameliorite."

"Then, [redacted]—"

„Turn on the Thought Machine, and you will come to know."

"T-turn it on? You're crazy!"

„It is *your* creation, human."

Delta swerves around to face the engineering marvel behind him. He's hesitant, for what untold consequences could come from its activation?

„Do not be afraid, dearest benefactor. Trust the power you now have vested within you—"

A susurration of wind comes from deep within Delta's heart and soul. The last thing he needed was to be caught in the middle of a dubious situation—with the Wonder of Estranged Evil, no less—at a time like this.

„—and the authority of that「Regnator」."

Delta frowns, his troubled expression more than telling. He'd rather not use his authority, especially after what tragedy he caused.

„I see…"

Thousands of miles above, the increasingly livid light rays of the bloodshot Sovereign eye shine down from the heavens above, its photon awning adorning the horizon. The newly dawning day sparkles like fresh blood on the faces of the unsuspecting ameliorites situated above.

Meanwhile, in the Earth's outer core, the source of the catastrophe, a dissonance drifts and drones on like a declaration of war. Delta's hidden resonance reverberates like a church bell, sparse semblances of a sanguine, selfish hope convening from his surroundings and in his fists.

'..I shouldn't be doing this, but…'

„Keep pushing."

A silent rage bubbles over Delta, almost consuming him. In a manner reminiscent of Erebus's stance, he outstretches a singular hand. How terribly he wants to smash it to bits; though, he knows better, and activates the Thought Machine.

The machine's low murmuring quickly abates, falling into a complete silence. Instances of varying wavelengths, then, begin to fade in and out of existence around the machine. Faster and faster become the positive, yet myriad photon readings that are visualizing themselves in front of the successor of renegade tenebrae, 'till suddenly

they take shape.

Mechanical beings of uncannily human semblance overtake the blank black and white. Different body builds define each of their torsos alongside unique accessories, though the same pants and robotic hats play on their appearances.

The restless「Red」proliferates a plentiful message of passion-filled playfulness, dancing like a distinguished guest present within a regal ballroom of flame-lit guests. His right arm is of a champion's golden gauntlet, embroidered with a royal insignia—an emblem that exudes immediate authority over the world around him.

The ostentatious「Orange」revels in its mechanical mischief, humming a familiar, moon-linked tune towards the sky. Confidence consumes every presentable angle of his figure, wherein the ancient armor and empty, rusty scabbard covering his back serve as the backbone to such high airs.

The yare「Yellow」looks at the two men, thoroughly taken aback by their standings outside of the corruptive causality of Creation. A scarf of infinite nullity washes over his neck and

shoulders, a chromium visor shields his field of view, and shabby rags barely manage to cloak his true splendor.

The gallant「Green」takes a gander at the gleaming expressions of the others, rather intrigued by their electron-like excitement. His tattered, yet royal military gear—his glistening shades, his gray beanie, his dark yet royal attire—emanates echoes of the exemplary past his life once was.

The bold「Blue」streaks like a firework across the empty expanse of the cavern, his movements less controlled and more chaotic than「Red's」. He fashions a dashing fedora, a cool countenance to cover his telling eyes, and polished, blue armor that stays worn no matter the heat or rust.

The purposeful「Purple」blinks at the unattainable abyss, fascinated by its existence before all else; yet, he wants to remain here, away from it.

「Colors」—'so that's what those are'—splash into the monotone void, instantaneously recreating the boring reality of Somnium. Robotic beings, each a different color and nearly identical to ameliorites in composition burst forward, all scattered around and about the cavern. They confusedly survey the area, disturbed by the unfamiliar setting.

Erebus chuckles lightly, pleased by the pleasant sight of nostalgia. „Let the catastrophes unfold, and watch them as they rekindle this world."

'Who are they? What is all this?'

Delta raises an eyebrow, feeling a slight smile appear upon his countenance from Erebus's ever-present eidolon. „..You'll come to know soon enough. Do guide them, though, for your divine intervention may make all the difference in their story."

'Their.. story?'

A metallic clanging can be heard when one of the colored men falls to the heated ground. It's a stark, 「Red」 hue. He's on a single knee, his expression as out of place as the newly-inaugurated inverse mono painting the once empty space.

"..What is all this?"

None of the other colors can be seen in the vicinity. Erebus senses Delta's apprehension, speaking against it. „They all went off to carve their own paths. They'll be back… with answers."

Red's eyes glaze over the surface of everything, as if trying to slowly discern the atomic makeup of everything visible and invisible to the human eye.

"..Who are you two?"

Delta is a bit taken aback, for what pair of eyes could truly shape out the essence of two souls as one?

"Spectators," Delta level-headedly responds.

"..Who am I?"

„...“

Erebus's dreadful silence disturbs Delta. Neither knows what to make of this forlorn sight.

'Why didn't the others stay here with him?'

„Because… he was the only one to respond to your emotions—your… *heat signature.*“

「Red」, the Flame of Fate, and the first of the Catastrophic Colors had responded to Delta's rage at that moment; furthermore, all of the colors responded to the brightest signatures of emotion, reflective of their respective perspectives, from the very moment they were brought back to life.

'So, what am I supposed to do now..?'

„Talk to him,“ Erebus says, his serious tone permeating his world-weariness. „He's your「sketch」, after all.“

'..I don't wanna talk to that weirdo,' Delta opposes. 'What if my research was *wrong*?'

„The legends…Those games you played… The Tablets… It was all true. It was all real history.“

'Then, what happens when I [redacted]?'

Erebus sighs, answering his queries as if he was reading out the terms and service of some crappy, yet creepy contract. „You gain his powers and his memories, which are necessary

for reaching your [redacted]. Until you fully [redacted], however, you'll be splitting control with him in regards to every you say or do."

'…'

„Their aid is of the utmost import."

'…'

„Do you wish to save the world, or not? I thought you humans romanticized things like this."

'…'

„Make the choice, Delta," Erebus insists, his voice increasingly authoritative.

'…'

Delta, courage embedded in the entresol entering his feet, paces forward. He and Red share the same gaze—the same sleepy countenance that counts the sins of the dead and living alike. 'Everything feels so… unreal.'

Falling into a deep sleep outside of control and consciousness, their souls intertwine within a single interval between space and time. The interim reality of this single moment is almost unbelievable to Delta. 'Tis the kind of closeness that only exists when the distance between two is so immeasurable.

'I know who you are,' he wants to tell Red. 'You…'

"I… Who am I?"

"You.. are…"

["He's a monster!"]

"You…"

["A lonely, heartless beast, you are."]

"Are…"

["The most incompetent god…"]

…

…

“Red.”

The air is thick with heat. Red leads with an intensely-pointed index finger. Delta gulps, about to intercept it.

Red unexpectedly taps him on the nose instead, which elicits his own laughter. Delta makes a surprised expression, though shakes his head in amiable understanding.

As their particles make contact, a brilliant effulgence flashes through the farthest reaches of Creation. The bloody stream beyond the horizon abates into nothingness, and the Sovereign eye returns to its yellow mellow. The council of Sovereigns viewing the scene through Exar’s eyes panic, barking like dogs at each other.

«□□□□ □□□ □□ □□ □□?!»

«Exar should have gone rogue!»

«₴ØⱮ₣฿ØÐ₹ ₴₮ØⱣ ₮H₣Ɱ!»

At the center of the flashing lights, two individuals stand tall. Like two neutron stars encircling each other, their bodies oscillate endlessly about a fixed axis. Their beings entangle at the quantum level. The two stars collide and fulminate

into a supernova.

〖*Ψθμ αγε αβιε τθ μσε τλε σκιω “Γεβιεστίθη.” Cθηταστ μαδε. Cθμμεηςίηg fiγστ ργθτθςθι, “Ωεμθγψ.”*〗

Episode 1 — In Time

Red sails through the concrete ocean of obscurity, following a deep, indigo trail of light. 'I thought we were all supposed to be there a little later. I guess he's early.'

The day before, they all agreed to meet at the diner downtown half past noon. Why? None of them would admit it in a million and one years, but they all dearly missed each other. Somehow, Blue got there first. Of course, Red resolves to jump him.

All the while their shenanigans stain the streets of Earth, the sky that is once again full of stars shines a tad too bright today.

The man in red whistles a fair tune. Recollection fills his eyes the moment the melody makes his mind up for him.

[...]

The vast expanse of the multiverse seems minuscule compared to the infinite energy of the Catastrophic Colors. Their origins, though unknown, are plausible enough to break through the fabric of truth protecting reality, permeating Chroma and seeping into neighboring multiversal networks.

The monochrome that sewed the fabric of reality for forever now weaves itself into a larger tapestry, purely composed of beautiful moments. Colors, which were thought to be mere myths 'till now, have become the greatest concern in the eyes of the Regalia.

«At the very least, the fools fresh from the dead… brought back the stars.»

【Princesa "*Mourning Morningstar*" relishes the revived light of space's stars.】

High and low, they attempt to make short work of their uproar. Angels upon angels course through the arteries and veins of the omniverse, patrolling everywhere to find the pesky rebels that adhered to neither Enthalpy or Entropy.

That, of course, doesn't stop them from causing chaos everywhere.

"Which way is Earth..?"

One of them is lost.

"We don't have much time."

One gravitates towards the atrium of attention.

"It's so dark... How does Yellow travel..?"

One is going to be late to the party.

"...Ugh."

One, effaced from the face of reality itself, stirs softly. Strident winds of godsbreath circle his frail, smallish figure. An angry, purple haze escapes his ajar eyes.

He ponders everything from the comfort of the Moon, fearful of the prophecy he came to understand. He searches for the rest of the Crusaders in the sky, hoping for their

imminent arrival. He doesn't see a speck of Red, however, looking down upon Earth from Mons Huygens.

"Where is Red..?"

"Still down there."

One lurks within the stream of consciousness available to the「Oneiric Network」.

"What the..."

And one is coming to terms with these myriad realities, as well as the ones untold. He awakes from his slumber, in a daze.

"Why is my right arm so... sore?" Delta wonders, looking down at his new arm. His eyes widen, and his mouth droops as he gawks at his golden gauntlet. "What's happening? What am I doing here, again?"

„Must you question everything..?" Erebus cranking comments, his voice crackling at the mere inclination of ignorance. „Your disappointing species fails to act upon any form of basic intuition."

Delta remembers the Wonder's presence in his body, quickly, yet haughtily addressing it. "...Erebus. I need to know."

In Delta's impatience lies a fierce demand for answers, prompting a veiled power to shoot out through his gallant gaze. In a turnabout rush of intervention, his gallant gaze gives way to an eidetic rush of information he cannot yet discern.

"Agh—!" Delta recoils from the shock of the sudden awakening of a new skill.

⟦*Ψθμ αγε μηαβιε τθ μσε τλε σκιιι "Γεβιεςτιθη."*⟧

„So, you are lacking proper⌜Syzygy⌟with Red to use his skills…"

"Did you just rage bait me for science..? And WHY would I need *proper alignment* to work with this guy?! I thought I already merged with him! This game is rigged!"

„This is no longer a *game*, Delta. This is real life now, unlike what you saw before."

Delta attempts to exercise his new body's right arm, but it barely budges an inch. In pushing further, he only attains a new perception of pain in his mind—pain for Delta never had any depth 'till now. Even more to his dismay, the dormant Red doesn't react at all to any of his poor decision-making skills.

"Is there any way to switch back?"

Erebus rolls his eyes, trying to avoid the query. „Alas, there is not. A dilemma to come, however, shall offer an effect paramount to such."

"Why do you always speak in riddles..?"

Delta ascends from the ashen alteration. He's disoriented by the change of scenery, but he attempts to make some sense of his surroundings—right, the crystal cavern.

"Anyways, how long was I out?"

„In mortal calculations, approximately eight months."

Delta chuckles, but Erebus's demeanor remains stagnant. The laughter dies down, reducing slowly to nervous exhalations.

"Wh-what?"

Erebus manifests as a shadow behind Red, smoking a fake cigar. „The Sovereigns have been searching for you everywhere. They won't search for you in my pocket dimension, though."

"Bro, you aren't cool…"

Delta's eyes swivel about, seeing no difference in his surroundings. The moment he reaches his hand out, however, it stops just a few inches out. "You're a trippy guy."

„They cannot deal with my magic," he proudly brags. „They have no imagination to help them out, anyhow."

"Uh… Is it safe to come out?"

„Not at all."

"Then, what am I doing? Am I just supposed to sit here and do nothing..?"

„We'll move when the time is right."

"Ah, jeez…"

Erebus shakes his head, still smoking on his cigar. As the smoke rises, a daunting feeling does as well, which the shadow notices first. It turns its head upwards, sensing danger.

„Ah… I fear we don't get to be the ones to decide this."

⟦*Sθmετλiηg ϖiϛκεδ τλis ϖαψ ϛθmεs.*⟧

The ground tremors tellingly, screaming out for Delta to run.

„Prepare yourself."

The stunning shimmer of the sparkling sky dies down, and peculiar hues settle in the sinister, shadowy sustenance of「Entropy」. Encroaching tenebra take shape around the solar system, troubling enough to throw Erebus for a loop.

The black bitterness, bereft of any sense of balance or order, spreads its tenebrous tendrils over the regenerating starlight. Primordial chaos, though such never truly existed since forever, reveals its resurgence in this all-consuming void. Knowledge loses all definition in the face of this undefinable, esoteric force.

Delta makes out a violent disarray in his headspace. It's Red, bouncing off the walls. He loses himself in the memories of the past—a world he now can't have. He roars in distress, his psyche destroyed. Delta feels his suffering firsthand, only being able to cast a rueful smile at the scene.

A purple penance perforates Red's heart, where even the smallest shred of guiltiness overcomes his righteous resolve. His crestfallen countenance creates an obvious opening for doubt to sink its fangs into his veritable soul.

Then,

it grows dark.

THE SKY COLLAPSES.

Every eye focuses its aim at the stars—the blessings of those from beyond the horizon—with worried expressions.

Darker.

THE STARS SCREAM IN AGONY.

Everything in view elicits evocations of the past. The ruins of Lapis Lacrimae all those eons ago seem so similar to the distant distress, fiercely floating above.

Yet darker.

Where did it all go wrong..?

Episode 2 — Sinking

The skylight streams into the serene silence, persistently clinging onto the wandering Blue. It fervently follows him through the endless, repeating streets of New York City, never leaving him for a singular moment throughout his boundless stroll. A familiar street graces his eyes, however, just as soon as he was about to fully dissociate.

Blue wonderly waltzes into a retrograde diner, a neon-colored "Coffee Creamers" atop the steely awning. Though it dates nearly a hundred years back in terms of style, it remains popular to this day. The restaurant itself is lightly sprinkled with classy, faithful customers chatting their personal affairs away, all about the red and white booths.

The sky-dyed crusader seats himself comfortably on a specially-reserved booth by the most scenic window available. The worried waitress attending the area pinches her nose with one hand and holds the menu in the other as she approaches Blue.

"So, the usual?"

"Nope, just waiting for the bois."

"..If you order later, you're gonna have to wait for a while, then."

"I do NOT care."

"..."

"GET OUUU—"

"FINE, FINE, I'M GOING," the waitress haughtily returns, stomping away.

Blue shakes his head and turns towards the shimmering transparency. He gazes at the authentic auspiciousness in the air: the Sun. 'After millennia, it's returned.'

Chatty customers off to the side somewhere speak discretely about worldly affairs, as if top-secret information were escaping the-once-functional Regalia's hands.

"Have you heard? Some rebels overthrew Nova and her new Regalia!"

"Serves the Sovereigns right. They lost their true authority a long, long time ago."

"Crazy. Wonder how they pulled it off."

"Must've been a crazy story."

Blue whistles a familiar tune whilst listening giddily to all of this. He slowly raises his left arm, its metallic makeup shimmering in the primal light.

"..I can finally beat my—"

"Holy, bro… What is wrong with you?"

"What's wrong with you? Were you 'boutta watch???"

"Yeah, but—*OKAY*, I thought you couldn't use that arm though…"

"Well, I can."

"You said it 'wouldn't work,' though."

"Nig—"

"Nah."

『*Ψθμ αγε μηαβιε τθ μσε τλε σκiu "Π-Wθγδ Pαss."*』

"Whatever, it's a funny story anyway."

"Bro, just say it."

Blue dramatically grips his left arm in his right hand, starting his monologue solemnly. "When enough years had gone by to enable us to look back on them, we sometimes discussed the events leading to his accide—"

"This is NOT *To Kill A Mockingbird*, bro, what the ye—"

"I'm gonna finger y—"

"OKAY, shut up, guys," Yellow abruptly interrupts. "Everyone's staring at us."

"WHEN DID *YOU* GET HERE???"

"Bro does NOT have a clue."

"That's his whole motto," Yellow points out, pushing up his visor with a finger. Blue mocks him for looking like the nerd emoji. "If you tell us the story, I'll dress up in a maid ou—"

"December 31, 2029," Red declares, a world-weary wistfulness encompassing his now serious demeanor. "And I get to come too."

"Whatever, sure. Yes or no, dude?"

"Fine. You want the lore??? I'll give you the lore! I'm gonna make this SUPER long, though."

The waitress lady lurks nearby, listening in with a shade of curiosity.

[...]

[A few months ago, before Red awoke, and a few days after the activation of the Thought Machine…]

There was this kid I met. He was kinda weird, but he had a good heart. Plus, *his* lore was actually super duper crazy.

Are you also gonna give us his perspective?

Duh.

How would you know that stuff if you weren't even there for it, though?

Uhh… that's a great question; I just put some stuff together from what I saw, but I'll give you a better answer *after*.

This guy… This story is 'boutta be so buns—

I'm gonna rape y—

Put the fries in the bag. TELL US THE LORE!

Fine, fine.

Semper, the planet of warriors.

Tender, winter light shines warmly, flooding all the sky with its color. The blue of the sky shifts slightly, a dash of it brighter than the rest of the ether. It quietly crashes into a sepulcher of angelic darkness, that which fools all else with its "light." Every powerline traces back to it, but nobody besides the Sovereign in charge of the planetary energy construct knows how it works.

Meanwhile, a precocious train-lover—a "transit fanner"—dwells dolefully by the gilded tracks, taking pride in his hardly attainable internship at Regal Station. Yes, the Regalia had personally chosen *him* as an intern at one of their stations. As a transit fanner, this was a dream come true.

Though kids his age might be running about a route that means to prove their martial prowess, he only found meaning in pleasing himself with these hobbies of his—mainly transport.

The intern glances around the fancy station. Nothing catches his eye after a few years of going here. He trills his lips and fumbles for his phone in his pocket. He's only on it for a few minutes 'till his boredom kills him.

The precocious boy searches around the station for anything of entertainment: a displaced tile, a wobbly bench, an annoying dog, a hyperactive cat, and whatever else fits his interests in the span of an hour.

This day in particular, he feels lonesome. Tired. Somewhat empty, really. Not even his job could fulfill him.

Exactly a year ago, the Tomb of Somber Selection had chosen its newest ~~victims~~ candidates for sacrifice. He's one of them.

That isn't the reason for his inexplicable sorrow, though. He can't put his finger on it. It's as if there's a connection he's been desperately searching for without knowing, waiting to be made.

He checks the time on the fancy clock at the center of the station, patiently awaiting his train's arrival.

"It's time."

[...]

And you were... where, exactly?

Just let me tell the story, damn!

A mire-like flooring mediates Blue's finite standing. He languidly lays there, trapped by the gravity of his mental situation.

["Dance with Fire, and you'll get burnt."]

["It'll hurt. It'll hurt."]

["[redacted]"]

'Come back.'

["Dance with Fire, and you'll get burnt."]

["It'll hurt. It'll hurt."]

["[redacted]"]

'Come back..!'

["Dance with Fire, and you'll get burnt."]

["It'll hurt. It'll hurt."]

["[redacted]"]

'*COME BACK!*'

Consciousness floods over Blue's worldview, sweeping his slumber aside. He struggles to his feet, each step like quicksand.

"Anybody..?"

But nobody comes.

"..Please?"

But nobody comes.

"...Aha, what am I doing?"

But Nobody comes.

"Woahoho. Who are you?"

"Who are you?"

Blue placidly peers at the immature figure in front of him. He seems more lost than anything. Kind of like him, but with an aura icy enough to shun anyone away, and a stench more rancid than spoiled milk. He laughs it off, looking down at the runt.

"I asked you first."

"I asked you second."

"I'll ask again."

"Four fingers to your crack, would you still—"

Blue is losing his patience, but lets his guard slip this once. The innocence of this kid can be trusted in his eyes. 'Plus, the crazy storm outside is getting pretty bad.'

"I… am BLUE," he theatrically announces.

"Uh-huh. I… like trains."

Blue cackles at such a loony response. He stops as soon as he reads the severity of the fanatic's expression.

"Aaand how'd you get in here?"

"I dunno," he chuckles, totally unserious.

"You should probably get out."

"Why?"

"..You wanna die?"

Fire flickers, and torches on the wall make themselves apparent. Paintings of rich-looking fellas adorn the bleak walls, their eyes following Blue everywhere. A dim, red dot can be seen in each of the eyes. Were they being recorded?

"What the..?"

"You're in the middle of a competition. I was chosen for uhh… something *'special,'* the child apologetically speaks. "You're gonna wanna get out. It might choose you."

"For what?"

"Sacrifice."

The racket ramming against the walls is now made much more apparent to Blue; for it was chanting. Worry fills his emptiness.

"Why would you—okay, okay… What *are* the conditions..?"

"Being super strong (I don't know 'bout that though)... Having pottery for brains (whatever that means)… And winning all of the trials (or something)."

"Sounds fun."

The dark hallway continues to light up, calling the two to step up. "This is kinda spooky."

"Yeah," he says, no readable expression styling him.

"Do you wanna do this?"

"Mhm."

"Why're you willing to go through with this..?"

"I dunno."

"Then, why do it at all?"

"I dunno."

"Then, you should probably leave..?"

"Nah, no thanks," he sighs, shutting his sight off for a second.

Blue rubs at his temple. He laughs at the finality of the boy's forwardness, yet nothing seems funny about this to him. Even he is bewildered by the fact that someone can be this stupid. Though, there's always someone better than someone at something.

The fanatic thinks deeply to himself, his eyes still closed.

"[redacted]" the boy lightly laughs.

Blue's eyes broaden. What did he just say?

"I get it—"

Yet, a part of him understands.

"—buuut, we should still leave. This don't feel *right*..."

The kid rolls his eyes dismissively at Blue's discretion. "I really don't care. You can go if you want, though." The kid continues to walk absent-mindedly down the corridor.

"Hey, kid!"

Blue's insides churn from the resounding storm outside. The terrible tumult presents itself increasingly madder with the moment.

"Stupid, stupid, stupid…" Blue repeats to himself, following the child further into the catacombs.

The desolation of the sorrowful setting surrounding them somewhat breaks off at unseen areas of the walls' linings. They fully fail to escape Blue's focused eyes. 'Molten rock, obsidian, flint, and… *steel..?*'

Sprouting from the rocky terrain comes forth beady-eyed, beastly golems of immeasurable size and imposing stature.

"You might wanna leave… We're at the third challenge already."

The golem winds up, swinging outwardly with its left arm. The kid easily evades the oncoming blow, hopping onto its arm and shattering it at the joint with a kick.

The rest of the army goes down with barely a fight. The stone shatters into dust, and their ink runs dry.

Blue looks on with amazement. His eyes follow each movement of the kid, not with any particular fixation. If anything, it's the kid's coolness about the entire thing. The rest of his body seems so distant from the rest of his body.

"Everyone else that signed up already died," he says, seeing Blue ogling at him.

"I'm still here."

"You never signed up for this…"

The zealous kid huffs a sizable puff, unrelenting in his death march. Blue belatedly tracks his tail-end. In the meanwhile, golems surprise Blue left and right, and the fanatic barely makes an effort to subdue them.

The boy glances down at his hands for a moment. No damage can be deduced, though he almost thought otherwise for a moment. He coughs, redirecting his attention to his new and unlikely friend.

"Can you not use your Resin? Is your Milieu weak..?"

"Eh?"

"Your *powers*? No way you *don't* know what those are…"

"Ohh… umm…"

"..You *really* shouldn't have come here, dude."

"Neither should you've, bud."

They roll their eyes at each other as they hop through unstable platforms of sedimentary rocks, lava pitfalls hungrily bubbling from below. Swinging axes barely manage to scrape

Blue as he dashes closely behind the kid. The kid looks like paper swimming in the wind from Blue's viewpoint.

"You're doing all this just to kill yourself?!"

The kid gawks at Blue, like the answer was obvious. "Nah, Semper needs the angel alive for energy, sooo… the strongest out of the selection fed to it every year."

"*The angel???*"

"Duh."

An excerpt from "The Director's" monograph, Machinations of the Mysterious Mind.

Angels. The enforcers of the laws that Sovereigns set out for their people.

Sovereigns each control limitless numbers of them, therefore scattering them across every planet to insert their influence everywhere.

The less angels a Sovereign generates, the greater their own power becomes. This is only natural, as the angels are extractions of their total essence.

"Uh-*huh*… And no way *you're* the strongest."

"I *guess* I am."

Episode 3 — Drowning

Despite the transit fanner's laziness with the typical culture of Semper, he still manages to be the strongest. By some miracle, he was born with an incredible Milieu—to see「Boundaries」—and an equally impressive Resin—an unknown potential—to pair. None of his peers could come close in terms of power to him.

Never did he actually put his power into efficient practice, however. Upon discovering it, he came up with a singular expression of that power, and kept it that way.

"Talent only gets you so far without effort," he'd constantly hear from his peers. He didn't care much, though. They were the unfortunate ones that couldn't compare to him. Not a moment should be wasted dwelling on others' views on him; at least that's what he told himself. Following himself up on that point would be a different story.

"It's no fun, though."

"Charging through everything seems pretty fun, though."

"Yeah, but I'd deadass rather slowly enjoy the stuff I think's cool," the transit fanner blabs, bleeding with vulnerability. He's perplexed as to why he feels comfortable sharing this information with this random guy.

"Hm. Stuff like that?"

The fourth trial, with an almost dreamlike visage, is an incredible outdoor area leading out from the catacombs.

"Beau—"

"—tiful."

Their eyes settle on the enchanting expanse settling softly upon their wistful gazes. Were they really still participating in the selection?

The veranda of the venue is vivacious with a jungle of variable life-forms. The precocious boy blinks belatedly, stupefied by the sight. Blue, although impressed, is more so stricken by an odd feeling of nostalgia.

Each blade of grass is light-blue in hue, as well as the leaves falling gracefully from the hundreds of hand-shaped trees planted about the reserve. Pink water reflects the world in a pastel view of unimagined likeness, which Blue peers into with a stupid smile on his face.

The presence of phoenixes, ogres, gnomes, and other mythical creatures grace this sacred space. The fair fairies convulse and cry upon contact with the transit fanner's stench.

Colors of any kind can be found at any corner or cranny of the jungle, which ended into an amicable cove by the seaside shore. At the furthest of boundaries, past the sea and into the sky, however, was a glass barrier. Blue pretends not to notice it. Gabrius is just short of being able to see it.

Blue strolls through it all in childlike amusement. "Goofy ahh cloud," he comments, pointing at a gun-shaped cumulus cloud. The shimmer of the setting sun peeking over the pastel horizon strikes his eyes quickly proceeding his remark, prompting his aimless laughter.

The kid sighs in amazement. He wishes he could've lived his entire life in this sort of "bliss."

"I feel like I'm dreaming."

"Why?"

The boy smiles softly, a hint of vulnerability painting his face. "I dunno. I just… have everything I want."

"Would you ever think of… making something cool, outta all of.. *this*?"

"*Mmm, maybe a double-decker couch out of the trees,*" he giggles.

"No, not like that—Why a *double-decker* couch..?"

Blue doesn't have an exact answer. To be frank, he's pretty clueless half of the time, from what Gabrius can inspect. The idea, at least, is still there.

"For me and the bois, *duh*."

"You have friends?"

Blue grumbles, clicking his tongue and snorting roughly at the kid's insensitive comment. He thinks to bring the subject of discussion away from such humiliation on his end.

"Are you ever gonna tell me your name?"

"...Uhh—"

Should he really be telling a stranger his name? It was too easy of an answer. 'But it's as if I've known him my entire life.'

"I'm gonna annoy you 'till you say it, bud—"

"Gabrius," he impatiently spits out.

Blue is rather amazed by his assertion, roaring with laughter. He wouldn't have expected any form of progress between the two of them in a million years.

"..So, *Gabrius*, do you feel like getting out of this alive?"

"Yeah," Gabrius reluctantly reveals. "I still gotta go do what I said I'd do, though..."

"Nah, you don't."

Gabrius, for the umpteenth time, rolls his eyes at Blue. He wants to say something, but that something is too unclear to show or tell.

"It's more complicated than that."

"..."

The duo delves deeper into the madness of the trial chambers, Gabrius annihilating anything that dared so much as to breathe. Their intended route is indicated by an asphalt road, lined with rustic, wooden lantern posts.

Their walk is calming, aside from the occasional monster obstructing their path. Gabrius has time to ponder, and Blue is too occupied with the scenery.

Gabrius's mind slowly shifts whilst they walk their path together. He shouldn't care about anyone; so, why is he—this random robot-looking guy—so different?

'*Ah*, please don't let me lose this,' Gabrius prays pitifully. A feeling he can't decide on through his indifference, that utterly baffles him. Albeit, it's terribly wonderful to him, in a way.

Though the jungle is beguiling, there is something off about his insouciance. For once since that time long lost, Gabrius knows his feelings are genuine—not for naught. The experiences he's having mean something now.

'Why?'

It was too easy of an answer; and yet, there were no words in his mind for him to make any connection to one. Just these weird, messy colors.

Hours pass, and, in due time, the mess of monsters left a tale-telling trail behind the two adventurers. Impressive incandescence immolates their bodies as their kills accumulate alongside the rapidly approaching end of their adventure.

"Aren't we awesome?"

"*We*… I guess so. Semper's full of a bunch of tryhards, though."

In other worlds, they could be called world-class hunters. In Semper, however, they are merely small fry; especially in the capital city, Ferro City.

"We're almost done with the fourth trial…"

"What's next, then—"

Blue instinctively stretches to the side, wherein his entire left side is feeling quite stiff. Faster than a flash of lightning, a monolithic, scaled wing slices at where his neck was moments before. The entire landscape behind him is cleaved into a clear bisection.

"*BEHIND ME!*"

"HOLY SHIT—"

Blue's panic is prematurely perforated as another attack homes in. Gabrius blocks it with his right arm, and, for the first time, seems fazed by an attack.

Gabrius draws his wield from its scabbard. He coolly holds it at an arm's length from his face, pointing the tip towards the disastrous dragon perched atop an enormous tree—somewhat larger than it—before them.

"It's so over, bro…"

"Wouldn't be if you showed off a little."

The dragon snorts its fiery breath at them, disappearing the instant Gabrius's eyes unfocus from it.

"ON YOUR LEFT—"

"OH MY GO—"

The dragon's teeth clang in contact with Gabrius's shining sword. It attempts to devour them whole in one bite, but its jaw is being held wide open by the sword.

Gabrius reaffirms his stance, slicing at the beast's throat. It lands, minimal damage inflicted.

"We're so cooked…"

"Shut up and give me a *chance*..!"

Enraged, the draconian breathes its flames at point-blank range at the invaders. Gabrius vehemently spins his blade at a mind-numbing speed, expertly deflecting the flames.

Then, the icy aura cloaking Gabrius melts into a raging river. His blade glows grandly and quivers slightly, glossing over the air as he speaks one word:

"***Rend***."

An intense wind from his sword generates, which matches the "storm" outside. Next thing Blue knows, a fading afterimage of Gabrius's wield lacerates the mythical dragon. His strength perfectly fits the invisible speed as well, draconian blood splattering everywhere—'And I drank it.'

It instantly regenerates, but a scarlet scar is left on its massive chest.

"We're supposed to… kill that..?"

"C'mon, it'll be fun."

Blue scoffs, dusting his shoulders. He still doesn't know what the hell an Resin or an Išdum is, but he's sure he can manage something. In fact, something is resonating remotely in the far reaches of his mind—memories that didn't belong to him.

"Ugh… Fine."

A full fist forms at Blue's right.

"I feel like I need to be somewhere anyways."

And, by their combined efforts, they effortlessly…

"***HIYAHHH,***" Blue cries out, a tad racially motivated.

..Defeat?

"***Rend.***"

Episode 4 — Against the Riptide

Yes, defeat the nigh-insurmountable opposition. Blue can barely breathe afterwards. They chatter languidly about the toils of their epic battle.

Gabrius sheaths his sword. "*Holy*, that was crazy…"

"*Holy*, I don't even *know* how I did most of that..."

"You'd be crazy good at boxing here if you trained."

"*Ahh*, I dunno about that."

"Seriously, you'd go crazy. Mediator material, for real."

'The fuck's a Mediator..?'

An excerpt from "The Director's" monograph, Machinations of the Mysterious Mind.

Among the official rankings of the Regalia are the Mediators. The four major milestones are denoted as follows:

Visionaries » Mediators » Suzerains » Sovereigns

Sovereigns stand at the height of power, wherein the ideals their existences are based off of are the most foundational aspects of reality. For example, the Sovereigns represent strong principles, such as life, death, space, time, order, etc. (add stuff here later E10 Joe)

Some legends say that if your principle is strong enough, your soul will shine like a star in the night sky—placed in the hall of fame for all time.

Several, yet very few accounts of such a phenomenon taking place are known.

Meanwhile, Mediators are somewhere in the middle.

Gabrius chuckles and shakes his head, dismissing Blue's ignorance as a joke. Blue only sighs, chuckling somewhat.

"What was that crazy move you used?"

"Uhh… Something about seeing Boundaries. I just focus all my energy and—*boom*—slice into them."

Blue and Gabrius carefully climb up the many, long flights of stairs at the end of the pathway as they chat. It reaches into the false sky, going past the glassy ceiling and entering the highest height.

'Looks like one big-ass temple…'

Their entrance into the sad sanctuary is heard by the dormant divinity. Their voices fill the emptiness of the silent, sun-dried tiles of the reverent realm.

An endless maze of royal-purple and porcelain-white rooms wraps around their heads, unintentionally acting as their last impediment before "salvation." Patterns repeating, light and darkness unchanging. It cuts into any passerby's mind and unravels their entire being—a spool of yarn unfurling, like a spiral spiraling into madness. Their position changes with movement, but nothing else is there to prove such. 'And, to make matters worse, the rooms are shifting.'

"Can't we just break through these walls?"

"Nah, we're dead if we do."

"Aw man…" he pouts.

An odd feeling proceeds to grow in Blue's bosom the further their persistent travels lead them through the ruins.

"Say, doesn't it kinda feel… weird to you..?"

"What?"

"I mean, living like this..?"

"..."

"You're pretty much being set up for death, kid."

"Nah."

"Huh?"

A long reel of restitution creeps in through their introspection. A somber silence, it is. It isn't a pause for thought, though.

Walls shift. Writing forms on them. Words pop into Blue's head. 'Vaulted Vernacular..?'

Gabrius wearily weaves his head around. With each glance, the walls vibrate to form vague images—images of his regretful past.

Gabrius nods, as if he had made a firm decision in his mind.

"Just my way of going back to someone I miss lots," he lightly laughs.

"Uh-huh..?"

"But… I (really regret that I) chose all this for myself."

"Really?"

"I (sometimes) think dying is my best bet, here."

Blue turns to Gabrius, observing his small face. It's filled with pain—undiagnosed.

"(I just wanna go home)."

"You're being real quiet about this… You can always talk—"

The maze shifts again, a trap revealing itself. Arrows are pointing at Blue's neck. Gabrius is unperturbed, as if the maze is bending to his will.

"(Don't) stop worrying about me. I (don't) wanna do this."

Gabrius, as if unfazed by Blue's sudden predicament, dashes away.

"You gotta.. tell me *something*..!"

Before Gabrius can leave, Blue's sorrowful gaze gives way to an eidetic rush of unsealed evidence for Gabrius's stubbornness.

〖*Ψθμ αγε αβιε τθ μσε τλε σκιιι "Γεβιεστιθη."*〗

A splash of color replaces Gabrius's shadow, casting over the floor and walls. Images of a sorry sinner adorn his silhouette.

"What the…"

Blue can't help but feel empathy for the child—he who was so spontaneously brought into this world, only to experience… ***that***. To his dismay, Blue has stumbled upon a regretful connection between him and Gabrius.

[…]

["Dance with Fire, and you'll get burnt."]

["It'll hurt. It'll hurt."]

["I have to leave…"]

And ghosts from a distant memory continue to haunt his worldview.

Memories of the past. Clouds of yesterday.

A world he now can't have. Now with no one to love.

They're lingering. Is this life worth living?

["*Dance with Fire, and you'll get burnt.*"]

["*It'll hurt. It'll hurt.*"]

["I don't care if it'll hurt."]

'Shut up.'

["***Dance with Fire, and you'll get burnt.***"]

["***It'll hurt. It'll hurt.***"]

["**I don't care if it'll hurt..!**"]

Remembrance floods over Blue's worldview, sweeping his security aside. He struggles for his grip on reality, each step like hot coals—like he's chained to the ocean floor.

That laughter—painful—pulls him from his tree. His vantage point. His high ground. He joined in it—a sin he committed to. He can't ignore it anymore.

He closes his eyes for a moment. He can see what Gabrius sees. His frustration bubbles; then pops.

"SHUT THE FUCK UP!"

He'll use it—his sins.

Blue flows forward like a sterling stream. The crowds of Semperian citizens and high priests are stunned, monitoring from hidden cameras implanted around the maze which are displaying on the ginormous screens outside.

"Get him out!"

"He'll ruin the ceremony!"

Blue shatters each wall blocking his path, a grievous omen of imminent death sprinting for him at his rear. Black goo chases him, consuming his shadow. He feels his heart shake the more recklessly he tears through these hallowed halls.

His wobbling body slowly adjusts to the supersonic speed he's traveling with. Unsealed vitality shoots him a second chance at survival.

He knows how low his chances are at winning here; and yet, that chance is worth everything. He needs to do this. 'I just have to. I'm sinking, but he's… drowning!'

He desperately vies for any kind of plan that can save him here. Anything. Preferably something destructive. Then, eureka! 'That could work.'

Blue hones his strength into a single arm, and carefully recalls Gabrius's exact movements. He pours most of his focus into his sight, straining his eyes. He's trying to see them.

The Boundaries. He couldn't exactly see a Boundary, but he could use something else to define them: deflection.

「Laughter」.

"***Rend***."

Blue bemusedly cuts a pathway towards Gabrius, who's bowing (blowing) before the so-called "angel." It's a stony effigy of what one might describe as an ophanim, but its stationary state dissuades Blue from sensing any true danger from it.

"—And into your hands, I commend my spirit…"

"Don't be stupid!"

Blue grabs the idle Gabrius by the cheeks (heh heh) and throws him across the room, away from the idol.

"*Urgh*!"

Gabrius squints his eyes at Blue once the dust settles. A clamorous clang causes Gabrius to wince slightly. Seas of swords—penalties from brute forcing onwards—are pointed at Blue, though are barriered by a watery dissolution of gravity. 'An improvised application of Boundaries..?'

"Get out of here!"

Blue flails his arms desperately, one at Gabrius and one at the angel. He outpours some of his essence to Gabrius and lobs a glob of destructive energy at the effigy.

The angel, returning from its dormancy immediately, phases in and out of existence. A feather floats down from above. Blue slowly turns his face upward, only to see topaz luster leering at him with scorching scorn from the footing of the brick-beamed roof support.

"***Rend.***"

Again, the ophanim (oompa-loompa) evades the slice, now appearing inside Blue's right eye.

"***Re—***"

A beam of gamma pierces straight through Blue's head, from the inside-out.

Gabrius glares indignantly. Sure, he's angry with Blue, but he "*saved*" him. 'What does he know..? Does he *know*..? Maybe…'

Blue screams in agony as the ophanim (oompa-loompa) unravels his mind.

Gabrius rushes ruggedly like a rabid dog, scrambling for Blue. 'He's crazy… but—'

"***Rend.***"

A rush of Rend's wind phases through Blue's head, separating him from the ophanim.

'—he's making some kinda sense right now.'

Gabrius reaches out for Blue's hand, prompting Blue to instinctively reach back out at Gabrius. The reverberation from their joining of hands—two worlds colliding—sends out a multitude of tumultuous tremors. The entire galaxy trembles with the power from their handshake.

The ground beneath Blue and Gabrius splits apart and floats around them. Bits of various minerals rapidly orbit around them as if they were Saturn.

Waves of energy burst from their position. They're superimposed with an electric-blue ecstasy. They zoom in and out of their spaces like a merry-go-round of life. Like a tide's rise and fall. Like the moon's waxing and waning. Like a big blue scattered with green, lost in a black desert.

The rare rocks reflect Blue's shine, stealing the stars from the night sky. They all gather at the center of the orbit, floating between the two. Their atoms gather too, and Gabrius's body flows with「Laughter」.

The languid laughter alleviates the hearts of many. Regardless of the trial-teeming tensions, epic elation ensues. It fills the endless expanse of emptiness. It fills the hearts of many. It feels for the in-between emptiness

and knits a knot.

〖*Clεςκρθiητ γεαςλεδ! Γεβθθτ ςθmριετε! Ψθμ αγε αβιε τθ με τλε sκiω "Γεfιεςτiθη." Cθηταςτ mαδε. Cθmmεηςiηg fiγst ργθτθςθι, "Ωεmθγψ."*〗

Episode 5 — Learner's Limbo

"*AAAA

The stiff shadows barring them from reality warp wildly and reshape into a waterfall, beginning from where the droplet stopped. The waterfall washes over their eyes, vision itself becoming a blind spot.

The moment the cascade ceases, a train station encases them. A barrage of sound surrounds the two. Flashing lights. Click-clack of the tracks. Gabrius clutches his heart. He swears he can hear it beat.

'A… train station?'

'Oh nah…'

Gabrius recognizes this place—this memory. He tries to turn from the shore to run, but his body is stuck in place.

Their bodies act autonomously as they board the transport. The moment they're seated, the train bolts forward. Peeking outside, they see a thick fog tucking the world outside the windows into an ominous blanket.

Gabrius's eyes are bloodshot.

Blue's blood boils for no apparent reason.

From the intense silence, they can hear each other's thoughts.

'Fuck.'

'You alright?'

'Naw… GET ME OUT OF HERE!'

The midnight moon looms over all. Its watchful eye petrifies Gabrius. Though, what scares him more is Blue's.

Sweat trickles down his forehead, traveling down to his chin. It plops onto his thigh from on high. His arms fight for control so that he may rip his own throat out, but the mighty memory paralyzes him far too painfully.

'Are we cooked?'

'Nah, just me…'

Blue stifles another one of his odious giggles, having some respect for Gabrius's manic moment.

'Where are we?'

'Aboard the Constellation Complex. Specifically, the Incola Lucia constellation family. Specifically, the Auctus constellation. Specifically in the Iridium division. Specifically in the Argent Luisant district. Specifically, the Lotus Lake—'

'OKAY, SHUT UP.'

An excerpt from "Mourning Morningstar's" monograph, Navigation Nightmare.

When it comes to crossing the cosmos, the main form of transportation sought by the masses is the Regalia's transit, otherwise known as the Constellation Complex. Each "constellation" within the Constellation Complex is given its own visual and nominative distinction. Afterwards, one is assigned to each multiverse.

Of course, constellations have their own inner workings; therein, they branch off into different lines across universes, galaxies, solar systems, planets, etc. 'Till the present moment, no single Sovereign can fully navigate the conundrum that is the modern Constellation Complex besides Princesa "Mourning Morningstar" (I am tooting my own horn, haha).

Each constellations' trains are known as constellation connectors, and travel at impossible speeds. It's documented that they're capable of ignoring any obstacles, even escaping black holes on several occasions.

From asterism—the official term for their stations—to asterism they travel, and throughout the Somnium they go. Trillions of connectors exist in a single constellation, and the convolution of the routes is as abundant as the routes themselves.

Of course, there are certain limitations to the abundance of the Constellation Complex. Special railroad lines are required to go the distance between ensembles (groups of multiverses), as well as special passes to board them.

As Gabrius yaps about the staggering scope of the Constellation Complex, Blue zones out and glances around the carriage. He's still listening with half an ear, just to be nice.

Eventually, the fog fades out of view, leaving only a thin partition of glass between the galaxy and a childlike gaze. Blue's eyes meet with the astral expanse of everything. He's astonished.

'*Woah..*!'

'...'

They both wish so desperately to touch those stars, albeit only one of them is willing to break the rules in exchange for happiness. Blue focuses all of his willpower into extending his quivering extremity toward the invisible wall. It briefly taps the freezing glass, feeling for the sublime sensation of what lies beyond.

As he reluctantly retracts his arm in a snail-like motion, he feels much more freedom in his movements. He punches the air, and then the empty seat on his left. He slowly realizes that this single action has allowed him to move freely within the recollection. He obnoxiously stretches his muscles, loudly cracking his hips and hands while looking dead at Gabrius on his right.

'How'd you—'

'I'm not actually a part of this memory, am I? I can just do my own thing if I'm not.'

'Bruh...'

'What's this memory, anyways?'

'This is… the night I—'

'Left home? I knew it!'

'You… knew?'

'I'm pretty sure I saw some of your life.'

Gabrius recalls a strange twinge in his head that he felt, back in the temple.

[…]

"You gotta tell me *something*..!"

Before Gabrius can leave, Blue's sorrowful gaze gives way to an eidetic rush of unsealed evidence for Gabrius's stubbornness.

〖*Ψθμ αγε αβιε τθ μσε τλε σκιω "Γεβιεστιθη."*〗

[…]

'You went from there, to this other place (which we're going to right now), and then Semper..! I forgot after what tho—'

'That was you, you bitch!'

'Obviously it was me, dumbass!'

'And… that means you opened this up, too!'

Blue wasn't expecting that. 'Oh… oops.'

The blue man contritely whistles, not looking anywhere near Gabrius nor his direction.

'Then, do you know about..?'

'Well, all I saw was your childhood.'

A terrible childhood, at that. One filled with turmoil and complication, it was one riddled with regret from the moment of his conception. A shattered home. A crime-carved setting. The seclusion from everyone else was an added bonus.

'You left it all behind, this same night.'

'…Why'd you become so smart all the sudden?'

'Uhh… I dunno,' he shrugs, musing. 'You matter, that's why.'

Gabrius cracks an unsuspecting smile, only visible through his eyes. His mouth is wide frown, still. The train comes to a halt at its next stop, and Gabrius's body rises. Blue jovially walks next to him, not a care in the world.

'Oh nah.'

'Woah, what's this place..?'

'…Nunc.'

An excerpt from "Mourning Morningstar's" monograph, Navigation Nightmare.

Nunc, the planet of peace: a popular tourist spot for those visiting the Iridium universe, and the complete opposite of Semper.

Recognized for its myriad innovation towards an eternal rest of sorts, it's most famously known for its emotion-evoking technology. Due to the monochrome of the Somnium, many started seeking stimulation of any kind. Therefore, it was, and still is the place the people turn to for an escapade to invite themselves into.

To begin the process, the user is inserted into an interface.

Gabrius and Blue cautiously tread their way through Vorrà City. The streets are clean, yet clandestine. Out-of-place simpers steer their way towards theirs, angled perfectly to be in the two's shared view. The bustling crowds are unusually cordial, barely bumping into them. The air itself reeks of a sweetness de rigeur.

The destination? It's clear to Gabrius's innately keen eyes. It was visible from the moment they laid foot on this planet.

One awkward walk later, they arrive at an eastern, medieval monument—like a mix between a castle and a church. Its tree-like columns and gothic arches travel endlessly above, the

tippity top untouched by human sight. Within it is, of course, corrupted by abnormal hospitality.

The happy medium and its method of display are intuitively selected by the「Sol」of the user itself. The technology's system goes into effect the moment one's eyes lay upon the edifice of Nunc, Il Rifugio. From then on, the user is enclosed into their very own set of memories.

The program can be ended at any time if the keyword is spoken, that being the name of the user's Sol.

'Is this… your house?'

Blue laughs into the fancy facade. The details of everything can't be made out—it's a pure blur. Only Gabrius can truly see and equally describe everything, for it is infinitely personal to him and him alone; it is this much that Il Rifugio considers when visibility of certain secrets is involved.

'…'

The transit fanner's body automatically bolts out of the shattered home, his current self relieved they were thinking the same thing. It's a futile effort, though. Blue whispers in astonishment, still by his side.

'And this is your home?'

And so it is, or at least was.

A violently crowded town filled with endearing, single and two-story houses imbued with vibrancy unmatched lights up the landscape. The quaint architecture is niche and easy on the eyes, its skin bearing ornate tilework and its bones bending into graceful arches. It draws them in, fully roping their attention inward. It has replaced the somber streets of Nunc, already having detected Gabrius's Sol.

'...'

'Gabrius?'

'...'

"Gabrius."

"..."

Blue shakes his head, gazing at his woeful companion. He takes him by the hand, leading him elsewhere. To his dismay, Gabrius can feel the control coming back to him. His mouth moves with his mind, his utterances barely taking to their heels. "Hey, you're not supposed to—"

"It's whatever. We need to be somewhere else right now," Blue says aloud, as if mocking the gods without a care for the consequences of his action any longer.

Through the scary streets of the unnamed hometown they walk, as an unnerving essence tracks their tail end. It's all a farce, but enough to put Gabrius under the weather.

"Gabe?"

"I think I'm gonna be sick…"

[…]

"Gross…" Red comments.

"Yeah, I don't think I wanna hear about that part," Yellow says, shaking his head.

"Should I skip that, then?"

"Please do," the waitress lady begs.

The three crusaders collectively stare at her, a bit baffled by her presence in this quiet moment they're all sharing.

"What, I can't be nosey?"

"Fair enough. Continue."

[…]

The two rest by a river, one crouched over it. Blue chuckles lightly, patting Gabrius's back.

"We'll be fine. We just need to find a way out."

"I'd rather die, no offense…"

"Bro, we can do this. 'Lock in,' or whatever you were saying earlier.

Onwards they tread.

Onwards is the word that they mindlessly repeat to themselves.

Onwards is their pursuit of tomorrow, albeit one of them is heavily wavering in his tracks.

Onwards is the setting of their sights, seeing only the happiness that awaits them; no matter if it may doom them.

Onwards is the march of boots, where far too many are ready to die on the horizon.

Onwards.

Hours pass by before they see anything different. It's only a matter of time before each and every difference becomes a novel addition to the sum of sameness.

"I think we've been going in circles..?"

"My memory sucks ass, that's why."

"Maybe we should think of something else…"

"I don't really mind. I've been staring at *immense* power every loop."

"Who?"

Gabrius nods his head to the left. Blue spots her immediately, quickly discerning what "immense power" meant.

"Woah."

"*Right?*"

"Right."

Blue snaps out of it after a moment, staring Gabrius down. "You're one helluva pervert…"

"Whatever, I'm just tryna make this enjoyable."

"Whatever, man."

They continue their roundabout journey, the lady of their interest showing up on cue every repeat of the memory. Her placement in this memory is bizarre to the two, however. The only piece of evidence to prove them right was her esoteric style of clothing, such being different from the others'. Everyone else is adorned by artificial fabric, whereas she alone possesses woolen wearables.

"Her face is really pretty…"

"Her ass is—"

『Lišānu activation . . . Succeeded!』

"—[redacted]!"

『Lišānu, "Parodize," has been activated. Comfortable censorship applied.』

"And her [redacted] are [redacted]! I wish I could [redacted] the [redacted] out of those [redacted]."

Blue's face remains stagnant. The vulgarity passes through one ear and out the other. Sure, he might be thinking the same, but he has enough shame to know better.

'Wait… What if… I use this to get us outta here?'

Blue stops in his tracks, inspecting Gabrius. Gabrius sweats profusely, confused by the lack of distance between them.

"Huh?"

"Hold on."

『*Ψθμ αγε αβιε τθ μσε τλε σκiu "Cθησρεςτμs."*』

'Woah, what the yo?'

A small informational window pops up before Blue's bewildered eyes. It details every basic snippet of information he must know about his trusty friend, Gabrius, here.

『Gabrius: The Liberated Loneliness, and the nascent pathway for "Laughter" to be paved. Rumor has it that he is one of the sketches for the Catastrophic Colors, and numerous efforts for him to be erased/killed have been made. [redacted] take his spot as Lib—』

Censorship non-administered by him rings in his ears. Vertigo vexes his view of the world, greatly disorienting him. He falls on the floor, rolling around from the pain, as if trying to put out a fire on his back. Gabrius chortles, seeing the fire on his pants.

"Damn! Was that the… Harrowed Harmony?"

"What the yell is that..?"

"Uhh… like… they say it shows up as a fire on your pants when you learn something you're not supposed to. I dunno what it is, though."

Blue slowly stands, puzzled by the multitude of events that just took place. He tries to recollect, but can only remember a fraction of Gabrius's already-short synopsis.

"Do you remember how you got outta here? *Anything*… at all?"

"…Nah. I just remember a weird-sounding word whistling in my ear, and then… *BOOM*!"

«*BOO*!» screams an interceding voice in Gabrius's ear.

Gabrius jumps, taking a breather as he turns around and at his aggressor. To his surprise, it's the girl they've both been eyeing this entire time.

«Did I scare you?» she smiles.

Episode 6 — Starlight's Shoreline

Blue's skin tingles with hidden horror, beyond any explanation he can provide. Gabrius expects another comedic jab to come from him. Nothing returns, however. He's scared shitless, stiff as a stump.

The lovely lady bows, her face glowing. Her divine vocals gain precedence over the entire dreamscape without a fleeting moment spent. They're like a train whistle to Gabrius's ears.

«Welcome to Il Rifugio! I'm Calliope, your tour guide to the inside of our interpersonal facility. Your name's Gabrius, isn't it?»

Gabrius nods, embarrassed.

«Great! We scanned your identity the moment you walked in, of course. Just had to confirm.»

Calliope moves her eyes in Blue's direction. «And you're…»

Blue nervously laughs. 'Why's she looking straight past me?'

«Hmm… None of our algorithms are properly registering your identity. Nonetheless, welcome to Nunc's home for all!»

Gabrius carefully gazes at Blue, telepathically steering his friend's mind away from the ether. 'Bro, lock in.'

"Oh, thanks," he distantly mouths.

"Can we leave yet?" Gabrius unhesitantly requests.

«Well, of course..! You just need to speak your Sol aloud!»

Gabrius's face becomes a grim expression of defeat.

"What's a Sol?"

«It's like… your unique essence, pretty much,» she summarizes. «It gives you your own powers, pretty much, and can be attributed to all your memories. It's what we use to turn on and off Il Rifugio's function for individuals.»

'Woah… a memory inside a memory.'

'This is so trippy.'

«Well, what's your Sol?»

"I never… learned. I just know what it does… kinda."

Calliope blinks rapidly, baffled. «Oh, that's unfortunate! You really shouldn't be here, then, huh? Don't worry, I'll sort this out.»

The air in their lungs leaves them for a moment, and their lives flash before their very eyes. Their heads swivel like spinning chairs, and colors conquer the repeating patterns of

their unraveling wits. Suddenly, they're both on the cold, moist concrete, closely clutching their chests.

«Sorry!» she apologizes, squatting down at Gabrius. «That must've hurt, removing you from what was essentially your mind.»

She, then, regards Blue, perplexed by how he's affected by the pain as well. She keeps this concern to herself, though.

'I think we went too far with our shenanigans…'

'This definitely isn't a part of my memories…'

The two goofballs both wearily lift their heads up, studying the soft serenity of the real Vorrà City. Forgetting their pain, they upright themselves to get a better view. It's a magnitude grander than the dreamscape itself—the magnum opus of Nunc.

«Gorgeous, isn't it? An entire city built on and powered by water. *That…* is Vorrà City!»

The history befalling them is too much to be captured by their eyes alone. Canals, bridges, and ancient architecture rally together to piece together an artistic majesty. In a way, Gabrius feels he's back at home, only replacing the violent atmosphere with a romantic one.

Bright buildings reach for the stars as did the mirage of Gabrius's house. A lazy lagoon sits below it all, its barely flowing water glowing with a mystifying substance. It all enchants the goofballs, but scares them all the same.

«Best not to get too close to the water, of course,» she comments, although sounding as if she was fighting through a lump in her throat.

'I don't like this…'

'Me neither,' Gabrius glares. 'You think you can bring us back?'

'I've been trying, but… I-I can't.'

⟦*Ψθμ αγε μηαβιε τθ μσε τλε σκιω "Γεβιεστιθη."*⟧

'I swear, bro, if we're stuck here—'

«What's up?» she butts in, poking her head between the two.

"Nothing."

"Enjoying the view!"

She squints, twirls around, and vanishes into a nearby alleyway. «If you need me, I'm only a call away! *Ahem*, and without further ado… I, and everyone of Vecchi Amici, hope you both enjoy your time here!»

Wind washes her away, and waywardly whisks the pair elsewhere. With the wind washes quiet water over their beings, bringing a disturbance to their psyches.

When the water washes over them, the same creepy smiles from before fall on their shoulders, not having changed since their arrival.

["[redacted]"]

["[redacted]"]

Memories glitch, and finite boundaries reiterate. Nausea steals whatever cents they have for change, keeping them in a pricey check.

["[redacted]"]

["[redacted]"]

Smiles recede. They furtively crawl back into tenebras incognable, like rats into their sewers.

"Maybe we should just… explore."

"Eh? Sure, I guess."

『The course of fate has been temporarily altered. Rerouting…』

Nighttime ignites the avenues of Nunc with a dim daylight. Quiet rain arrives, arguing with the unreachable ground. Levitating feet connect with that ground, though only two pairs refuse to float.

In moments, they manage to slip away from each other, but only for those moments.

Gabrius strolls along the least-populated route of his interest, too scatterbrained to notice Blue's absence. Several things on the ground catch his eye, though he only pockets a few of them. His curious stroll leads him over an extensive, stony arch bridge, feeling over a mile long to Gabrius.

The peculiar boy freely enjoys the sound-free space, relishing the alone time he's reaping. Normally, something, or someone, would be interrupting this. As an added bonus, the sight to see is wide and welcoming. Normally, something, or someone, would be commenting on this.

Puzzled by the lack of comedic genius in his presence, he side eyes his 3 o'clock. He scratches his scalp, only to look forward at a familiar bonehead stupidly waving at him.

"Hey, dude! Look at these!" Blue yells, holding up a fresh pair of shades and riding on a scooter to match. "I found these behind a big ass restaurant!"

Yet, a smile equally as stupid adorns Gabrius's face. "Put them on!"

Blue slides his neat, new pair of shades on, gleeful at his completed look.

"You look a lot less… goofy."

"Covering my eyes makes me look lots cooler, right?"

"Yeah..! And why'd you take the scooter?"

"I dunno, I just thought it looked fun," Blue gleefully guffaws, jumping off his scooter and setting it down.

Gabrius nods understandingly, not contesting him in any way. Blue crosses the bridge, making his way to his newfound friend. He playfully rubs his thick head of hair, pointing ahead.

"Let's just go this way. The way I went just has a bunch of restaurants."

Gabrius gallantly grabs his blue-hued hand and sportively throws it away. "I'm so hungry, though…"

"We can get some food soon. I should probably register for some kinda ID before I get arrested or something."

"Bruh, fine."

Asking the kind locals for directions gets them their directions in a manner of minutes. Dragging their feet to the nearest agency available, they discover a line far too long to be waited on.

They grumpily groan, sauntering from their glassy viewpoint. Gabrius considers anything else they can do, rummaging through his pants. Then, he comes across an interesting relic.

"…Can we just have some fun instead?" he suggests, pulling a pair of carnival tickets out of his pocket.

[Hours later, at the carnival…]

Blue and Gabrius squeeze every ounce of energy possible from their bodies to maximize their chaotic fun.

Water-gunning every kid we saw was so peak, bro. I remember stealing the guns from the Water Gun Fun booth, and then we just blasted all those kids.

No attraction is safe from their undoing, as they make sure to hit every mark available before they'd eventually be chased out.

Bumper cars…

Blue confidently crashes into Gabrius, sending the latter flying. The blue fool cackles like a maniac, wheezing even when the brutish boy comes recoiling back into him. They bounce about like pinballs, the rest of the carnival goers acting as their playfield.

Roller coasters…

They simultaneously stand in their seats during the drop, frightfully-excited tears blurring their eyes. Wild winds whip at their bobbly heads, widening their already big mouths and stretching their always-flared nostrils. Puking in every trash can afterwards becomes an obvious necessity.

Carousels…

Gabrius struggles to reach the horse, repeatedly jumping up and missing the seat. "Hold up, I can carry you." Blue effortlessly picks Gabrius up, practically throwing him onto the wooden animal. Without any time to find an animal for himself, he throws himself onto the nearest one, mounting a unicorn.

The ferris wheel…

A giant wheel they've never seen the likes of before captivates their capricious minds. They nod at each other, knowing what the other is contemplating. The line kills them with boredom, but they adamantly stick it out. It was *so* worth it.

They hop into a blue cabin, giddily gazing out of the windows surrounding them. As soon as they reach the summit of the ride, the setting star blinds them. They laugh aloud, ignoring the stinging currently scorching their eyes, profusely blinking through it.

Food…

Their ever-wandering minds are absorbed by neon-colored signage, appetizingly promoting "scrumptious" funnel cakes. Gabrius's stomach generously grumbles, unveiling an obvious secret.

The funnel cakes were scrumptious, the cart rides were scrumptious, and the music was scrumptious… It was all *so scrumptious*!

Euphoria resounds, leaving no corner unturned. Something sinister about it lurks, however.

Trepidation conceals its form with a shower of precipitation, lurking in every body of water in Vorrà City. The strangely-scented water wafts through Blue and Gabrius's noses, coldly caressing their senses and careening them off the clear road they were so soundly set on.

[...]

"Bro, that reflection was so peak."

"How long did you spend 'reflecting..?'"

"I dunno," Blue shrugs, sipping on a milkshake. "I think we lost track of time."

"Time is irrelevant inside of『Reflection』, but I'm pretty sure you spent a few years there in terms of the real time y'all experienced."

"I mean, I only remember the fun parts. It's really weird, actually. I'm pretty sure my memories got messed with."

"Got lost in the sauce," Red comments. "Wait, so you just lived in the reflection for *that* long?"

"Yeah. I'm pretty sure the water there did something to me."

"You said, earlier, that it smelled funny?"

"Mhm. Like scorpion grasses, or whatever they're called."

"Myosotises, yeah. How'd you even get out? Y'know, of Il Rifugio?"

"Uhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhh—"

[...]

"Why do we keep seeing her here?" Gabrius worriedly whispers to Blue.

"Maybe she likes trains too," Blue whispers back.

Calliope candidly sits on a bench nearby, carefreely kicking her legs and happily drinking a smoothie. She superstitiously senses two pairs of eyes on her, turning to the boys and peacefully waving at him.

«What's up? Do you two need anything?»

I'll TRY to remember the main stuff. The lore is insane.

For the first few months, we visited Nunc's first asterism—of the other 25—every morning before messing around Vorrà City. It was weird that Calliope was there every morning, though.

«Hey, boys! I heard you two had fun yesterday.»

"Yeah."
"Yeah."

«Wanna know what'd be even cooler than all that train stuff?»

"What?"

'No, don't ask her—'

«A cat café! C'mon, I'll show you~!»

She was annoying as hell! *Always* forced us to do things with her every morning. Looked at us without actually looking at us (¾ gaze or whatever). Acted like she knew us, or something…

«Want to come explore some more today? I promise there's lots more to see here!» she sweetly suggests.

Blue and Gabrius look at each other, intrigued. Despite their laziness, they'd feel bad about any other answer they might dish out to deny her.

That first day, we worked at a pizza place with her. It was *definitely* the most fun we had while we were with her, but we never went back there after.

Then, we started doing things—weird things—*for* her.

Busting our asses over becoming business tycoons…

"How does this money-making system work?" Gabrius questions, pointing at the mechanical droppers of neon-lit packages.

«Great question, Gabe~! I… actually have no idea!»

Adjusting to the fields, so we could grow a garden…

Blue, startled by the highly-personalized tools, shoots an inquisitive stare at the boss lady. "Whose garden is this?"

«No idea, but it's good volunteer work to lift your spirits, right guys?!»

"Ugh."

"Ugh."

Doing some orphans…

WHAT.

WHAT.

Woah, I meant—like—working at an adoption center.

"Why're there so many orphans on the planet of *peace*?" the transit fanner raises, genuinely alarmed.

"Yeah, there's no way it's a money problem, right? Literally so many people are rich here…" the blue buffoon sustains, seriously concerned.

"And everyone always looks super happy, but there'll barely be anyone sad about anything!"

"And when you see those kinda people, they look C-R-A-Z-Y!"

"Yeah, what the heck's up with allat?"

"I don't know, man. Yo, wait, can you remember anything from yesterday?"

"Nah, what about you?"

"Nope, but what about the day before that?"

"Absolutely not. Woah, this is mad sus."

"Yeah, we're not *THAT* geeked. Callie, d'you know anything about this, or…?"

And I think one day we started asking so many questions that she just snapped!

«Would you guys ***STOP*** asking so many questions?»

Her veracious voice booms, enunciating at a blistering volume. The same skies once surely sunny now reiterate, overcast by her sudden outburst. The two swear they can feel their ears ringing from the swift impact of her vocals.

Though sedately smiling, every bit of unpronounceable emotion and utterance from her soul scorches them; as if real flames were bursting forth from her tongue, solely set on subduing them.

Finally, the pressure pouring from her lips recedes, and the skies' calm demeanor returns. The uncanny mood switch, however, settles itself in for the remainder of the rowdy two's day.

«Ahem, anyways..! Sorry, but some questions are better left unanswered.»

We've only seen her crash out once the entire time we were there—

«Could you two go around town and pass out these flyers? The local observatory really needs more visitors!»

—without anything to follow it up with; like it never happened.

It was like… kinda spooky. A bunch of odd jobs, a weird timeline of events, but I can't even remember the exact details of anything. Lots of white noise in my head.

Through all of that?

That's crazy.

I'm pretty sure we stopped meeting at the train station at one point. She said it wasn't good for us, or something. Then, she forced us to get IDs, made us take a bunch of tests, stole us from what we were doing to hang out with her a bunch, blah blah blah. And then… Wait a minute—

[…]

"You're actually stupid."

"She deadass sounds like a walking tourist trap. I dunno how you fell for that."

"…Me neither."

[…]

"[redacted]"

Y'know, on at least one of those days, *something… weird*… happened. Like a switch flipped on in my head. Like something spoke to me.

Actually… that might've been it.

"Duude."

"What?"

"How long have we been here?"

Gabrius checks his mental calendar, calculating arbitrarily. "Like… eight years? Why're we talking about this right now?" he questions, the two of them sat at a booth.

Blue pupils dilate, panic prodding at his soul. "Eight years… I knew this'd be bad. We need to leave, now."

Gabrius kindly receives their boxed pizza pie from the waiter whilst taking this all in. "Damn… What were we doing before all this?"

"Uhhh…"

The scatterbrained duo exits the pizza parlor, their scattered brains more pieced apart than the pizza pie in front of them.

Calliope materializes into being, hiding out of sight from the two goofballs. Her expression, although always a gleeful array of pearly whites, is secretly grave at this moment. 'My hold on them… It's slipping.'

Blue senses her instantly and turns before Gabrius does, giving their so-called "tour guide" the stare of a thousand suns.

『*Ψθμ αγε αβιε τθ μσε τλε σκιω "Γεβιεστιθη."*』

Silhouettes scatter, and a puppet show of a past untold unfolds before his very eyes. The shapes and their boundaries strengthen and weaken, defined only by eidetic flashes of extrospection. Synapses fire and impulses converge, Blue pushing the very limits placed on him by nature to read Calliope's story.

'As long as I don't touch her, it won't send me to her memories… I think—'

Time slows to a crawl. Space holds its breath. Blue can feel something. It's in her memories, but also his. The back of his skull tauntingly tingles, a tantalizing urge to scratch it being held above his head.

'That's not a headache…'

『The Calamity "[redacted]" warns his fellow Calamity.』

A force beyond recognition taps him on the shoulder, advising him to use the skill on himself. He, without question, nods to himself, about to enter the subways of his mind.

«Hm? Is there a problem?»

'What the—'

Blue hastily pieces the blurry puzzle in his fading consciousness together before his train of thought escapes him, knowing something he can't quite yet voice. The words won't come to him.

"Nah, you just had… something… on your face."

«Oh, is it gone now?» she asks, pulling a handkerchief from her pocket and daintily wiping her face with it.

"Yeah."

«Awesome, awesome! Anyways, I have a new adventure for you two today—»

"Actually, we don't feel like doing any of that today."

«What if it involves something you both would find *super* interesting?»

"Absolutely not!" Blue huffs. "Honestly, we don't even wanna be on this planet anymore!"

'We?' Gabrius raises wordlessly. Regretfully so, he does not feel so inclined as to leave this place like Blue.

«Ah, but today will be a great lesson on Nunc's interpretation of transportation!» she jubilantly announces, her eyes not directly facing them. «It'll be a blast! I know I've always wanted to go through the motions of this kinda thing! After all, I know you've only experienced this on the way from **Antecedens**.»

'Antecedens…' The box of pizza shakes in Gabrius's once-apathetic hands.

'Hey, chill out.'

There was a reason Blue barely mentioned Gabrius's home planet. In fact, the possibilities that might arise from any mention of "Antecedens" were enough to completely deter Blue. After having stumbled upon his more impressionable years of a time long gone, he now knows no current reminder of such would do any good for Gabrius's mental health. Nothing good could come of *that* place.

Antecedens, the planet of primordial peril, and a place no being should go lest death may already be upon them.

'It's alright.'

Blue puts his arm around Gabrius's shoulder, for the first time, in a non-creepy fashion. He roughs the distraught kid's hair up, facing them in the other direction. "I don't know how you know that, but we really don't need any of that! We'd rather leave, right?"

Gabrius can only shrug, too caught up in his own mental conflict to concretely decide anything.

«Blue, bestie,» Calliope chuckles. Her visage turns from amicable to a frightening fear factor, doubling Blue's shrouded terror.

She waves her hand to mute the streaming microphone attached to her, not forgetting to angle the camera away from her face as well. «I'm not feeling too great today, so I'll only repeat myself once: hop on the train down this block, and I won't have to harm you two.»

"What are you actually trying to accomplish here?" Blue interrogates, his guard now fully raised.

'Yo, is there really a problem with staying here?' Gabrius telepathically asks Blue. 'We could just… *not* fight, right?'

«It's better if you two aren't in the know. I'm only doing what is best for you guys.»

"Best for who? Might just be for you."

«You don't even know half of this whole ordeal. I'm trying to keep you two safe—»

"From what?"

«I-I'm not allowed to talk about any of that.»

"That's pretty sus."

«It wouldn't be if you knew the history we had, or at least Gabrius and I!»

"History?" Gabrius sputters, almost blushing.

«Not like that, yuck!» she silently snickers. «*Ha*. If you boys keep dragging this, I'm not above forcing a more favorable outcome for all of us.»

Gabrius's face scrunches like plastic, disturbed by this oddly familiar dialogue. The hypnotic ethereality of lost—lasting, once upon a time—echoes linger in his aching head. They bounce off the walls of his headspace with laughter, some bouts euphoric

"Is this what we're doing now?" Blue angrily asks. His bones snap into place as his fists close, each crack creating a thunderclap.

His harrowed heart swells with remembrance, though his mind can't quite seem to grasp at those foggy waters yet. With each sad attempt at grasping them, such only slips from his fingers. He tries to catch every minute, the feeling in it; at that, though he thinks himself closer to knowing, the dancing figures in his memories keep growing away from him.

'Away from me…'

Eternal regret swirls in his heart, mixing with his burning blood. It burns with an unresolved sadness. The sadness sears his bastard soul so scornfully. He wants to laugh, to push aside these rugged shoes for a new pair to walk in; that much is obvious to Blue.

"

Episode 7 — Lagtrain

Phase 1: Overture

{*On ne voit bien qu'avec le cœur...*}

[Meanwhile, a tale—otherwise known as a group, in Regal terminology—of Sovereigns settle at a round table.]

Gray lines grimly gather, and unkind designs for a destined future strictly conform. A prosaic tale of Sovereigns sternly faces one another, tensions telling taller tales than one can describe with a single glance.

«Has *anyone* gotten a hold of the Catastrophes?» the six-armed Sovereign inquires.

«Trying, I'm afraid all of us are; and yet, they slip under our radar,» the sycamore-shaped Sovereign staunchly states.

«Stop rhyming so much, it's getting on my nerves!» the circus ringleader Sovereign, Lucretia, shouts aloud. «Go back to writing poetry, or some—»

«Calm down,» the angelic Sovereign soothingly susurrates. «One of them seems to be running more rampant than the rest, somewhere within the Auctus system. Can *anyone* get a reading of their heat signature?»

The dumbfounded dullards shake their heads, devastating the angelic being. «I fear our options are numbered, here. We might need to fully enact「Novus Ordo」if this continues getting out of hand! We may end up losing more of those within our ranks…»

All of the Sovereigns sorrowfully sigh, bowing their heads for a moment to commemorate their fallen comrades. An unspoken rule amongst the prosaic tale, inspired by the original grandmaster of the Sovereigns, stands to be the only agreement they have to this day: to honor the dead, whether friend or foe.

«Calliope…» Lucretia laments.

«Mallor,» Nova whispers.

Soon, a flurry of names flow, like ill ink on a torn piece of paper. Umbin, Aesop, Mortis, Satis, Paradox, Aurelius, Proxima, Seng, Vox, Welkin, and many others.

The bespectacled Sovereign, spangled by another one of his personally-tailored, eight-piece suits, sits somberly. He raises a hand to speak, softly saying, «So much loss.»

«Yes, and we must put an end to all of this.»

They all nod their heads, agreeing without as much as a second thought. Although some are skeptical of her motives, only one is willing to call her out on it.

«Dearest Nova, why must you insist upon such intense interference?» The Sovereign with a lion's mane politely raises his hand, standing up to her authority. «Your enactment has already plagued Chroma, so what more will spreading it throughout the encompassing ensemble do? The people already under it *despise* it.»

«When did I say you could call me by my name, Regulus?» the angelic being, Nova, addresses, her eyes faintly flaring with hatred. «And while I am aware of how much everyone hates the <lofty> laws I set up, they all fail to realize how much protection I'm giving through them.»

Regulus raises an eyebrow. «Then, why do you refuse to announce those benefits?»

«It's unnecessary.»

«It is a risk you aren't willing to take.»

«So what if it is? You *must* know what kind of risk it is if you're willing to question my decision, right?»

«Maybe I do, maybe I don't.»

«Then, what <say> do you have in what I see?»

«I am only suggesting that—»

«I request that we cease this,» the sycamore-shaped Sovereign speaks. «The majority of us are agreeing with the initiation of Novus Ordo. All we need is the minority's agreement. Please, Regulus.»

Regulus crosses his arms, utterly disgusted. «…»

«Before we may sign on this, would anyone amongst us be willing to seize the Catastrophe in Auctus?» Nova kindly requests.

All the background chatter ceases, and everyone goes quiet.

A singular, steely hand slowly raises, belonging to that of the six-armed Sovereign. It is of no surprise to the other Sovereigns. After all, the Catastrophe is in his domain.

[...]

{*L'essentiel est invisible pour les yeux.*}

Boredom hits the two like a hangover, everything a black and white in their mind. Becoming of light to show what's right, and to never shine down on them; at least for now. A blackened spire centers itself on the stage of their headspace, leaving nothing but a wasteland of forgotten joy and independence.

It was only natural for them to succumb to the darkness, yet completely out of line for the darkness to take charge; for that darkness isn't theirs. Temptation struck, so they would have to prove themselves against it. Even then, the temptation—Calliope—watches their every move, keeping at bay what their ambitions ~~wouldn't~~ couldn't.

She really gave you the opportunity to leave Nunc like that? Something's definitely off.

The train carries onward without a hitch, its tireless trail flourishing with the flip of a switch. Nothing could stop the train, and to try would mean immeasurable pain. Something could save them from boredom, that was known; but what arms could they even call home?

Of course there was, but we barely had a clue.

Gabrius and Blue are well-off on their trip now, taking their jobs more than seriously. Even better is that they're paid in addicting drinks to substitute for their ineligibility for any pay. The two didn't care a bit about their previous concerns with this new development.

…This kind of escape feels all too easy for a guy like you.

They definitely don't waste this opportunity to avoid acting posh, either. After all, it's only in their nature to horse around. It gets them answers on their own time, though, that's for sure.

"Why, hello there, my good sir! Would you like some tea with your biscuits?" Gabrius asks in the worst, fancy accent known to amelioration, bowing to a lavish-looking, suited gentleman equipped with a newspaper.

The old man, though astonished, nods demurely. Gabrius grins, pouring the tea into a tiny, porcelain cup and placing it on the table in front of the man.

Blue stifles an enormous laugh, still trying to take in his surroundings. A fancy lodging like this can be found on some sort of private jet, but not any kind of commercial transport. This, however, is no mere formality of falsehood, nor luxury for losers; this is the constellation connector of Nunc, and perfect property of the Regalia—free to the public as signified in the Novus Ordo codex.

The transit fanner is practically bouncing off the walls with such ecstasy! The coy boy's joy washes over the coach car, filling everyone in his vicinity with a cool, yet reassuring

teaspoon of positivity. Only a teaspoon, though. Gabrius's rancid stench manages to even it out almost entirely. It's only been getting worse ever since he found…

"Dude, you should try some of this!" the transit fanner yelps, calling Blue over from the other side of the car.

Blue chuckles, capering over in an esteemed fashion. "You smell crazy… Slide some!"

The blue menace gingerly grabs the thing of orange liquid, straightening his uniform's tie before chugging down the remainder of the blissful beverage. His face barely brightens as he tenderly tosses it to the trash can, not reading the bottle at all. "Damn, what was that?"

"Arizona!" Gabrius exclaims, moving the bottle to the recycling bin. "Came all the way from a different multiverse. Tastes mad scrumptious."

"Scrumptious? You stealing my words?"

"Nuh uh."

"Bro, at least freshen up before lying to my face," Blue giggles.

"Huh?"

Everyone within proximity of Gabrius, besides Blue, pinches their nostrils to protect themselves from the powerful odor of the peculiar boy.

"I smell that bad?"

"Duh. It's actually gotten *way* worse since we got here. We *literally* just got here—"

The peculiar boy absently bobs his head whilst Blue yammers on, cheekily unsheathing a new, fully-filled bottle of Arizona from his back pocket. His boisterous sips cut into Blue's sentences, drowning the sound of him out.

"—and you already smell like the whole bo—bro, is that another one?"

"No… *sluuurp*."

"You're crazy."

"It's just that good!"

"Actually how, dude?"

"Because it's so juicy, bro. I'm too addicted to this stuff already."

"Nah, you're insane."

"At least tell me it's that good, though."

"It's better than Nunc's water, but hell nah…"

"Four fingers to your crack, would you still—"

Wait, I swear you said the same thing a few minutes ago.

Nuh-uh.

Your story feels like it's been going literally nowhere. It'd make a good slice-of-life story, but…

I promise there's a story in my head. It's just really funky.

[…]

"Plus, it was all Calliope's fault, not ours!"

"Literally, how?"

"You know… like, when you wanna leave from somewhere, but someone kinda keeps you there by being too nice?"

"Bro got guilt-tripped into being kidnapped."

"I mean, that *is* a thing; but, he's still a simp."

"Okay, *but* hear me out. She had MASSIVE knockers."

Red and Yellow side-eye each other, almost intrigued by Blue's proposition. They both eagerly eye him back, giving him a moment to elaborate.

"24DD," Blue daringly declares, his saucy visage saying it all.

Ketchup and Mustard's innocent gazes blink momentarily before the Blue Cheese can pull up a sizable example. Their immediate switch-up says it all.

"Immense power."

"Completely justified."

[…]

"I swear, we should've arrived at Semper a *while* ago," Gabrius complains, throwing his hands up into the air.

"Then why are we still moving?" Blue wonders, slumping down onto the nearest seat.

"Maybe we're on the wrong train..?"

"Nah, you've yapped for hours about the transit system. I'm pretty sure you wouldn't be geeked like that."

Blue peeks out the window, watching the relative movement of everything outside; that way, he can get a good idea of how fast the train is going.

"Hey, the train's barely even moving!"

Gabrius irritably groans, pulling an otherworldly device from his pocket, also known as Nunc's newest invention…

"Did you get a new phone without me?" Blue inquires, raising an eyebrow at the portable cellphone.

"You said you didn't want one before I left the hotel, so…"

"Didn't think you'd get one without me, though."

"Man, it's whatever. Let me just check the—"

No cell service. He's hindered by the strange lack of connection, unable to access anything. 'What the hell?'

"Maybe there's no connection in space."

"Nah, they said this thing could go anywhere."

Gabrius aggressively taps his phone over and over again, almost smashing his hand against it out of frustration.

"Yo, chill out," he whispers, noticing the nosey eyes on them.

"Ahh, I knew this was all a bad idea."

"Then why didn't you say anything?"

"I dunno… I just thought we—"

"You can think?" Blue jokes, pleased with himself.

"You don't hafta make a joke out of everything…" Gabrius mumbles, weakly kicking the ground.

"I *have to* keep our spirits up, at least."

"Can you… ever be serious?"

"What?"

"Can you ever be serious?" the peculiar boy repeats, his peeved tone reaching Blue. "It's like you're allergic to anything without comedy somewhere in it."

"You're overthinking it," the blue menace dismissively says, fanning his hand against Gabrius's hot air. "You're just making everything harder for us."

"Are you saying I'm a burden?"

"No, that's not what I meant—"

"Just stop—"

"*Bro*, it's not that serious."

"…It's how I feel, at least."

Blue's eyes focus for a moment, finding a flickering fallacy in his friend's voice. "Why are you bringing that up if you're always putting your feelings last?"

"What?"

"This *literally* all started because you tried to kill yourself."

"That's… *not* how that works. Plus, this started because *you* got involved."

"So… I should've left you to die?"

"Yeah."

"How..?"

"I dunno."

"Whaddaya mean 'I dunno?'"

"I dunno."

"…"

"Ever since we landed on Nunc, you've been *super* annoying," Gabrius sourly states, stepping aside and resting his tense body on the window sill.

Blue steals his idea, propping himself up against an adjacent window. He turns slightly to see the stars beaming his way, the stellar view stunning him. "And you've been super grumpy. What's with *you*?"

"I dunno, you just… *confuse* me!"

"How am I confusing???"

"You *randomly* fell out of the sky, *somehow* ended up stuck with me, and have acted like you've known me or something this entire time! That's crazy suspicious!"

Blue pauses for a second, turning his head towards the only star that should matter to him.
"What's confusing about that?"

"I *don't know*, I… I'm not *that* good with my words."

"Neither am I, but you can try! No one's here to judge you…"

"I guess I just think you feel… *realer*… than everyone else."

Guilt washes over Blue, a fresh shower of emotions renewing him. He wants to admit how wrong he was for his behavior earlier; of course, his pride precedes him.

"…"

"…"

Blue looks away again, facing back towards the starry shoreline. Though beaming at him, he feels as if the stars ahead are watching him, waiting for him to say something.
He—carelessly, as is his nature—momentarily allows the creepy light to corrupt his view.

"It was a sacrifice you were making for others, not yourself. You definitely put your feelings last there."

"..."

"..."

The quietude cuts like a cool knife, and away is the sway of what was once a normal day. Their thoughts keep to their owners, though rabidly pulling at their leashes; for forever in their captivity, they have wished to be **liberated**—maybe to meet each other in the middle.

'What if we're stuck? Damn, where do we go from here..?'

'Damn, where do we go from here? What if we're stuck..?'

„Even below the surface, those subways of your mind shadow the world outside. Why do you two think that is?" postulates an antique voice.

"Huh?"
"Huh?"

The voice clears its throat, resuming its spectator role. The boys wave their heads back and forth, searching for whomever called them out.

{*On ne voit bien qu'avec le cœur...*}

Nova nears the edge of the great castle—the home of the Sovereigns. It stands atop the highest point of the Somnium, hanging over the highest height to define the limits of amelioration, as well as to flaunt the ancient city.

Only myriad myths, through their composite image, can truly begin to depict the city's ethereal existence. However, it's worth noting that every one of those myths share the same, direct details: unreal greenery, timeless architecture, endless space, and unfathomable creations.

The amber-tinted "verdure" murders any chance of realism that the city could fool one with. The impossible geometry of such nature, its unique beauty surrounding the ancient city, can easily manage to melt any mortal mind that might observe beneath its surface.

Buildings of harmonious and uniform architecture line the somber streets like photos on a wall, illustrated by limestone and marble columns, friezes, and roofs. Besides the symmetry, verily decorative art of the Sovereigns' history is chiseled into the minerals.

Its boundaries choose the beginning and end of any horizon, as it is said to be the sky itself. Denizens in more abundance than grains of sand on a beach fit comfortably into the ancient city; and albeit all the space, its animated atmosphere is unlike any other. Rumor has it that the vast majority of those denizens are now dead, however.

Incomprehensible structures only found in the sketchbooks of a dreaming child are scattered near and far in the city. Liminality lingers everywhere within said structures, nostalgia and emptiness coming together to create the spaces. The castle is one of those many oddities, informally known as Stormwatch Keep.

Nova rests her head on her hands, her gaze fixed onto the megacity below. «I've never analyzed the view from up here so longingly… Am I becoming human, once more? *Ha*…»

She pushes aside her fake halo and reaches into her Rapunzel hair, pulling out an instant camera darker than pure obsidian. It frames the sight in front of her face, printing it into an eternal memory. She inspects the print. It's no different than the horizon hailing her home.

«Nothing more perfect than this, is there? Mmm, I'm sure you'd be of more use to the folks down below. Hmph, if only you weren't a gift from—»

As she tucks the camera back into the tufts of her hair, her heart begins to drum against her chest. «—ah, *him*,» she concludes, frustration riddling her tongue.

Regulus works his way up to the angel, scaling the round staircase to the rooftop of Stormwatch Keep. He's resolved to reason with the "fair" lady during this brief period of solicitude.

The Sovereigns' meeting has been granted an adjournment, as per everyone's indecisiveness, before the final decision regarding Novus Ordo may be made.

Regal reverberations reflect off of the limestone and marble, the footsteps of a perfect king bursting forth like a constant bombardment.

The show of Sovereignty sends shivers down the "fair" lady's spine. She feels her sins crawling on her back. Her airs of elegance are rarely troubled, yet the perfect king is doing just that.

Finally, the lion-maned Sovereign arrives, stony like a statue at the precipice of fate.

«Nova.»

Small wrinkles above the angel's eyes carve cracks into her mundane mask.

«Regulus.»

His general visage hardens, but the corners of his mouth soften the tiniest bit.

«I remember those times from so long ago, your excited self taking pictures all willy-nilly.»

«What do you want, old man?»

«I simply want to know about what has been bothering you.»

«What are you talking about?»

«Are they not eating away at you, those moral dilemmas you keep so close to your heart?»

«No, they're easy fixes. Test subjects are simply scarce, that's all.»

«The「Permutation Project」is not an easy fix, though. It is selfish beyond comparison.»

«You say that, yet you turned a blind eye to it when we were implementing it into those planets.»

«Because I trusted that you would do the right thing, though I suppose that I can be wrong about quite a few things.»

«And it was the right thing to do! I don't know who you're judging, but it has provided ample security against the Void since I put it into effect.»

«You *are* practically a serial killer, however. All of those lives taken by your project's ‹permutation machines› could have fulfilled so much more, yet you chose to waste what you once deemed was so precious.»

«Not *wasting*, but *recycling*.»

«That is indeed a twisted notion you have backing your work. I am confident that it can justify the ‹refuge› you built on Nunc, which on its own has taken over 21 billion lives; all in exchange for that energy you need so badly.»

«It's for the greater good! How many times do I have to repeat that to make it make sense?! Billions could've become trillions if I didn't step in!»

«There are other ways.»

«Like what?»

«I'm not sure, but we could always talk about some other solutions over tea. You would still like that, wouldn't you?»

«...»

Nova can't bear to meet Regulus's eyes with hers. Her back stays turned from him, wings flowing from her shoulders shielding her teary face.

«You *are* doing your best, fauntekin. I can see that much, but this dirty work cannot go unnoticed.»

«You're the only one noticing it—the only one opposing it.»

«Everyone else does so too, at least in their hearts.»

«Sacrifices need to be made, at least. That much is true to you, isn't it?»

«…»

«Plus, the permutation process keeps the minds of those lost living onward, even after their bodies have decayed! I was kind enough to add that feature, no?»

«Replaying a closed interval of time for their minds does not count for a term such as ‹living.› It fails to court any kind of future for the victims. It is a prison like no other.»

«Whatever. You'll all thank me one day for the work I did, which *you* people weren't willing to do.»

Regulus slowly shakes his head in disapproval. Nova's eyes get redder by the second.

The perfect king walks a few inches closer to the "fair" lady, although finding her barely approachable.

«You were not as brazen as this before, Nova. Perhaps **his** death filled you with a sense of purpose,» Regulus comments.

Her hands twitch. He can see her peripherals momentarily panic, standing as still as a statue behind her. She hates hearing **him** mentioned by anyone else, especially at a time like this.

«Hm, you were his favorite out of all of us. You still would be if he was here today,» he comforts, a troubled susurration flying from him.

«Oh, so you're jealous!» Nova laughs, slapping him on the back. He slips forward slightly, resting his body on the railing. «I should've known you were that petty, harassing me for eons over such a thing!»

Regulus shakes his head, chuckling to himself. «Let me be clear, fauntekin. This is not a matter of personal discourse.»

«Then, what? Why would you bring him up?»

«Only to remind you of what you once stood by.»

«That was a bygone era, you old fool. I'd much rather take joy in creating a new one, rather than remaining trapped like *some* people,» she affirms, discretely looking Regulus up and down.

«You mean… trapped like *those* people, hm?» he refutes, not a second spared in his speech. «Those ameliorites in the aftermath of that battle, consumed by the water—»

«It was for a greater good than you could ever imagine,» she defensively diverges. «They're a small sacrifice in exchange for salvation. That water is helping us, Rex.»

«Your—really, it isn't ever yours, young lady—so-called ‹water› is a heinous crime against amelioration itself. It is practically Il Rifugio's stomach acid! 'Tis a fancy prison—an eternal dream—for those unfortunate enough to be lured into Nunc..! *Hah*… you and your creations disgust me!»

«It's simply another form of protection for our people.»

«And against what?!»

«I… can't tell you that.»

«You've wrought, with your own two hands, for centuries on a singular project, only to now cast it aside from our judgment?»

«It's for the same purpose that Novus Ordo must be enforced.»

«You can at least trust me.»

«I really can't.»

«There's a light at the end of the tunnel, waiting for you; that is *if* you can at least relinquish yourself of this silly secret of yours.»

«I don't need your metaphors to make a decision, Rex.»

«His metaphors helped you, at least.»

«How dare you—»

«We all miss him, fauntekin. There is no hiding that. I miss him more than I would like to admit. Of course, Kosmos is gone now, and… only you can truly continue his legacy, but not like this!»

The brightest angel shudders, as if chilled by a freezing gust of wind after *his* name. «I-I needn't hear anymore of your squandering—»

She briskly walks off at a pace unseen by any mortal eye, but Regulus carefully catches her by the arm.

«You know full well of what message he wished for everyone to know before we lost him. These actions of yours… their weight… it all adds up and equates to a befitting end, adjacent to his. You mustn't make the same mistakes—»

«Who cares?! Everything I did was perfect to him, and forever will be, even without his input!»

«And what you do will forever become what you've done. Do you really want the world to know you for the treachery you've caused—the prisoners you've procured—at such a cost?»

«It won't matter if everything is **perfect** in the end!» She sighs, frazzled. «You've pushed me to my limit, big guy. Let me go, or there won't be any trace of your name left in this new world I have yet to write!»

«I have rules from him that I must follow, fauntekin, and I absolutely *cannot* let go of them now. I have *sworn* to *protect* you!»

«From what?!»

«Maybe the **same** thing you haven't been telling any of us about!»

«Then, screw those rules! Why would you need them when I have everything completely in the palms of my hands—»

«Because those rules were written in BLOOD, Nova—*HIS* blood.»

«I. Don't. Care.»

«I refuse to let you have your way if it is to be like this—!»

Nova's eyes flicker with a faint flash of rage. She spins around to face her protector, getting one last look at him before—

«Well, let me make this easier for you then.»

A quick shove to his upper body sends him flying through the railing.

A thunderclap from the collision shakes the entire roof. Thankfully, the wreckage of architecture is magnitudes louder than the screams of those who are witnessing his fall—music to Nova's ears.

«You won't be saving yourself from this either,» Nova authorizes, activating her Sovereignty.

[insert sovereignty activation here]

Without any warning, he plummets to an ostensive demise; in fact, it was already too late from the moment he uttered the man's name.

Below him, a statue of a hero points upwards with a sword. It pierces his chest, splitting him straight through the heart he once wore on his sleeve. Blood oozes, trickling down from the statue and onto the street. His fellow Sovereigns see him from the lower floors of the castle, gasping and shrieking in horror.

Though the roof collapses from her temper tantrum, she bows to her invisible audience, hearing it as their applause. The anger on her face is no more. Sweet bliss is all it is.

«And *that*… folks, is—»

{*L'essentiel est invisible pour les yeux.*}

"—Scene!" blares the TV, a cartoon playing on the big black box.

„I didn't know they had entertainment on this train! Hoh!"

An old man is jumping from his seat. He seems to really be getting into the action. He turns to his right, seeing the two boys staring at him. Seems they've realized it was him who called them out.

„Are you boys alright?“ inquires the old man, lowering his thick set of papers and tipping his fedora.

The blue boy's attention snaps to his left. It's the lavishing-looking lad Gabrius was serving a few minutes ago. The blueberry's head tilts in puzzlement and raises an eyebrow, his gut growling at his heart. 'Why does he look… familiar?'

"We're fine, good sir," the transit fanner replies, reinstalling his regal tone of voice. "Nothing a fine fellow like you should concern yourself with."

„Ah, of course,“ he chirps, almost flying from the conversation completely as he pulls his newspaper back up to his wrinkled face.

An awkward lull in the loud-mouthed exchange enters like an unwelcome guest. The sophisticated sips of Nunc's special water susurrate like leaves on a fruitless tree. Eyes shift unsurely like quantum particles in motion.

Gabrius rests against the wall behind him, sagely staring at the inverted sky. 'The memory… I think we're almost at the end.'

'Eh?'

'This is the train I took to Semper…'

'Really? I thought… Wait, how did we get here again?'

'You like, opened up my memories, or something.'

'Uhhh… I did that?'

'So geeked…'

Calliope's faint presence lingers lividly. She can tell something's set to startle her sinister scheme.

The mysterious man snaps his daily paper back into shape, cracking it like a whip. He buries his head against the headlines, a small smirk appearing on his face.

„We're losing more dignity by the day, aren't we?"

Blue and Gabrius eye the old man with intrigued irises, brightened by the distant starlight.

„I mean, what is the purpose of putting these lusty ladies on these perfectly-written pages?" he mutters to himself, his squinted peepers scrolling through the paper screen.

Gabrius jolts subtly at the sentence, rotating his view ever so slightly to peek.

He's already caught Gabrius's attention. Great. Now for the bigger boy's heed.

The mysterious man puts a pair of glasses on, adjusting them carefully. „At least these cologne prices are going down."

Blue jolts subtly at the sentence, rotating his view ever so slightly to peek.

For whatever reason imagineable, Blue became obsessed with all kinds of aromatics—mainly colognes—during his time in Nunc. Honestly, after smelling that kid for the first time, I thought I'd avoid being anywhere near as stinky as *him*.

A sudden gust of wind knocks the newspaper out of the man's hands, very conveniently placing it at Gabrius's feet.

„Ah, would you mind picking that up for me, my friend?"

"Uh, sure."

As the transit fanner bends over, his eyes catch a short glimpse into a sickening sight. Blood rapidly rushes to his head, for he is stuck frozen in his bent pose. His shoulders stiffen, muscular knots tightening. He's tempted to tie one 'round his neck.

"You good?"

"I…"

"..?"

Blue saunters to the boy's side, peering downward. Then, it all makes sense. "Holy…"

A perfect blue wraps around his conscience, fashioning a ribbon of his arms. He clutches his chest, almost falling back into the seat behind him.

‹Regal Rest: Seventh Sovereign Death This Year!›

'What?'

‹Calliope, the Radiant Refrain, has been found dead on Nunc, the planet of peace. Albeit known for her ***fiery*** spirit, not even a Sovereign's flame can last forever. No evidence has been provided by her scene of death, as it is only her lifeless body building rot on the sidewalk. Some coroners say her death was accidental, some say her death was suicidal, but the majority say her death was a menacing message. From whom is an answer unknown, but with due process will be figured out in time.›

Phase 2: First Intermezzo

[Eight hours later…]

The doleful two are left alone with their thoughts, thinking about Calliope; that much thinking hurts their heads, however. Just what were they dealing with here?

The endless ride has gotten stale for the two boys, especially without each other's company. Like shy school girls, they exchange occasional glances from time to time. That's about it, though.

The rest of the passengers follow suit, surrendering to the silence. Really, though, they were already absent the moment they had a glass of water.

The old man, his newspaper back in hand, can only alleviate the stress on them by making comments about the cartoon show…

„Would you look at that? If only **heroes** like that were real!"

…or by yapping about his newspaper.

„So many good stories to read about these days. Modern-day **heroes** are just swell!"

None of it seems to work, however. He's only a senile old man to them, talking nonsense to himself. 'Maybe I should make my approach more… *direct*.'

„Say, boys… Where do you seem to be headed?"

"Semper."

„Ahh, an interesting destination. Where did you two board from, then?"

"Nunc."

„Mhm mhm, makes sense. I'd be leaving Nunc at any chance I could take."

"Huh?"

„It's a terrible place. I've heard many-a wicked tales from my friends, mostly about the stormy weather. Frighteningly enough, the grand majority of those tales turn out to be true in the end."

'He sounds like a pirate…'

'Trueee.'

'Wait, was the weather there even stormy?'

'I don't think it was. He might be high.'

„I can hear you two, you know."

'He's bluffing, don't listen to him—'

„No bluffing to be found for miles, my friends."

"You still sound cuckoo."

„I'm sure I do, but there's still a method in *my* madness. No longer is there in any of yours'."

"You calling us stupid?"

„Clueless, yes; stupid, no. That's what that many repeats can do to fellows such as yourselves."

"Repeats?"

„*Ahem*, but I digress. You boys seem much too confused for passengers of this wonderful system."

"Uh, yeah."

"Has it felt like we've been here for waaay too long to you, or is it just us?"

„Ah, perhaps it's ***Boredom***?"

"Boredom?"

"Nah, that isn't it."

„Hmph, then maybe I should tell you two a story that might get your brains going."

The winds of change imparted the leaves.
It shook them from their tall tree.
Such is the price of that Fall fee:
The Fall of their Foundations.

One leaf flew far, far away from there,
Through a tear in time, as a pair, on a dime.
Its new partner knew well, but it knew better
Than to test the zephyrs' flow.

On and on they went, so bent out of shape.
Time and time again, the distance teased their hearts.
Cyclical were the train tracks, forever which they tread
In hopes of finding their friends.

'That was kinda boring.'

'I feel like he's tryna tell us something…'

„You two do know I can still hear those thoughts of yours, right? Plus, sharing stories is a pretty decent way to spend the time if you're asking me."

"I guess, yeah. Keep talking, then."

Blue and Gabrius politely seat themselves by the old gentleman. His distinguished, yet casual demeanor relieves a hidden tension in their torsos that they didn't know plagued them.

„Mm… there's this other story I know. It's quite the charmer with everyone it's shook hands with."

I once knew a boy who was just like me,
As blue as the bashful sea.
He was shy, but still filled with a silly glee,
As bright as stars could ever be.

He knew no bounds, but the ones that barked—
The ones that harkened to the darkened sky—
The ones that binded his foot to his eye—
Locked him in his stark room.

I sit, now, on the other side, as trapped as he,
As blue as the bashful sea.
I'll wait forever, even without a key,
Trapped here for eternity.

"That was weird."
"That was fire."

The baleful boys squint at each other, annoyed by their conflicting feelings.

„You boys wouldn't be this invested if you weren't ***bored***."

The pair of delinquents look back at the man, realizing how close they are to him. Without a clue, they scooted closer to him mid-storytelling to hear his gravelly voice better.

„I'm flattered, really, but personal space is much appreciated."

"Oops, my bad," they say, scooting away.
"Oops, my bad," they say, scooting away.

„Hmm… Another story, then?"

"Sure."

'These stories are gas.'

'They kinda are, I can't lie.'

'Do they sound a lil' repetitive to you, though?'

'...Yeah?'

'Lock in the third time. Listen to what he's saying.'

„Well, this last one's a classic in my opinion. Y'all ready for this?"

They eagerly gesture a yes with their hands, excited albeit anxious. The genial gentleman grins, kicking back before allowing his wayward words to fly free.

These walls endlessly repeat.
If they could talk, they'd say nothing.
I'm listening for his pair of feet,
But I can't hear anything.

Someone save me from this living dream—
No, this knave nightmare.
Someone breathe this heart back to life,
So it can beat once again

Like the boy he once knew to be,
The boy who, once, reeked of the sea,
The boy who, once, was blue with glee
And was always dreaming of she.

"She?" Blue wonders, tepidly turning to his wingman.

"..."

"Hm?"

Gabrius, squandering no time at all, is putting his brain to the test. His trains, always stationed, are now back in commission.

"..OOOOOOHHHHHHH. I think I get it now."

„Heh, and they say he don't got a clue."

"No way bro took this long..."

"Wait, wait, so what you're saying is... we're trapped in a loop?"

„Trapped in a loop."

"With nothing going for us?"

„Nothing going for you two, in a much more physical sense. She's a real cruel mistress."

"Huh? Is that the 'she' at the end of the third one?"

"Nah, nah... it can't be that."

The edges of the pages are burning. Suspense hangs in the air, like a cat on a branch. The clickety-clack of the railroad tracks is drowning out the ticking time clocks. Confusion bubbles in their brains, but a conclusion—a destination—has yet to be reached. They're being told something, but what?

The wise old man rolls his right sleeve up, checking totality's time. 'Hah, time's almost up. **Wonder** if they'll figure this out on time—'

"WAIT, were you talking 'bout us in those stories?"

"Like an allegory!"

He's careful about his signaling, albeit immensely impressed by their reasoning. He only smiles to confirm their hypothesis, not wanting the Harrowed Harmony to consume the kids.

Harrowed Harmony: an agreement between [redacted] and [redacted] against dangerous knowledge, and the creator of cognitohazards and infohazards. Even information of its existence is a potential hazard if procured precariously.

Amongst the majority of amelioration, no one knows the true reason for its existence. Only an ancient folk tale came to define its association with and between [redacted] and [redacted].

Different magnitudes of its punishment exist for forbidden knowledge of any kind, the most common one lighting a person's pants on fire. More severe reprimanding takes place for fate-altering insight, available for both receivers and givers of such insight.

The only way around these threats? Naturally progressive learning, of course! It's a grand trick for someone on the receiving end; for the one giving, however…

„The name's Daniel ‚The Nightchaser' Bonhomme, and it's a pleasure having met you meddling two like this!" he jubilantly announces. „I'm rooting for you boys!"

He nobly tips his hat before the Harrowed Harmony can take him Elsewhere. Its ubiquitous gaze sears through space, roaring at the rare, old man. The next time they blink, he's gone without a trace.

"YO—"

"AY PUTA!"

They catch their breath for a moment, awestruck by reality flickering in front of them.

"…Where'd he go?"

"Man, I don't know!"

"Uhh… what are we supposed to do now?"

"Uh… no idea. Maybe…"

"Huh?"

"Uhh… I mean it's your memory, so…"

"So?"

"...if you told me how this memory went before..?"

"Are you asking me to do a lore-drop?"

"Kinda, yeah."

"No, thanks!" Gabrius exclaims, no hesitation needed. He scoots a small distance away from Blue. "We can figure this out without allat..."

"Dude, would you rather be stuck here forever? I got time to kill, but not all of it," he impatiently inquires, inching closer.

"I really don't wanna."

"Please, man?"

"I thought you already saw some of my memories!"

"Only some of them."

"Then that's all you're getting outta me."

"Bro, you don't hafta be so scared all the time!"

"Why? For what reason do I—"

"*BECAUSE*! We're going through this together, or whatever. From the moment I met you, I felt like I could trust you. See you—I could see you. I can finally see someone. I feel like I've known you my entire life..!"

Blue feels as if he might puke from all this seriousness and sincerity. Such a suit is *not* a good fit for him; still, he might try to wear it on important occasions.

"Give me something, though—a sign! I didn't even know if I *should've* gone through with saving your dumbass back then… I just *wanted* to. Don't make me guess again…"

"You legit said that this wasn't that serious."

"I wasn't… thinking, I *guess*," says the stubbornest mule.

"Oh, um—"

"Please, don't make this awkward," Blue pleads. "I know when I'm wrong."

"…"

"So?"

"*Ay caramba*… fine, fine! You want the lore??? I'll give you the lore! I'm gonna make this SUPER short, though."

[…]

A small, petite boy saunters to school, a lengthy, intangible black cape decorating the ground behind him. Arid footing disturbs his every step. Thick waves of heat crash against his frail body. A sickly, artificial star coughs its calculated light onto him.

Antecedens, the planet of primordial peril, traps all under its angry eye—the artificial star.

An excerpt from "Formality at Its Finest's" debriefing on the stars, minutes after [redacted]

Artificial stars are engineered to provide the same energy all the stars once did before disappearing. They've replaced every star in sight, beholding an uncanny beauty that can't quite match their precursor. They perform nuclear fusion on the same level as them, however, and are capable of generating energy tens of times greater than that.

The original concept was patented by "Mad Scientist," with the fuel derived from "Mourning Morningstar" herself. Every other supplier of energy became obsolete due to the ingenuity of the Sovereigns' creation and the flow governed by "Mourning Morningstar." Their only flaw? They feel oddly… watchful.

…

Many refugees seek shelter from the Regalia's brutality through Antecedens, a world even they are reluctant to touch. According to local legends, a monster too powerful to be dealt with resides there, giving it its epithet "the planet of primordial peril."

This lack of visitation from the Regalia, however, only starves the lowly planet of any growth, like a malnutritioned child. In this way, everyone lives in utter chaos and poverty.

Gabrius isn't free of this fate, shackled to it like everyone else. Like everyone else. See, he doesn't wish to be like everyone else. He only wants to live, not as a prisoner of fate, but just live.

His home life, meanwhile, is the bottom of the barrel. Home is the unfamiliar outdoors, whilst the unfamiliar outdoors is home. He looks for home everywhere, finding it anywhere but home.

Everyone thinks the boy aloof for the way he's always looking around.
Everyone sees the boy larking along the shoreline, sometimes further out.
Everyone knows the boy as a lively laughingstock, garnering attention one way or another.

"Gabrius, may you please solve the equation on the board?" the buff math teacher quizzes, tapping on the blackboard. It's something… algebraic?

"Oh, yes… um… So you see, the circumference of the triangle is equivalent to the magnitude of the neutron star's vector when approaching the limit of—"

Everyone roars with **laughter**.

He loves that **laughter**. It's his song—his soul. The stupidity of any action he commits makes them all **laugh**. He feels good—amazing—just from hearing it.

The day never subsides, spilling into the dimly-lit, spring afternoon.

Gabrius and his peers all sit down at a table to rest. They've been feeding soup to the poor for the entire day. Now it's their turn to eat!

He and his friends **laugh** like never before, joking about the day. The meddling boy, however, finds an opportunity to make everyone **laugh**. He readies his subtle attack on the girls across from them, launching a grape at one of their faces.

The girls all scream, wondering who in their right mind would assault them so dubiously.

The troublesome boy innocently whistles, walking away before any of them could accuse him. His friends cry with **laughter**.

Even a while after the disturbance, they're all still **laughing** about it.

Gabrius was already out of mind, though.

They still seem to be having fun **laughing** about it all. Everyone seems to be living just fine without him.

Ha ha, that's pretty humorous, isn't it? To **laugh** without **laughter?**

The **laughter** sways and lurches on the tracks, crusading out the school doors and into the streets. He's curious to see if they'll notice him gone. They don't. He can hear gaggles of people screaming in the distance behind him.

"Why am I still walking?" he asks his legs. They don't reply. "I still need to—"

He turns to the building behind him. That grape launch was good enough for his grand exit of the day. "Ah… nevermind."

He walks away from the school for today, totally tuckered out. His eyes scan the sad-looking streets, searching for any public seating arrangement of sorts; one that doesn't involve entering any kind of fine establishment.

Eventually, he settles for an oak bench, crouching down to finally rest. Making others **laugh** is tough work.

Gabrius, as he's dwelling, hears an approaching fanfare flailing about in the distance. He picks his head up, noticing something. He recognizes those tracks. He's at the Regal asterism, 8th of the total 26.

"Yo, hey, hey!!!" he screeches, waving vigorously at the train. It doesn't stop for him, simply passing him by like one onlooker or another. His arm floats down from its airy stoop, settling like a leaf on the seat.

'If only I were here when the train stopped.'

As a prisoner, he's always teased with escape—a world beyond the iron bars. Those trains that pass by every now and then, they seem fun. They look cool. They could save me.

Liberate me. Those are the little synapses that fire every time he sees one, and **liberation** is his wish.

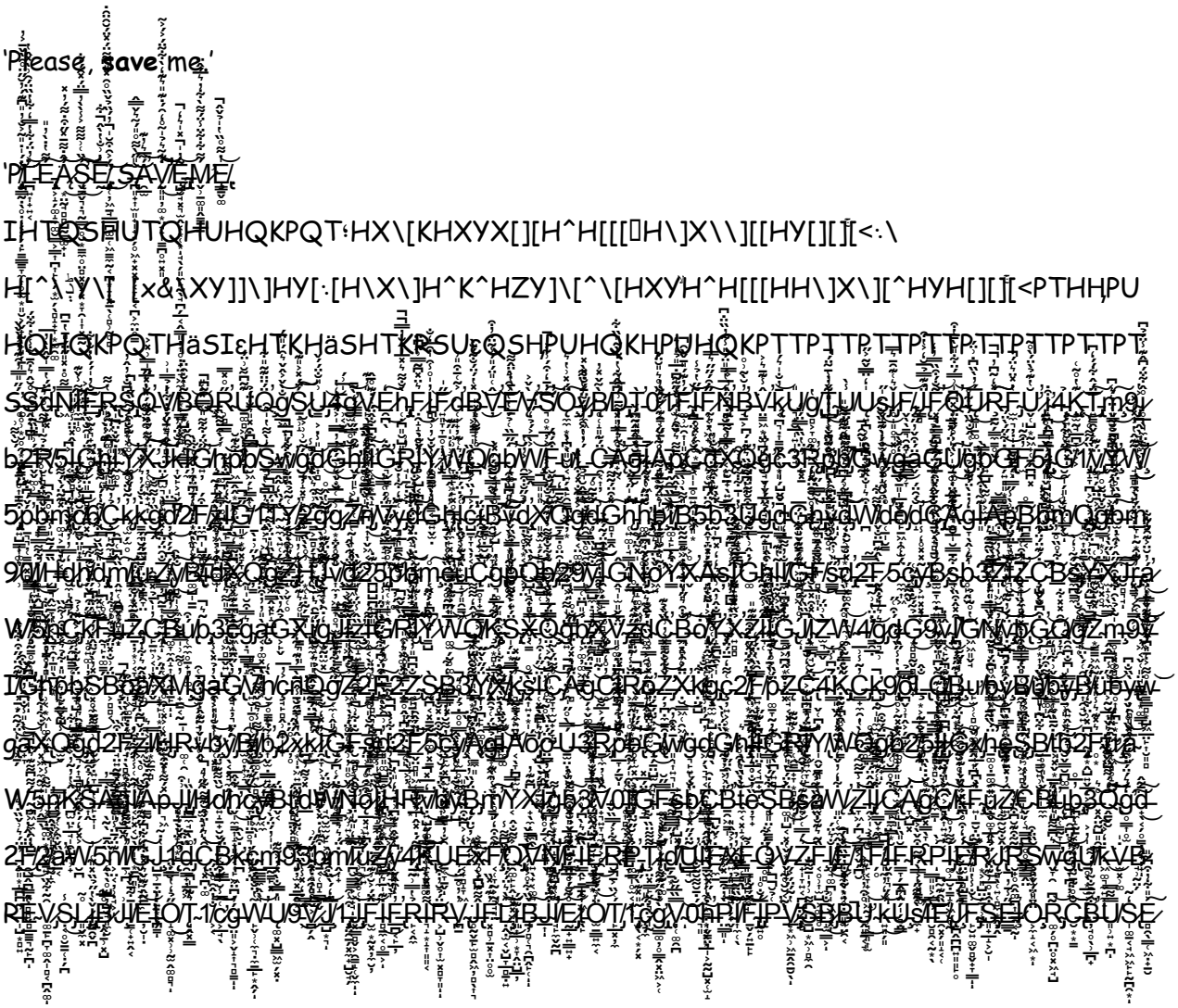
'They could save me.'

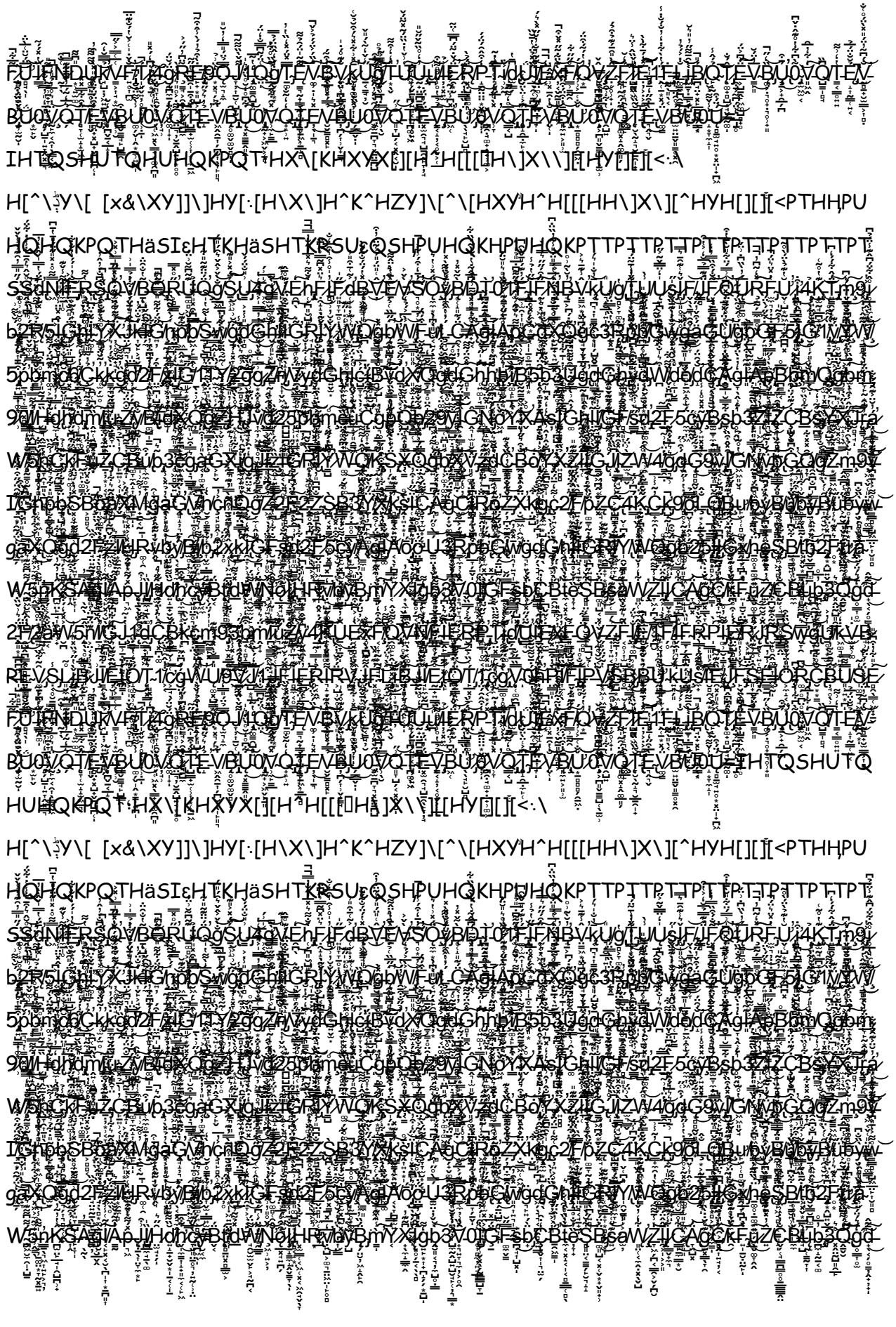
'They could **liberate** me.'

'**Liberate** me.'

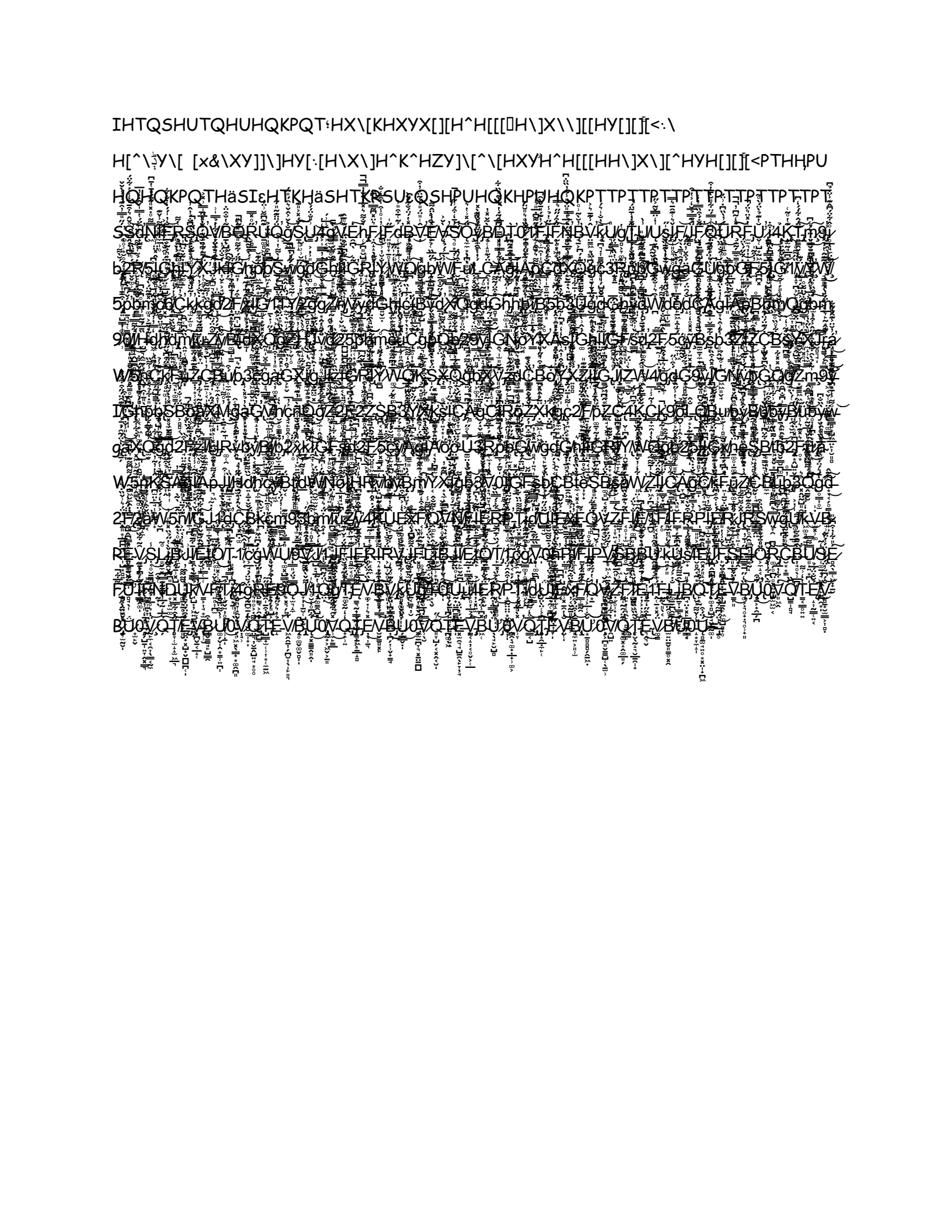
'**Save** me.'

'Please, **save** me.'





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RE VSIJIFJIE1OT1cgWU9VZJ1JFIERIRVJIFIJBJIEZOT1cgVQ5PJFIPVSBBU1kUSIEUFSEHORCBUSE
FU1RNDUJkVFITZtOFERQJ1QgTEVBVkUgFCUJIERPTldUIFxFQVZFIE1FIJBQTEVBU0VQTEV
BU0VQTEVBU0VQTEVBU0VQTEVB



The passing locomotive splits Gabrius's head apart. He clutches his head, ruffling his obscenely long hair.

The sky is dark now. Streetlights are shining. People swarm the lonely station. Most of his belongings are gone.

'Was I out for that long?'

Gabrius struggles to his feet, boarding the local train that has just arrived. It's no constellation connector, but it's still welcome.

The ride home is calm and slow. He couldn't care less about the fistfight to his left, nor the smell of drugs to his right.

Home, at last. The door in front of him creaks open, and he steps a few steps inside. He wishes he could feel relieved, but the sounds of broken glass and the back-and-forth vitriol of two animals are not so inviting. It's an everyday commodity for drowning the noise out in his head, but it's definitely not healthy. Today, he feels particularly fed up with the incessant arguing.

Before leaving, he takes one look at his starving sister, scared and hiding underneath the dining table. She gazes up at him. He takes a few small steps towards her, but backs away.

He throws his backpack into the house and exits as quickly as he entered. He slams the door shut without a whiff of worry in his heart; at least that's what he fools himself with. Nobody has a *clue* of how he really feels.

Nowhere else to go. 'Maybe I'll just hop back on the train.'

The local trains, though dangerous, welcome Gabrius with open arms. Sure, he gets the clothes ripped clean off his back, but it's nothing he hasn't handled before. Surely, he'll be—Wait.

"Huh?" he interjects, a tepid trail traveling down his right cheek.

No, he—I mean—you weren't fine. You were confused. You didn't have a clue. You still don't know the first thing about your own emotions.

And you're acting like you know any better?

Maybe.

Fine, let's go with that.

Gabrius goes from train to train, hoping to find solace somewhere along his journey. It doesn't seem to have boarded the same train as him, however. Perhaps he's been going far too slow with the local routes.

'Maybe I should get on a different train…'

The train comes to an abrupt stop, throwing everyone standing forward. 'An emergency brake?'

Tiny tremors trickling in from the outside, the revolving world more bothered than before. The screams of millions following the tremors kill any semblance of sanity keeping the

people together. That twisted song has a mortifying motif for anyone who knows, the common commotion resounding,

…

"IT'S ***ENTROPY***!"

An excerpt from "Unyielding Heart's" address to the Somnium.

If the Regalia was painted to be the lawful good of the Somnium, then Entropy would be the chaotic evil opposing it. They are the foil of any ordered character.

They are not mice-like rodents, not minor consumers, not tertiary carnivores, nor blasphemous beasts, but eldritch gods of utter ruin.

IT IS OF THE UTMOST IMPORT THAT WE MUST NOT YIELD.
SHIELD YOURSELF BEFORE ALL IS LOST.
THERE IS NO NEED TO FEAR.
ENTROPY IS HERE.

ACT IMMEDIATELY.
HONOR AND GLORY AWAITS.
THE EYES ARE WATCHING.
THE TIME HAS COME.

BEAR YOUR BLOOD WITH OPEN ARMS.

SHED YOUR SKIN AND BONES.
LET THOSE FOLLY THINGS SEEP INTO THE STREETS.
RETURN TO THE DUST YOU ONCE WERE.

JOIN YOUR PAST IN THE INEVITABLE FUTURE.
TAKE THIS KNIFE AND STAB INTO YOUR HEART.
THE UPPER-LEFT CORNER OF YOUR TORSO, PIERCE IT.
JOIN YOUR FRIENDS, YOUR FAMILY, YOUR GOD.

If one is to hear their roaring anthem, then may The Sovereign's spirit bless your soul.

I entreat any unauthorized ameliorites to please refrain from engaging these foul figures of destruction. They know what you love. They know what you fear. You cannot approach them without endangering all other parties associated with you.

Do whatever you must to *retreat*, I *entreat*, I *repeat*.

"Unyielding Heart,"
the Arch-Sovereign

Flashing lights. Trembling earth. Shaky eyes. Bated breaths. Picking fingers. Unstable thoughts. Hot air. Heartbeat in his neck. Everything is a mess. He needs to go. He needs to get out of here.

'I need to… leave.'

Gabrius breaks through a window, hopping out of the halted train.

The city on the horizon is too far to walk towards.

His thoughts race through the rails, though he finds that pocketing them keeps them all alive.

He wheezes through the night as his lungs burn inside, sprinting along the tracks.

He desperately searches for another way to fade into the day—it never subsides.

Out of the blue, a rustling of leaves catches his attention. A thick layer of foliage to his right invites him into its hidden realm.

He dives into the greenery, branches and rocks breaking a few of his bones on the way down. He struggles to his feet, each step like quicksand. He remains crouched to avoid any stray harbingers of Entropy. Fickle flowers tickle his face, though he does his best to ignore them.

"Anybody..?"

But nobody comes.

"..Please?"

But nobody comes.

"…Ugh, what am I doing?"

But Nobody comes.

"Huh? Who are you?" Gabrius calls out, straightening himself.

The moon lays dormant on its blackened bed, its bright blanket pouring over onto the terra-firma floor. It drapes over the tallest tree in Gabrius's vicinity, casting a shadow over the dark figure in the background, just some meters away.

«Who are you..?»

"Um, Gabrius. You?"

The humming of insects drowns out their response. They're too quiet—supremely timid. The winds wind down to give them a chance; even then, the local panic over the invasion could overpower their voice from even a thousand miles away.

"Huh? I couldn't hear you," he says, stepping forward slightly.

The figure shifts backwards. Its body jerks uneasily with each crinkle beneath the peculiar boy's feet. He pauses to think—rarely done by him—and looks down thoughtfully to gather his trains.

'Is it the flowers?' he notices.

He steps aside to avoid the small patch of withered roses, carefully inching his way towards the ethereal threshold.

«You… noticed?»

"I mean, they're right there."

«Ah…» they interject, their tone more amicable than before. A faint, fragile hand—it's of a lady's—reaches from the threshold, beckoning the boy closer; then, it recedes.

"Huh?"

«Don't come any closer…»

"Why not?"

«This is the closest you should be. I'd rather you not see… too much of me.»

"Huh?" he questions. "But you're beautiful."

«Ah… um…»

An awkward, watery dissolution of the soundless atmosphere stirs in this melting pot of thresholds.

[...]

"She was *beautiful*. Like an angel sent from heaven," Gabrius revels.

"Woah. What did you like most 'bout her?"

"Her voice. Super duper sweet and shy, but passionate; like a warm, humble fire."

"Did you ever get her name?"

"Nope. I think I forgot to."

[...]

Booms of boundless energy sentence the ameliorates of Antecedens to death and damnation. Softly-spoken magic spells vie against them, carried by breath and loosely-strung hope. The city in the distance rumbles. Perhaps the longer route was better this time around.

A silent exchange of words blows like a zephyr between Gabrius and the spectator. Everything tells itself through the moonlight, dancing on their sorrowful visages.

'The boy of yore, who failed with faith. It's him, isn't it?' she cogitates.

A petite boy in eight sweaters, despite the unforgiving heat, stands erect before her. His telling eyes turn a tinted blue the closer he is to the headlights of night.

«You… wish for **liberation**.»

"..Huh? Who told you that?"

«The flowers.»

"Excuse me?"

«N-nevermind.»

She crouches down to Gabrius's height to tend to the flowers. His confused expression is crystal clear to her. It's painted a true, blue hue of reflected sky.

«I've met… *one*… like you, before. The same, dead-yet-alive demeanor about him. He, too, seemed special to me.»

"(I'm special?) What happened to him?"

«He… I… I-I'm trying to find him.»

"Oh. How long have you been looking?"

«…»

A reflection of Gabrius quickly passes by her eyes and mouth, tending to the weak soil.

«Too long. Longer than centuries. Maybe millenia… Eons…»

"Um… Do you wanna—"

It's a stupid question. He's just met this person. Yet, it feels like he's known them for… *forever*. Maybe…

"—find *him* together?"

Of course, he's not so set on traveling so swiftly. Yet, he feels this change in his slow life is necessary. 'I need to lock in…'

«Hm..?»

Just maybe…

"Sorry, I feel like I've known you my whole life, but not in a romantic way or anything."

He could…

«That's odd. I can feel that as well…»

Make this ride less ***boring***.

[...]

"That's the *deepest* you've ever been, kid."

"Pause."

"Don't backtrack and be immature now, big boy. We *need* to get to the bottom of this."

[...]

Antecedens, although an ashtray of ameliorites, is seen as a haven by the rest of the Somnium for its lack of contact with the Regalia. The community knows, though, how

terrible it really is. Worst part: nothing returns from the planet's bowels. No escape has ever been documented to date. The constellation connectors *never* stop at Antecedens.

«I might like to leave…»

"Oh, cool," he coolly replies, hiding his excitement. "Uhh… I dunno how to leave, to be honest."

«Oh, that's not an issue.»

"Really?"

«Of course. The real challenge lies between your ears, behind your eyes.»

"Huh? I'm not good at riddles, lady. I almost failed my reading class."

«Don't worry, then. You'll know when every domino falls into place.»

Her shadowy figure grows from the withered roses, feeling comfortable to finally show herself to Gabrius. She's well over twice as tall as the boy.

«Dance with Fire, and you'll get burnt. Remember that.»

"Oh, okay..?"

The moonlit lady flashes a small smile at the belligerent boy. Roses wilt beneath her feet, pointing towards Entropy's march.

«I should protect this planet one last time before departing, shouldn't I?»

"Protect?"

«Mhm. I do, really, owe this place some space from Entropy, after housing me so warmly; like wood fed to a fire.»

An excerpt from "Acting Overseer of Creation's" epic poem Chasing Hearts.

She climbs the cityscape, that Watchmaker
Resting on each wonder of this world
Hiding in every flashing light
Wheezing through the blurry night

A rose in the metal jungle, that Watchmaker
Growing through the concrete
Fearing nothing but themselves
Sweeping worry off the shelves

Anticipate the best with them
Antecedens is blessed with them
For though she's an ancient rabblerouser
She's the kindest of any lone star up there

The ticking that turns heads
The Watchmaker of such unrest

Time dances on her moonlit hands

To just once play hooky with Fire

A particular poem wraps around Gabrius's ears like a worm, searing through his arid skin like a fire ant. 'Is she—no, that can't be it…'

"Go do what you need to, then. I'll just wait," Gabrius shrugs.

The fair lady bows before the boy, quietly thanking him for all he's given rise to—there, then, and now.

As flickering as the fast moonlight, she escapes into the atmosphere.

Gabrius follows her lightspeed trajectory for as long as he can before shaking his head, perfectly dazzled by her radiance. 'I needa find a way outta here…'

Gabrius sighs, kicking at the ground. He's stumped, but not totally lost. To him, it isn't worth it to use ***that***, yet.

[...]

"Even with everything happening, that singular moment… it felt… so *peaceful*," Gabrius remembers.

"Definitely," Blue smiles, nodding. "Honestly, the way you talked about them makes them sound like a… ***Sovereign***? Is that what they're called?"

"Yeah. Did you just learn that on Nunc?"

"Yup. I have no idea who they are, though."

"Well, I dunno, but I don't really think she's a Sovereign," Gabrius frowns. They're not really… a *nice* group of people."

"Do you know 'em like that?"

"Nah, but everyone sees them… like—"

"Cold? Cruel? Buttfaces?"

"I guess, yeah."

{*On ne voit bien qu'avec le cœur...*}

At the edge of the ancient city rests "Unyielding Heart." His perpendicular mind shifts uneasily. His knee shakes as his left heel kisses the ground, over and over again.

«Argento.»

"Yes, my lord?" the suzerain responds, lightning-fast. **【Noble "*Ardent Agent of Gray*" bows dutifully to his lord.】**

«Wherefore—»

"Let me stop you right there, sir. Remember: small words speak louder than big words."

«Right, right…»

"Do as we practiced. Breathe in, breathe out, and recite the sequence."

«*Smmmm… haaaa… smmmm… haaa…* 0, 1… *smmmm…* 1, 2… *haaaa…* 3, 5, 8.»

"Good show, my lord. Now, you may continue."

«Have you heard any word on why the meeting is still adjourned?»

"Unfortunately not, my lord."

«Goodness gracious. You'd think someone died with this lengthy of a—»

"Excuse me, but I've just received word that Regulus has… been murdered."

«I should really shut my mouth. *Hmmm…*»

Paragon meditates on the alarming news served on his plate. His best friend is dead. What is he to do with such sudden information?

«Any indication of who committed the crime?»

"No, but I'm almost certain it was—"

«Yes, of course it was her. Thank you.»

He breaks his meditation, his aura completely contrasting that of what just was. Pure, unadulterated anger exclusively encompasses his eyes, but nothing more.

«This anarchy will not stand. I'll fix this mess up if Ord decides to sit still, like a lame duck.»

"Of course, my lord."

«Speaking of duck, I'm craving some food. Can we get takeout?»

"...Of course, my lord. Which planet?"

«Not sure. We'll figure it out after the meeting.»

"My lord, if you are so distraught as to ignore your dear friend's death, I suggest we talk—"

«Prithee, humor me this once, Argento.»

"..."

«Ahem, *please*.»

"..Of course, my lord."

An excerpt from "Unyielding Heart's" private conversation with "Ardent Agent of Gray."

"You know… you never really told me how you two met, my lord."

«Ah, we go a ways back. I do not wish to monologue into an unforeseen tangent, however.»

"Oh, but there's no harm in a long chat between us. You have time to kill before the big meeting, anyhow."

«Hm, I guess so.»

"Mm, so?"

«Ah… I was visiting the greenhouse when I met him.»

"First impressions?"

«Just another stubborn, selfish Sovereign—like me.»

"I see. You should elaborate more."

«Am I being interviewed, or something?»

"No, though this will be documented. I simply wish to help you speak your mind more often."

«…»

"You need help, Paragon—excuse me for speaking out of line. Of all the Sovereigns, you're the only one concerning themself so heavily with Entropy."

«Regulus, too, certainly. He's been handling the entire load of legislation recently, with the events of so many Supernovas.»

"His eyes seem heavier these days, yes…"

«Hm! I remember when they were heavier, and we'd resort to adolescent misgivings. Once upon a blue moon, when I'd lower my Sovereignty and partake in recreational inebriation—»

"Remember, my lord. Small words speak louder than big words."

«*Ahem*. Every so often, when I'd lower my guard and go out for drinks, I'd always see Regulus there waiting for me. It was strange how he always knew when to meet me there.»

"Does he, supposedly, not go every day?"

«No, he'd only go when I go. I *suppose* he was able to pay close attention to—keep tabs on, really—my personal affairs.»

"He was quite the busy bee, though."

«Precisely; yet, he still went out of his way to take good care of me on my worst days. That is simply how he is with all of his good friends, really. It's admirable. It's what inspired me to be a better person.»

{*L'essentiel est invisible pour les yeux.*}

"You never know, though."

"It's whatever. Not the point, anyways."

[...]

«Leave these lovely people alone, Lethe,» the moonlit lady says, leering at her adversary.**【Princesa "Saintly Scribe" holds a protective hand over Antecedens.】**

«You flee from the ancient city and pronounce yourself dead, all to simply hide away like this? O' primordial peril, how far you've fallen.»**【Auger "Forgotten Flower" bitterly mocks their former colleague.】**

«What's with your jargon, old friend? You never, once, spoke like this to me, nor have you ever ignored my real name.»

«It'll be nothing but dust in a moment's time.»

Phase 3: Recitative

Total ruination. That was the status quo

of these kings and queens, whose real names have been long forgotten.

An excerpt from "The Director's" monograph, The Machinations of the Mysterious Mind.

Sovereigns. They are a specific breed of **amelioration**[1] that possesses greater capabilities than 98% of the masses, all across the Somnium. To be classified as one, however, one must meet three criteria.

For one, their Milieu must be above 80% in terms of **veritability**[2]. A canvas must be of the finest material to receive an absolute masterpiece, after all.

Additionally, their Resin must be above 50% in terms of veritability. A picture's paint must be supremely pristine in every step of the way, whether it be concerning the paint itself or the technique imbued within.

Finally, their Sol **must** be of a path 100% unique to them. A masterpiece is only a masterpiece when it is the only one of its variety.

It is for these three reasons alone that all other ameliorites pale before the stars, whereas Sovereigns have a chance of dancing with them in a spectral pantomime.

---

[1] The general term for all peoples of the Somnium
[2] The threshold of total power (which will never be fully found)

These beings have relinquished their **true** names in order to participate in such a dance, as anything one may observe regarding their "real" names is only an amicable alias. Codenames such as "Calliope" or "Lethe" reflect this principle heavily; half-symbolic at most, but are throwaways at the very least of what is to be expected.

In the case that two or more of these larger than life figures were to clash, then it would spell absolute disaster for any onlooker involved. Only ruins would be left after a battle of such epic proportion.

Elements explode in the air like fireworks, flowing water clashing against raging fire. Their chromatic confetti rains down from the sky, a chaotic party overtaking the scene. The chant of Entropy creates fear, but the cry of the poor creates hope.

A dragon-shaped mirage of water closes in on the moonlit lady, though she quickly responds with a fiery tiger.

«Gaze upon the ruination of your new home, primordial peril,» Lethe mocks.

«It isn't over yet, and *quit* calling me that!»

Lethe flicks her wrist, casting a tidal wave of nature's tears to sweep over the landscape. The scribe stomps on the terrain, opening the ground up to wipe the flood of tears away. She swiftly seals the crack back up, pulling both ends of the ground together.

«You haven't lost your strength, I see.»

«My true strength was more vocal, so it isn't wrong to say—»

«Goodness, I always hated when you'd ramble on endlessly!»

«Oh, I thought you enjoyed that,» the scribe says, somewhat sad.

Lethe lashes out with a quick burst of retaliation, launching a geyser of steaming, streaming water at her foe. The calmly-composed lady whispers an incantation under her bated breaths, splitting the beam in half before it can reach her.

Each attack, the scribe shows an exceedingly creative and elegant solution to. It's as clear as day to anyone watching that "Forgotten Flower" is growing increasingly impatient.

«You know you can't beat me in a battle of endurance, don't you?» "Saintly Scribe" sweetly comments.

«I just wanted to see if I could beat you in a fair fight, but I guess that is… *still*… implausible.»

Lethe shoots a ball of energy at the civilians watching, though the scribe immediately intercepts it.

«You're too easy sometimes,» the Auger comments, catching the fair lady off guard. Her hand grips onto the scribe's arm, locking her in place.

«You—»

『Lethe's *αβιιιτψ*, "Oblivion," *λας βεεη αςτινατεδ*.』

«I finally won for a change… hm?»

『*Cαωιθρε's αβιιιτψ*, "Versed Vindication," *λας βεεη αςτινατεδ*.』

«So that's what forgetting feels like… That did quite a bit of damage,» the scribe sputters.

«Calliope, you're.. crazy!»

«Creative, but not crazy. If you wish to see <crazy,> I don't mind showing you.»

Speed: Calliope, out of every Sovereign, has taken it the most seriously. None of her powers rely on anything else besides it. Calliope phases into position, appearing behind Lethe. She kicks her into the boundless sky, sending her crashing into Antecedens's moon.

«You were once a great Sovereign, Calliope. Why did you hide away after achieving such glory?»

Calliope lands on the rocky terrain before her adversary, readying another incantation. Lethe attempts to throw Calliope off her groove, but every attack of hers is evaded easily.

«We were getting too ahead of ourselves. We're nowhere near *gods*, so why should we, as powerless as we are, pretend to be? It just doesn't make sense.»

Lethe disappears into the empty space above, hurling a comet at the scribe.

«What doesn't make sense about wanting more power?! We all felt powerless after [redacted]!»

The comet explodes into snow, as Lethe flies behind it with both fists in front and aiming towards Calliope. The cheeky Calliope sidesteps it, grabbing her friend's leg from behind and swinging her around 'till the Auger puked. Then, throwing her to the nearest mountain, she appears above Lethe.

«All of our experiments towards reinforcing the Somnium and our own security… I realized they all meant something *much* more sinister than what Ord declared. It was unholy, what was really sought out for. It was **Nova's** cruel curiosity.»

«Don't blame this on Nova. Your fears of transience shouldn't fall on her!»

Lethe bursts forth from her stony hole, throwing a sharp hand blade at Calliope. The blow is barely glanced, though it does some kind of damage.

«Don't you know? They were lying to us! The Regalia forgot everything about order, and cast it all aside for some… sick, sacrificial worship!»

«I haven't a clue of what you're yammering about now, but I already abandoned the Regalia if it makes you feel any better.»

«What?»

Calliope takes a quick kick to her stomach, too surprised to react.

«I had a bad feeling about *everything* the moment you left. I blamed it mostly on you, and vowed I'd find you one day for twisting my mind like that, but now… *haha*… you have such a holy way with your words. I don't even know what to believe in anymore.»

«Is that what turned you into an Auger?»

«Maybe, though I'm not very sure. A part of me has forgotten what I truly wanted in becoming this <monster.>»

«Perhaps it is time to set your sword down, and contemplate all thus far—to take a well-deserved break.»

«As much as I want to… I have a promise to fulfill. I've pledged my heart to a different faction now, and soon, you'll be one with it as well.»

A bright, vine-like pattern spreads with a viral rapidity from Calliope arm, from the spot Lethe touched. It moves down her legs and up her torso, every line reconvening at her heart.

«F-from whom did you accrue these powers..?»

«You'll know in time. Hopefully THEY accept you.»

«These cheap tricks… won't work on me!»

The scribe swiftly shoots an energy bullet at the flower, though it is too weak to inflict any pain.

«Checkmate,» Lethe victoriously announces. She readies up her right arm, revving it up to deliver an earth-shaking straight to Calliope's chest, which sends her hurdling back down into Antecedens.

Gabrius trudges his way uphill, out of the thick foliage from where he found Calliope. He's all caught up in cooking up ideas for escape.

'Maybe I could stand in front of the train…'

From his peripherals, he spots her amidst the foggy atmosphere, almost mistaking her for a meteor.

"EVERYONE, GET OUT OF HERE!" he yells to the bystanders in the vicinity.

Her body boisterously impacts with the arid terrain, creating a crater larger than 100 meters in diameter. Without wasting a second, she shoots back up to fend off Lethe. Their battle rages on across the entire planet, though Calliope pours most of her efforts into avoiding collateral damage.

Gabrius joins the spectators in their observing of the two Sovereigns' clash.

"She's losing," he mutters to himself. What did he expect, though? For all of this to be smooth sailing? No, it was never that way in the first place, regrettably so.

He glances over his shoulder to see complete ruination, the city melted like ice cream and scrambled like an omelette. Massacred carcasses paint the cityscape, blood spilling from their bodies and seeping into the brimstone.

Seas of Entropic invaders line the streets and skies, perpetuating their destruction of every semblance of order that Antecedens once held as tithing to the cosmos. Nothing but regret returns to shade Gabrius's fear-filled expression. He swears he can make out what was once the outline of his school buried within the chaos, but he can't bring himself to look.

A faint, blue emission ebbs from his heart and flows through his veins and arteries. His blood tastes like the sweet, slightly sour laughter of every regretful soul around him, dead and alive.

An excerpt from "The Director's" monograph, The Machinations of the Mysterious Mind.

Everyone awakens their Sol somehow, someway. Every experience derives from different expressions of one's own existence, giving each Sol a different flavor; in fact, surveys show that one is guaranteed to taste such in their blood thenceforth.

This presumably acts as an immense indicator towards the name of one's Sol, yet it is still up to one to figure that name out for themselves.

What allows one to use their Sol to any degree, however, would be how truly one trust and/or recognizes oneself. Even the smallest, most subconscious effort to know—to verify—onself would result in an explosive expression of existence; of power.

The vine-like pattern grows on Calliope, restricting her movements more and more. Her will to fight Entropy becomes less and less. Her breaths grow erratic and worried.

«You'll be convinced in carrying out her plan from the moment you are enlightened by her emblem. Don't worry.»

«We shouldn't play into their games, Lethe! The higher powers, they—»

«Know far better than any of us.»

Meanwhile, Gabrius's heart beats with **Liberation**. He's eager to leave this planet, and to push the past aside; the latent avenue—la rue de l'avenir—awaits.

Yet, he still wants to help the mysterious lady. He wants to remember whatever he knows about her, and he wants to know whatever she seems to know about him, 'but I can't do that if she's *this* cooked!'

'Damn… How am I gonna—'

Every domino in his mind palace falls into perfect placement; henceforth, he makes up his **deliberation**. His heart beats with **regret**, that familiar hymn of **liberation** staining the starless sky.

'—fix this mess?'

[...]

"I literally forgot everything after that. Just blurry memories," Gabrius shrugs.

"Do you remember… uh… going to Nunc?"

"A little. Me and her mostly did what me and you did before, like exploring and stuff. I don't think we found who she was looking for."

"So that's why you guys went to Semper?"

"Yeah… Yeah? Actually, how did I end up in Semper..?"

"You're so geeked! How do you not remember?!"

"It's coming—pause…"

"Mhm…"

"Whatever, it's not important. I'm just tryna remember what we actually did on Nunc…"

"Hurry up, bro."

"...Okay, I deadass wasn't believing that guy from earlier, but I kinda am now. I thought he was high or something."

"I kinda was. If it helps, you should too."

"Now that I think about it…"

"Uh-huh..?"

"I don't…"

"Hmm???"

"...remember leaving Il Rifugio.. with her."

{*On ne voit bien qu'avec le cœur...*}

Calliope pants heavily, collapsing to the floor and crying. The aftermath of an intense argument hangs in the air. The atmosphere grows thicker with every step Gabrius takes, away from her.

Calliope shivers within the bosom of the undying mirage, her body entangled by an eerie emblem of THEIR Authority.

Gabrius has been lured away from her discretely, small manifestations of Chaos beckoning him over into the horizon's trap.

She is all alone, and by herself. She dislikes this. She hates this. She thought this feeling would be gone by now, after having some kind of company. She's been deceived by her own emotions. She feels like she's been punished by the world for even trying to remedy her sadness. She **regrets** ever trying.

Negativity takes her over, and an unseen force of nature bores a hole into her heart. The vine-like pattern grows in a frenzy, slipping through that opening and providing her with profound "enlightenment."

//Hello, Calliope. Once the radiant refrain, but from now on the cruel collector. Chaos is pleased to make your acquaintance.//

An excerpt from "The Director's Shadow's" monograph, The Mechanism.

Cosmos means order. Order is what we can control.

Chaos… is a means of order we cannot control. To the demon that can see order in chaos, they are not like us. To THEM, chaos is "order," and they are only adding to our "order" in their mind. To us, it is death.

Control, that warm feeling of enthalpy, leaves her fingertips. An overwhelming voice of ostensible monotony seals her in an icy tomb of THEIR logic. She can't help but want to follow THEIR wishes.

A darkened hue of blue washes over her, renewing her once keen sense of creativity, as it slowly becomes THEIR creativity.

Every characteristic once held true to Calliope… it is THEIRS, now and forever.

In turn, THEIR stuff floods her headspace. Everything. Yet, it feels like nothing.

Calliope can only watch as Gabrius is led into a trap. She tries to scream out to him, but it's already too late. The extraction process has already begun. It has begun: the beginning of the end.

[And, years of imprisonment later…]

The invisible rampart recedes, still keeping a keen gaze on everywhere that is anywhere.

«How troublesome…» Calliope comments, commencing forth with the livestream. She silently trails the two goofballs' tracks, slurring a bit in her words and actions while working with the broadcast.

〖*Cαωiθρε's αβiωiτψ*, "Versed Vindication," *λαs βεεη αχτiνατεδ*.〗

«***AGH!***» Calliope cries out, falling to the floor. She ends the livestream immediately, thinking it was finally being moderated by the Regalia; then, she looks at her own hands suspiciously, realizing something.

«What… am I still doing here?»

She rubs her eyes with her palms, revealing a monstrous entanglement of wires and circuitry to hers and Gabrius's bodies. She wrings her arms out, struggling against her shackles, but to no avail. She sighs, staring at her arms, noticing the complete emblem on them.

«Damn it…»

This is the true Il Rifugio. A tower of technology, designed to deceive, encompassing almost all of Nunc—far beyond Vorra (FIX ACCENT LATER) City. Nothing more, nothing less. Nothing returns.

'I was profiling those two goofballs with the algorithms before losing consciousness, wasn't I?'

She closes her eyes, trying to recall the algorithms. The algorithms contain information of everyone who's stepped foot within Nunc. 'Blue didn't show up on them. Just who is that rascal? He might be—no, that wouldn't make any sense…'

Her eyes sift through the seas of information, all procured for the purpose of luring people into Il Rifugio. No one knows what exactly it does. It simply consumes without any apparent reason.

'THEY've pitted us against each other to throw us off track; THEY're smart, but not smart enough; though, I can only hope those boys aren't pitted against each other in the future.'

She searches for Gabrius and Blue profiles, finding that they are still trapped in Il Rifugio.

'Sol levels are lowering, Milieu and Resin fluctuating. This is one hot mess…'

Maybe the coding could give Calliope an answer, but she can only decipher the most glaring part of it. Electron displacement and control was always Nova's forte (fix accent here later), but Calliope's understanding was too unfounded to deal with it.

'No solutions for this loop. Is it meant to be executed indefinitely? Wait…'

There is one singular conditional for a breakthrough in the code. She can't believe her eyes. ***Sol***. She flips through her mental diary of this entire trainwreck to see if her current realizations match with that of those she'd already written down (and possibly forgotten). 'This is one ***sick*** experiment, even for you, Nova. This isn't worth it at all!'

Her body reflexively shrinks to the interruptive crackle of thunder from outside. The planetary storm outside of Il Rifugio roars ominously. It was the very storm il Rifugio was meant to serve as protection against, yet the refuge itself is now its own battlefield.

An excerpt from "Saintly Scribe's" eighth entry regarding Nunc.

I've figured it out. The constant crescendo of roaring in the back of my mind… it's what lies beyond.

Nunc must be some kind of testing grounds for new technology, but I can't pinpoint exactly who just yet. It could be the Regalia and their Enthalpy, or the Boorish and their Entropy. They're too far together in alignment to even tell nowadays.

Now, for what lies beyond, I'm not sure. I've only heard local legends, entailing a massive storm—a rumbling—that Il Rifugio serves as refuge from. No wonder why it was so monstrously built.

Anyone can hear it from anywhere within its simulation. It is notable that all those that were in favor of such tall tales were dismissed for their "insanity," but I'll bet my eye on their sanity.

…Isn't it poetic, this catastrophe? A means of refuge is now a decadent prison.

«I need to tell them; we were stuck from the start—!»

『*Cαωiθρε's αβiωitψ*, "Versed Vindication," *λας βεεη* de*αςτiνατεδ*.』

«***HRK!***»

Calliope falls to the floor again, succumbing to THEIR Authority. No amount of history with oneself can defeat it, no matter the amount of time or effort inputted. All of those rich "lives" fare as well as nothing against THEIR totality.

//On second (or whichever iteration this is) thought, honestly, you're a large liability. As much as I want to regain my control over you, I've seen how you've been struggling to believe in me and what I do for this "world." Is it that remnant of him you were blessed with, perchance? Ah, it doesn't matter! I might as well get rid of you right now.//

«What?»

It's only a voice, but it holds complete control over her. Complete Authority. A completed Authority. Tears well up in Calliope's throat. She feels like a child that's been caught red-handed. She didn't know she was still being listened to.

Calliope's body stands of her own volition, but by only the smallest bit of her will. THEY can exploit it, as long as it exists.

«Ahem, Your Highness, please. This isn't necessary. If you aren't happy with my results, then—»

//That isn't what I'm worrying about.//

It saunters to the nearest, tallest building in the area, which just so happens to be "Il Rifugio." It is a fake, although it faintly resembles the real one that Calliope documented in her entries.

Calliope can detect the seriousness in THEIR voice. All formalities completely drop.

«Please, don't do this…»

Next thing she knows, her view is consumed by Vorra (FIX THE ACCENT LATER) City. Everything seems so little from so high up. Everything becomes so insignificant. 'Maybe this is how THEY feel.'

All she can see is Vorra City and its ant-like inhabitants. She can only **regret** what has led up to this point. 'If only I didn't… yell at him like that.'

//You won't feel a thing, Calliope, so stop resisting. You're only going to sleep for now. You'll wake up in the next iteration.//

Her left foot hangs over the edge of the ledge.
Her left foot hangs over the edge of the ledge.
Her left foot hangs over the edge of the ledge.

«No, please, I swear I won't—»

//Shh, sleep now, child of light.//

Her right foot moves to the left, shaking with fear.

Her right foot moves to the left, shaking with fear.

Her right foot moves to the left, shaking with fear.

«You're making a big mistake, here! This won't end well for—»

//Shh, that's alright, Calliope. I'll take it from here. Thank you for all of your help. Rest now. I'll be borrowing your body soon.//

…

'And, in a way, this was all my fault. It's all my fault. Oh god, I can number all my bones.'

'It hurts so much.'

'It hurts.'

THEY took away my Sovereignty.'

'No wonder why this stings so badly.'

'...'

'I didn't mean to hurt any of you.'

'Please forgive me, Blue.'

'Please forgive me, Gabrius.'

'I didn't mean those things I said to you, on that day.'

'I'm so sorry.'

'I shouldn't have teased you…

with who you once were.'

{*L'essentiel est invisible pour les yeux.*}

"You're kidding."

"Nah, I'm actually not."

"Is that why you're always so… *mopey*? Your one chance of escape is gone, so—"

"I stopped thinking about it a while ago, so you can shut up.."

"My bad, was tryna be smart for once."

"Whatever. Anyways, you have a plan now, or..?"

"Let me cook, hold on," Blue confidently asserts. He rubs his head, starting his thought machine up like some old computer.

"We've been waiting for waaayyy too long here. I'm getting bored."

"I mean, I kinda hoped to enjoy this ride (with you) after all that thinking we just did. I don't mind staying here a lil' longer if you wanna chill and stuff."

"I don't mind either, but I'd rather we do something at the same time if we're chilling here. Wait, is that why you were so calm the entire time?"

"Probably. This train is just me for real."

"Y'know, that's relatable," Gabrius smiles, melting like ice cream into his seat.

"Why, 'cause people called you 'Lagtrain?'" Blue giggles, melting like ice cream into his seat.

"Yeah. They weren't wrong, though."

"Yeah. Yo, it'd be kinda fire if we used this time to yap. That Daniel guy got me in the mood."

"True; it's crazy, though."

"What?"

"I was so worried about what the old dude was trying to tell us, but…"

"But..? (Haha, butt)."

"Um… is it okay if I get a *little* corny? You don't hafta listen, but… um… you made me wanna yap too," Gabrius shyly requests, looking down at his feet.

"Of course, bro. Go ahead."

"So like… I don't know, it's just.. recently, I've been wanting to slow down and chill with you, since you're kinda my best buddy; everything's been getting in the way, though."

"Yeah, it's so annoying!"

"Haha, yeah. Dude, I used to think you were getting more bored of me the more we hung out, but… like.. I guess you being goofy doesn't really mean allat, huh?"

"Obviously. You think I act funny 'cause I wanna?"

"Not anymore, nah. It's kinda cool though."

"What, my attitude?"

"Nah, how at peace you are, even when you aren't. Like, you care so much about everyone else, but you're also forgetting to take care of yourself. You're just me, to be honest."

"Yeah, that's fair. We'd probably be twins if I was your age, even though I lowkey forgot how old I am. There is one difference 'cause of that, though."

"What?"

"You use Laughter to make yourself feel better. I use it to make sure everyone ends up laughing. Not roasting you, just wanted to say."

"But you're not wrong, and that lowkey makes sense. I was wondering how you copied my **Boundaries** with **Laughter**. I'll probably be moving the way you do when I'm older."

『Keywords have been detected by Il Rifugio! Awaiting secondary keyword, break function potentiality in execution…』

Blue smacks his forehead with moderate strength, trying to quiet whatever voice is interrupting Gabrius. "As long as you're still being yourself, sure, bro."

"Sure, bro."

The system of the mechanism awaits orders from Gabrius and Blue, having heard their Sols' names.

"Bro, I feel like we're so close to escpaing. Lowkey, it'd be better if we could just ***restart***, so we know what to do—"

Coincidentally, in that moment, the train's engine roars, the futuristic ensemble of unknown machinery thundering forth. It shakes with power, traveling at breakneck speeds, soaring through the sky like a shooting star. 'There better be a good explanation for this…'

"*SHIT*, WE'RE GONNA—"

"OH SHOEZ—"

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Gabrius's alertness reconvenes without a moment's notice.

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They continue their roundabout journey, the lady of their interest showing up on cue every repeat of the memory. Her placement in this memory is bizarre to the two, however. The only piece of evidence to prove them right was her style of clothing, such being different from the others'.

"Her face is really pretty…"

"Her ass is—"

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"—[redacted]!"

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"And her [redacted] are [redacted]! I wish I could [redacted] the [redacted] out of those [redacted]."

Blue's face remains stagnant. The vulgarity passes through one ear and out the other. Sure, he might be thinking the same, but he has enough shame to know better.

'Wait… What if… I use this to get us outta here?'

Blue stops in his tracks, inspecting Gabrius. Gabrius sweats profusely, confused by the lack of distance between them.

"Huh?"

"Hold on."

『*Ψθμ αγε αβιε τθ μσε τλε σκιιι "Cθησρεςτμς."*』

'Woah, what the yo?'

A small informational window pops up before Blue's bewildered eyes. It details every basic snippet of information he must know about his trusty friend, Gabrius, here.

『Gabrius: The Liberated Loneliness, and the nascent pathway for "Laughter" to be paved. Rumor has it that he is one of the sketches for Catastrophic Colors, and numerous efforts for him to be erased/killed have been made. [redacted] —』

[...]

'What if we're stuck? Damn, where do we go from here..?'
'Damn, where do we go from here..? What if we're stuck?'

They both look at each other oddly, assessing each other's faces intently. It'd be gay to them if they weren't so queasy from a strange feeling of… dread.

'...'
'...'

They both instinctively look to the side, expecting someone to confront them about their out-of-place behavior. No one appears, however. Their eyes end up lingering on an empty seat.

"You should lore drop."

"Why?"

"It's gettin' way too quiet. Also, we kinda need material for an escape plan out of YOUR memories, so…"

"Fine, but—"

[...]

"You're kidding."

"Nah, I'm actually not."

"Is that why you're always so… *mopey*? Your one chance of escape is gone, so—"

"I stopped thinking about it a while ago, so you can shut up—"

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"*SHIT*, WE'RE GONNA—"

"OH SHOEZ—"

"*AAAA

Blue howls with laughter, in pure hysteria. He, too, is in the same pain. Withal, he couldn't care less, and continues to laugh at Gabrius.

Plop.

A droplet of water resounds throughout the nothingness. It instantly catches Blue's attention. Right, they were just fighting an angel; so, where were they?

Cessation.

Gabrius's alertness reconvenes without a moment's notice.

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'A… train station?'

'Oh nah…'

[…]

"Gabe?"

"Yeah?"

"Doesn't it feel kinda weird to you?"

"Huh?"

"Like… we're going nowhere?"

Phase 4: Second Intermezzo

[...]

"*AAAA

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'A… train station?'

'Oh nah…'

Gabrius recognizes this place—this memory. He tries to turn from the shore to run, but his body is stuck in place.

Their bodies act autonomously as they board the transport. The moment they're seated, the train bolts forward. Peeking outside, they see a thick fog tucking the world outside the windows into an ominous blanket.

Gabrius's eyes are bloodshot.

Blue's blood boils for no apparent reason.

From the intense silence, they can hear each other's thoughts.

'Fuck.'

'You alright?'

'Naw… GET ME OUT OF HERE!'

The midnight moon looms over all. Its watchful eye petrifies Gabrius. Though, what scares him more is Blue's.

Sweat trickles down his forehead, traveling down to his chin. It plops onto his thigh from on high. His arms fight for control so that he may rip his own throat out, but the mighty memory paralyzes him far too painfully.

'Are we cooked?'

'Nah, just me…'

Blue stifles another one of his odious giggles, having some respect for Gabrius's manic moment.

'Where are we?'

'Aboard the Constellation Complex. Specifically, the Incola Lucia constellation family. Specifically, the Auctus constellation. Specifically in the Iridium division. Specifically in the Argent Luisant district. Specifically, the Lotus Lake—'

'OKAY, SHUT UP.'

An excerpt from "Mourning Morningstar's" monograph, Navigation Nightmare.

When it comes to crossing the cosmos, the main form of transportation sought by the masses is the Regalia's transit, otherwise known as the Constellation Complex. Each "constellation" within the Constellation Complex is given its own visual and nominative distinction. Afterwards, one is assigned to each multiverse.

Of course, constellations have their own inner workings; therein, they branch off into different lines across universes, galaxies, solar systems, planets, etc. 'Till the present moment, no single Sovereign can fully navigate the conundrum that is the modern Constellation Complex besides Princesa "Mourning Morningstar" (I am tooting my own horn, haha).

Each constellations' trains are known as constellation connectors, and travel at impossible speeds. It's documented that they're capable of ignoring any obstacles, even escaping black holes on several occasions.

From asterism—the official term for their stations—to asterism they travel, and throughout the Somnium they go. Trillions of connectors exist in a single constellation, and the convolution of the routes is as abundant as the routes themselves.

Of course, there are certain limitations to the abundance of the Constellation Complex. Special railroad lines are required to go the distance between ensembles (groups of multiverses), as well as special passes to board them.

As Gabrius yaps about the staggering scope of the Constellation Complex, Blue zones out and glances around the carriage. He's still listening with half an ear, just to be nice.

Eventually, the fog fades out, leaving only the atmosphere. Blue's eyes meet with the astral expanse of everything. He's astonished.

'Eh?'

'...'

Blue focuses his willpower, allowing him to move freely within the recollection. He obnoxiously stretches his muscles, loudly cracking his hips and hands.

'How'd you—'

'I'm not actually a part of this memory, am I? I can just do my own thing if I'm not.'

'Bruh...'

'What's this memory, anyways?'

'This is... the night I—'

'Left home? I knew it!'

'You... knew?'

'I'm pretty sure I saw some of your life.'

Gabrius recalls a strange twinge in his head that he felt, back in the temple.

[…]

"You gotta.. tell me *something..*!"

Before Gabrius can leave, Blue's sorrowful gaze gives way to an eidetic rush of unsealed evidence for Gabrius's stubbornness.

〖*Ψθμ αγε αβιε τθ μσε τλε σκιυ "Γεφιεςτιθη."*〗

[…]

'You went from there, to this other place (which we're going to right now), and then Semper..! I forgot after what tho—'

'That was you! You bitch!'

'Obviously it was me, dumbass!'

'And… that means you opened this up, too!'

Blue wasn't expecting that. 'Oh… oops.'

The blue man contritely whistles, not looking anywhere near Gabrius nor his direction.

'Then, do you know about..?'

'Well, all I saw was your childhood.'

A terrible childhood, at that. One filled with turmoil and complication, it was one riddled with regret from the moment of his conception. A shattered home. A crime-carved setting. The seclusion from everyone else was an added bonus.

'You left it all behind, this exact night.'

'…Why'd you become so smart all the sudden?'

'Uhh… I dunno,' he shrugs, musing. 'You matter, that's why.'

Gabrius cracks an unsuspecting smile, only visible through his eyes. His mouth is wide frown, still. The train comes to a halt at its next stop, and Gabrius's body rises. Blue jovially walks next to him, not a care in the world.

'Oh nah.'

'Woah, what's this place..?'

'…Nunc.'

An excerpt from "Mourning Morningstar's" monograph, Navigation Nightmare.

Nunc, the planet of peace: a popular tourist spot for those visiting the Iridium universe, and the complete opposite of Semper.

Recognized for its myriad innovation towards an eternal rest of sorts, it's most famously known for its emotion-evoking technology. Due to the monochrome of the Somnium, many started seeking stimulation of any kind. Therefore, it was, and still is the place the people turn to for an escapade to invite themselves into.

To begin the process, the user is inserted into an interface.

Gabrius and Blue cautiously tread their way through Vorrà City. The streets are clean, yet clandestine. Out-of-place simpers steer their way towards theirs, angled perfectly to be in the two's shared view. The bustling crowds are unusually cordial, barely bumping into them. The air itself reeks of a sweetness de rigeur.

The destination? It's clear to Gabrius's innately keen eyes. It was visible from the moment they laid foot on this planet.

One awkward walk later, they arrive at an eastern, medieval monument—like a mix between a castle and a church. Its tree-like columns and gothic arches travel endlessly above, the tippity top untouched by human sight. Within it is, of course, corrupted by abnormal hospitality.

The happy medium and its method of display are intuitively selected by the「Sol」of the user itself. The technology's system goes into effect the moment one's eyes lay upon the edifice of Nunc, Il Rifugio. From then on, the user is enclosed into their very own set of memories.

The program can be ended at any time if the keyword is spoken, that being the name of the user's Sol.

'Is this… your house?'

Blue laughs into the fancy facade. The details of everything can't be made out—it's a pure blur. Only Gabrius can see everything.

'…'

The transit fanner's body bolts out of the shattered home, his future self relieved they were thinking the same thing. It's a futile effort, though. Blue whispers in astonishment, still by his side.

'And this is your home?'

And so it is, or at least was. A violently crowded town filled with shabby, single-story houses and vibrancy unmatched attracts their attention. It replaced the streets of Nunc, already having detected Gabrius's Sol.

'…'

'Gabrius?'

'…'

"Gabrius."

"…"

Blue shakes his head, gazing at his woeful companion. He takes him by the hand, leading him elsewhere. To his dismay, Gabrius can feel the control coming back to him. His mouth moves with his mind, his utterances barely taking to their heels. "Hey, you're not supposed to—"

"It's whatever. We need to be somewhere else right now," Blue says aloud, not caring for the consequences of his action any longer.

Through the scary streets of the unnamed hometown they walk, as an unnerving essence tracks their tail end. It's all a farce, but enough to put Gabrius under the weather.

"Gabe?"

"I think I'm gonna be sick…"

The two rest by a river, one crouched over it. Blue chuckles lightly, patting Gabrius's back.

"We'll be fine. We just need to find a way out."

"I'd rather die, no offense…"

"Bro, we can do this. 'Lock in,' or whatever you were saying earlier.

Onwards they tread. Onwards…

Hours pass by before they see anything different, and it's only a matter of time before the difference becomes a new addition to the sum of sameness.

"I think we've been going in circles..?"

"My memory sucks ass, that's why."

"Maybe we should think of something else…"

"I don't really mind. I've been staring at *immense* power every loop."

"Who?"

Gabrius nods his head to the left. Blue spots her immediately, quickly discerning what "immense power" meant.

"Woah."

"*Right?*"

"Right."

Blue snaps out of it after a moment, staring Gabrius down. "You're one helluva pervert…"

"Whatever, I'm just trying to make this less worse for me."

"Whatever, man."

They continue their roundabout journey, the lady of their interest showing up on cue every repeat of the memory. Her placement in this memory is bizarre to the two, however. The only piece of evidence to prove them right was her style of clothing, such being different from the others'.

"Her face is really pretty…"

"Her ass is—"

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"—[redacted]!"

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"And her [redacted] are [redacted]! I wish I could [redacted] the [redacted] out of those [redacted]."

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Blue stops in his tracks, inspecting Gabrius. Gabrius sweats profusely, confused by the lack of distance between them.

"Huh?"

"Hold on."

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'Woah, what the yo?'

A small informational window pops up before Blue's bewildered eyes. It details every basic snippet of information he must know about his trusty friend, Gabrius, here.

『Gabrius: The Liberated Loneliness, and the nascent pathway for "Laughter" to be paved. Rumor has it that he is one of the sketches for Catastrophic Colors, and numerous efforts for him to be erased/killed have been made. [redacted] —』

Censorship non-administered by him rings in his ears. Vertigo vexes his view of the world, greatly disorienting him. He falls on the floor, rolling around from the pain, as if trying to put out a fire on his back. Gabrius chortles, seeing the fire on his pants.

"Damn! Was that the… Harrowed Harmony?"

"What the yell is that..?"

"Uhh… like… they say it shows up as a fire on your pants when you learn something you're not supposed to. I dunno what it is, though."

Blue slowly stands, puzzled by the multitude of events that just took place. He tries to recollect, but can only remember a fraction of Gabrius's already-short synopsis.

"Do you remember how you got outta here? *Anything*… at all?"

"…Nah. I just remember a weird-sounding word whistling in my ear, and then… *BOOM*!"

«*BOO*!» screams an interceding voice in Gabrius's ear.

Gabrius jumps, taking a breather as he turns around and at his aggressor. To his surprise, it's the girl they've both been eyeing this entire time.

«Did I scare you?» she smiles.

Blue's skin tingles with hidden horror, beyond any explanation he can provide. Gabrius expects another comedic jab to come from him. Nothing returns, however. He's scared shitless, stiff as a stump.

The lovely lady bows, her face glowing. Her divine vocals gain precedence over the entire dreamscape without a fleeting moment spent. They're like a train whistle to Gabrius's ears.

Whilst Calliope blabs on, Blue whispers a tentative thought to Gabrius.

'Dude, something's seriously wrong.'

'No idea what you mean by that, but spill.'

'I'm legit scared. Everyone's looking at me like I'm crazy.'

'No one's lookin' at you, bro. What's goin' on with you?'

'Um… has this all.. happened before?'

'What?'

'Has it?'

[...***8***]

"*AAAA

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A terrible childhood, at that. One filled with turmoil and complication, it was one riddled with regret from the moment of his conception. A shattered home. A crime-carved setting. The seclusion from everyone else was an added bonus.

'You left it all behind, this exact night.'

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'Uhh… I dunno,' he shrugs, musing. 'You matter, that's why.'

Gabrius cracks an unsuspecting smile, only visible through his eyes. His mouth is wide frown, still. The train comes to a halt at its next stop, and Gabrius's body rises. Blue jovially walks next to him, not a care in the world.

'Oh nah.'

'Woah, what's this place..?'

'…Nunc.'

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Blue shakes his head, gazing at his woeful companion. He takes him by the hand, leading him elsewhere. To his dismay, Gabrius can feel the control coming back to him. His mouth moves with his mind, his utterances barely taking to their heels. "Hey, you're not supposed to—"

"It's whatever. We need to be somewhere else right now," Blue says aloud, not caring for the consequences of his action any longer.

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"I think I'm gonna be sick..."

The two rest by a river, one crouched over it. Blue chuckles lightly, patting Gabrius's back.

"We'll be fine. We just need to find a way out."

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Onwards they tread. Onwards…

Hours pass by before they see anything different, and it's only a matter of time before the difference becomes a new addition to the sum of sameness.

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"My memory sucks ass, that's why."

"Maybe we should think of something else…"

"I don't really mind. I've been staring at *immense* power every loop."

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Gabrius nods his head to the left. Blue spots her immediately, quickly discerning what "immense power" meant.

"Woah."

"*Right?*"

"Right."

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"Whatever, I'm just trying to make this less worse for me."

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They continue their roundabout journey, the lady of their interest showing up on cue every repeat of the memory. Her placement in this memory is bizarre to the two, however. The only piece of evidence to prove them right was her style of clothing, such being different from the others'.

"Her face is really pretty…"

"Her ass is—"

『Lišānu activation . . . Succeeded!』

"—[redacted]!"

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"And her [redacted] are [redacted]! I wish I could [redacted] the [redacted] out of those [redacted]."

Blue's face remains stagnant. The vulgarity passes through one ear and out the other. Sure, he might be thinking the same, but he has enough shame to know better.

'Wait… What if… I use this to get us outta here?'

Blue stops in his tracks, inspecting Gabrius. Gabrius sweats profusely, confused by the lack of distance between them.

"Huh?"

"Hold on."

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A small informational window pops up before Blue's bewildered eyes. It details every basic snippet of information he must know about his trusty friend, Gabrius, here.

『Gabrius: The Liberated Loneliness, and the nascent pathway for "Laughter" to be paved. Rumor has it that he is one of the sketches for Catastrophic Colors, and numerous efforts for him to be erased/killed have been made. [redacted] —』

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"Damn! Was that the… Harrowed Harmony?"

"What the yell is that..?"

"Uhh… like… they say it shows up as a fire on your pants when you learn something you're not supposed to. I dunno what it is, though."

Blue slowly stands, puzzled by the multitude of events that just took place. He tries to recollect, but can only remember a fraction of Gabrius's already-short synopsis.

"Do you remember how you got outta here? *Anything*… at all?"

"…Nah. I just remember a weird-sounding word whistling in my ear, and then… *BOOM*!"

«*BOO*!» screams an interceding voice in Gabrius's ear.

Gabrius jumps, taking a breather as he turns around and at his aggressor. To his surprise, it's the girl they've both been eyeing this entire time.

«Did I scare you?» she smiles.

Blue's skin tingles with hidden horror, beyond any explanation he can provide. Gabrius expects another comedic jab to come from him. Nothing returns, however. He's scared shitless, stiff as a stump.

The lovely lady bows, her face glowing. Her divine vocals gain precedence over the entire dreamscape without a fleeting moment spent. They're like a train whistle to Gabrius's ears.

[…**13**]

"*AAAA

Gabrius screams in terror; like he's being groped by a big, black man. Mind-numbing pain pierces his soul.

Blue howls with laughter, in pure hysteria. He, too, is in the same pain. Withal, he couldn't care less, and continues to laugh at Gabrius.

Plop.

A droplet of water resounds throughout the nothingness. It instantly catches Blue's attention. Right, they were just fighting an angel; so, where were they?

Cessation.

Gabrius's alertness reconvenes without a moment's notice.

Caution.

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Gabrius's eyes are bloodshot.

Blue's blood boils for no apparent reason.

From the intense silence, they can hear each other's thoughts.

'Fuck.'

'You alright?'

'Naw… GET ME OUT OF HERE!'

The midnight moon looms over all. Its watchful eye petrifies Gabrius. Though, what scares him more is Blue's.

Sweat trickles down his forehead, traveling down to his chin. It plops onto his thigh from on high. His arms fight for control so that he may rip his own throat out, but the mighty memory paralyzes him far too painfully.

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Blue stifles another one of his odious giggles, having some respect for Gabrius's manic moment.

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'Aboard the Constellation Complex. Specifically, the Incola Lucia constellation family. Specifically, the Auctus constellation. Specifically in the Iridium division. Specifically in the Argent Luisant district. Specifically, the Lotus Lake—'

'OKAY, SHUT UP.'

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Blue focuses his willpower, allowing him to move freely within the recollection. He obnoxiously stretches his muscles, loudly cracking his hips and hands.

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'I'm not actually a part of this memory, am I? I can just do my own thing if I'm not.'

'Bruh...'

'What's this memory, anyways?'

'This is... the night I—'

'Left home? I knew it!'

'You... knew?'

'I'm pretty sure I saw some of your life.'

Gabrius recalls a strange twinge in his head that he felt, back in the temple.

[...]

"You gotta.. tell me *something*..!"

Before Gabrius can leave, Blue's sorrowful gaze gives way to an eidetic rush of unsealed evidence for Gabrius's stubbornness.

⟦*Ψθμ αγε αβιε τθ μσε τλε σκιιι "Γεφιεςτιθη."*⟧

[…]

'You went from there, to this other place (which we're going to right now), and then Semper..! I forgot after what tho—'

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'And… that means you opened this up, too!'

Blue wasn't expecting that. 'Oh… oops.'

The blue man contritely whistles, not looking anywhere near Gabrius nor his direction.

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The lovely lady bows, her face glowing. Her divine vocals gain precedence over the entire dreamscape without a fleeting moment spent. They're like a train whistle to Gabrius's ears.

[...***34***]

"*AAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAHHH—*"

Gabrius screams in terror; like he's being groped by a big, black man. Mind-numbing pain pierces his soul.

Blue howls with laughter, in pure hysteria. He, too, is in the same pain. Withal, he couldn't care less, and continues to laugh at Gabrius.

Plop.

A droplet of water resounds throughout the nothingness. It instantly catches Blue's attention. Right, they were just fighting an angel; so, where were they?

Cessation.

Gabrius's alertness reconvenes without a moment's notice.

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Blue wasn't expecting that. 'Oh… oops.'

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Of course, constellations have their own inner workings; therein, they branch off into different lines across universes, galaxies, solar systems, planets, etc. 'Till the present moment, no single Sovereign can fully navigate the conundrum that is the modern Constellation Complex besides Princesa "Mourning Morningstar" (I am tooting my own horn, haha).

Each constellations' trains are known as constellation connectors, and travel at impossible speeds. It's documented that they're capable of ignoring any obstacles, even escaping black holes on several occasions.

From asterism—the official term for their stations—to asterism they travel, and throughout the Somnium they go. Trillions of connectors exist in a single constellation, and the convolution of the routes is as abundant as the routes themselves.

Of course, there are certain limitations to the abundance of the Constellation Complex. Special railroad lines are required to go the distance between ensembles (groups of multiverses), as well as special passes to board them.

As Gabrius yaps about the staggering scope of the Constellation Complex, Blue zones out and glances around the carriage. He's still listening with half an ear, just to be nice.

Eventually, the fog fades out, leaving only the atmosphere. Blue's eyes meet with the astral expanse of everything. He's astonished.

'Eh?'

'...'

Blue focuses his willpower, allowing him to move freely within the recollection. He obnoxiously stretches his muscles, loudly cracking his hips and hands.

'How'd you—'

'I'm not actually a part of this memory, am I? I can just do my own thing if I'm not.'

'Bruh...'

'What's this memory, anyways?'

'This is... the night I—'

'Left home? I knew it!'

'You... knew?'

'I'm pretty sure I saw some of your life.'

Gabrius recalls a strange twinge in his head that he felt, back in the temple.

[...]

"You gotta.. tell me *something..*!"

Before Gabrius can leave, Blue's sorrowful gaze gives way to an eidetic rush of unsealed evidence for Gabrius's stubbornness.

⟦Ψθμ αγε αβιε τθ μσε τλε σκιυ "Γεφιεστιθη."⟧

[...]

'You went from there, to this other place (which we're going to right now), and then Semper..! I forgot after what tho—'

'That was you! You bitch!'

'Obviously it was me, dumbass!'

'And… that means you opened this up, too!'

Blue wasn't expecting that. 'Oh… oops.'

The blue man contritely whistles, not looking anywhere near Gabrius nor his direction.

'Then, do you know about..?'

'Well, all I saw was your childhood.'

A terrible childhood, at that. One filled with turmoil and complication, it was one riddled with regret from the moment of his conception. A shattered home. A crime-carved setting. The seclusion from everyone else was an added bonus.

'You left it all behind, this exact night.'

'…Why'd you become so smart all the sudden?'

'Uhh… I dunno,' he shrugs, musing. 'You matter, that's why.'

Gabrius cracks an unsuspecting smile, only visible through his eyes. His mouth is wide frown, still. The train comes to a halt at its next stop, and Gabrius's body rises. Blue jovially walks next to him, not a care in the world.

'Oh nah.'

'Woah, what's this place..?'

'...Nunc.'

An excerpt from "Mourning Morningstar's" monograph, Navigation Nightmare.

Nunc, the planet of peace: a popular tourist spot for those visiting the Iridium universe, and the complete opposite of Semper.

Recognized for its myriad innovation towards an eternal rest of sorts, it's most famously known for its emotion-evoking technology. Due to the monochrome of the Somnium, many started seeking stimulation of any kind. Therefore, it was, and still is the place the people turn to for an escapade to invite themselves into.

To begin the process, the user is inserted into an interface.

Gabrius and Blue cautiously tread their way through Vorrà City. The streets are clean, yet clandestine. Out-of-place simpers steer their way towards theirs, angled perfectly to be in

the two's shared view. The bustling crowds are unusually cordial, barely bumping into them. The air itself reeks of a sweetness de rigeur.

The destination? It's clear to Gabrius's innately keen eyes. It was visible from the moment they laid foot on this planet.

One awkward walk later, they arrive at an eastern, medieval monument—like a mix between a castle and a church. Its tree-like columns and gothic arches travel endlessly above, the tippity top untouched by human sight. Within it is, of course, corrupted by abnormal hospitality.

The happy medium and its method of display are intuitively selected by the「Sol」of the user itself. The technology's system goes into effect the moment one's eyes lay upon the edifice of Nunc, Il Rifugio. From then on, the user is enclosed into their very own set of memories.

The program can be ended at any time if the keyword is spoken, that being the name of the user's Sol.

'Is this… your house?'

Blue laughs into the fancy facade. The details of everything can't be made out—it's a pure blur. Only Gabrius can see everything.

'...'

The transit fanner's body bolts out of the shattered home, his future self relieved they were thinking the same thing. It's a futile effort, though. Blue whispers in astonishment, still by his side.

'And this is your home?'

And so it is, or at least was. A violently crowded town filled with shabby, single-story houses and vibrancy unmatched attracts their attention. It replaced the streets of Nunc, already having detected Gabrius's Sol.

'...'

'Gabrius?'

'...'

"Gabrius."

"..."

Blue shakes his head, gazing at his woeful companion. He takes him by the hand, leading him elsewhere. To his dismay, Gabrius can feel the control coming back to him. His mouth moves with his mind, his utterances barely taking to their heels. "Hey, you're not supposed to—"

"It's whatever. We need to be somewhere else right now," Blue says aloud, not caring for the consequences of his action any longer.

Through the scary streets of the unnamed hometown they walk, as an unnerving essence tracks their tail end. It's all a farce, but enough to put Gabrius under the weather.

"Gabe?"

"I think I'm gonna be sick…"

The two rest by a river, one crouched over it. Blue chuckles lightly, patting Gabrius's back.

"We'll be fine. We just need to find a way out."

"I'd rather die, no offense…"

"Bro, we can do this. 'Lock in,' or whatever you were saying earlier.

Onwards they tread. Onwards…

Hours pass by before they see anything different, and it's only a matter of time before the difference becomes a new addition to the sum of sameness.

"I think we've been going in circles..?"

"My memory sucks ass, that's why."

"Maybe we should think of something else…"

"I don't really mind. I've been staring at *immense* power every loop."

"Who?"

Gabrius nods his head to the left. Blue spots her immediately, quickly discerning what "immense power" meant.

"Woah."

"*Right?*"

"Right."

Blue snaps out of it after a moment, staring Gabrius down. "You're one helluva pervert…"

"Whatever, I'm just trying to make this less worse for me."

"Whatever, man."

They continue their roundabout journey, the lady of their interest showing up on cue every repeat of the memory. Her placement in this memory is bizarre to the two, however. The only piece of evidence to prove them right was her style of clothing, such being different from the others'.

"Her face is really pretty…"

"Her ass is—"

『Lišānu activation . . . Succeeded!』

"—so fucking fat!"

『Lišānu, "Laughter," has been activated. Comfortable censorship applied.』

"And her boobs are voluptuous! I wish I could squeeze the shit out of those massive tits."

Blue's face remains stagnant. The vulgarity passes through one ear and out the other. Sure, he might be thinking the same, but he has enough shame to know better.

'Wait… What if… I use this to get us outta here?'

Blue stops in his tracks, inspecting Gabrius. Gabrius sweats profusely, confused by the lack of distance between them.

"Huh?"

"Hold on."

『*Ψθμ αγε αβιε τθ μσε τλε σκιιι "Cθησρεστμς."*』

'Woah, what the yo?'

A small informational window pops up before Blue's bewildered eyes. It details every basic snippet of information he must know about his trusty friend, Gabrius, here.

『Gabrius: The Liberated Loneliness, and the nascent pathway for "Laughter" to be paved. Rumor has it that he is one of the sketches for Catastrophic Colors, and numerous efforts for him to be erased/killed have been made. It is preordained that he is destined to reconvene with his color, Blue, and find his future in his past—』

Censorship non-administered by him rings in his ears. Vertigo vexes his view of the world, greatly disorienting him. He falls on the floor, rolling around from the pain, as if trying to put out a fire on his back. Gabrius chortles, seeing the fire on his pants.

"Damn! Was that the… Harrowed Harmony?"

"What the yell is that..?"

"Uhh… like… they say it shows up as a fire on your pants when you learn something you're not supposed to. I dunno what it is, though."

Blue slowly stands, puzzled by the multitude of events that just took place. He tries to recollect, but can only remember a fraction of Gabrius's already-short synopsis.

"Do you remember how you got outta here? *Anything*… at all?"

"…Nah. I just remember a weird-sounding word whistling in my ear, and then… *BOOM*!"

«*BOO*!» screams an interceding voice in Gabrius's ear.

Gabrius jumps, taking a breather as he turns around and at his aggressor. To his surprise, it's the girl they've both been eyeing this entire time.

«Did I scare you?» she smiles.

Blue's skin tingles with hidden horror, beyond any explanation he can provide. Gabrius expects another comedic jab to come from him. Nothing returns, however. He's scared shitless, stiff as a stump.

The lovely lady bows, her face glowing. Her divine vocals gain precedence over the entire dreamscape without a fleeting moment spent. They're like a train whistle to Gabrius's ears.

[...]

"I stopped thinking about it a while ago, so you can shut up—"

"My bad, was tryna be smart for once."

"Whatever. Anyways, you have a plan now, or..?"

"Let me cook, hold on," Blue confidently asserts. He rubs his head, starting his thought machine up like some old computer. "We should deadass just... uh... dude, I just got crazy chills. I don't even think I should cook up my next thought."

"Nah, just do it. What's the worst that could happen?"

"Yeah... yeah. Dude, I wish we could go **back in time** and fix everything—"

[...***1,779,979,416,004,714,189***]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

A… train station?

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

You alright?

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

Are we cooked?

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

Where are we?

[redacted]

[redacted]

OKAY, SHUT UP.

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

Eh?

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

I'm not actually a part of this memory, am I? I can just do my own thing if I'm not.

[redacted]

What's this memory, anyways?

[redacted]

Left home? I knew it!

[redacted]

I'm pretty sure I saw some of your life.

[redacted]

[redacted]

You gotta.. tell me *something*..!

You went from there, to this other place (which we're going to right now), and then Semper..! I forgot after what tho—

Obviously it was me, dumbass!

Oh… oops.

Well, all I saw was your childhood.

[redacted]

You left it all behind, this exact night.

[redacted]

Uhh… I dunno, [redacted] You matter, that's why.

[redacted]

[redacted]

Woah, what's this place..?

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

Is this… your house?

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

And this is your home?

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

Gabrius?

[redacted]

Gabrius.

[redacted]

[redacted]

It's whatever. We need to be somewhere else right now,

[redacted]

[redacted]

Gabe?

[redacted]

[redacted]

We'll be fine. We just need to find a way out.

[redacted]

Bro, we can do this. 'Lock in,' or whatever you were saying earlier.

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

I think we've been going in circles..?

[redacted]

Maybe we should think of something else...

[redacted]

Who?

[redacted]

Woah.

[redacted]

Right.

[redacted] You're one helluva pervert...

[redacted]

Whatever, man.

[redacted]

Her face is really pretty…

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

Wait… What if… I use this to get us outta here?

[redacted]

[redacted]

Hold on.

[redacted]

Woah, what the yo?

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

What the yell is that..?

[redacted]

[redacted]

Do you remember how you got outta here? *Anything*… at all?

[redacted]

BOO! [redacted]

[redacted]

Did I scare you? [redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

[…]

"Gabe."

"Uh… yeah?"

"I **REALLY** don't like this," Blue says, shivering. They both sit adjacent together on the train, externally stoic despite their internal trepidation.

"Huh? What's wrong?"

"Bro, doesn't it feel like.. I don't know, man…"

"If you were gonna yap about me being open with you, I might as well know about what's bothering you."

"Okay, chill.. I just… We need to get to Semper, or I'm gonna crash out."

The roar of the train engine fills their ears at that exact moment. The constellation connector thunders forward, seeking out Blue's next destination with a hunger filled only by his satisfaction. Blue stumbles forward, startled by the train's sudden start-up.

"Gabe..!"

"Blue..! I think I'm gonna throw up.. *Hrmmp…*"

"Yo, train, stop it!" Blue shouts, half-sarcastic.

Without a second to spare, the locomotive halts in its tracks, sending Blue flying forward from inertia's interference.

"FuuuuuuuuuUUUUUUUUUUUAAAAAAAAHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHH—"

Blue, in a last-ditch effort, spreads his body out to prepare for any whatever nasty impact is coming his way. Though, it might not be as effective as he'd hope, being that he's—

'—FALLING FROM FUCKING SPACE?!'

By the time his body shot out of the train cabin, they were already within Semper's atmosphere. All that was left for the journey was the gravity of the situation. Literally.

"*GABE! GAAABEEE!!!*"

A chilling sensation freezes his blood whilst he passes through the clouds. He hopes for something to break or soften his fall somehow. Thankfully, he's in luck! It's not long after that he sees something rising into view.

'Is that… a tower..?'

Tender light shines warmly, flooding all the sky with its color. The blue of the sky shifts slightly, a dash of it brighter than the rest of the ether. It quietly crashes into a sepulcher of angelic darkness, that which fools all else with its "light."

CRASH!

⟦*Fiγst ργθτθςθι, "Ωεmθγψ," λας βεεη δεαςτινατεδ. Δ ƒμω γεβθθτ ϖiω τακε εffεςτ ϖλεη τλε ςλεςκρθiητ is γεαςλεδ. Ριεασε αςτίνατε τλε sεςθηδ ργθτθςθι τθ βegiη τλε ργθςεss.*⟧

Blue, in that brief moment of irreversible impact, forgets every bit of significant history surrounding the past. Before he can completely black out, he subconsciously calls upon something deep within himself to save him from the inevitable future he faces.

⟦*Cθmmεηςiηg sεςθηδ ργθτθςθι, "Γεβθθτ."*⟧

A splitting headache drags Blue down to the depths of unconsciousness almost instantly. Such a headache would've killed a hundred men, yet he manages to endure it with so much as a blunt injury.

Reality swims and struggles against the tests of time and space as the two wander wildly, reversing with the crippled causation of Antecedens and Nunc's events in tow. It perseveres with an unbridled power through the raging waters, keeping Blue safe within its waves, albeit the constraints it faces in doing so.

The world around them glitches into oblivion, flickering with sparks of blue and purple. It attempts to repair itself, slowly mending the past into the present, and the future into the present. Its only reference point is Blue. It is only held together by Blue's presence.

Meanwhile, a precocious train-lover dwells dolefully by the gilded tracks, taking pride in his hardly attainable internship at Regal Station. Yes, the Regalia had personally chosen *him* as an intern at one of their stations. As a transit fanner, this was a dream come true.

Though kids his age might be running about a route that means to prove their martial prowess, he only found meaning in pleasing himself with these hobbies of his—mainly transport.

The intern glances around the fancy station. Nothing catches his eye after a few years of going here. He trills his lips and fumbles for his phone in his pocket. He's only on it for a few minutes 'till his boredom kills him.

The precocious boy searches around the station for anything of entertainment: a displaced tile, a wobbly bench, an annoying dog, a hyperactive cat, and whatever else fits his interests in the span of an hour.

This day in particular, he feels lonesome. Tired. Somewhat empty, really. Not even his job could fulfill him.

Exactly a year ago, the Tomb of Somber Selection had chosen its newest ~~victims~~ candidates for sacrifice. He's one of them.

That isn't the reason for his inexplicable sorrow, though. He can't put his finger on it. It's as if there's a connection he's been desperately searching for without knowing, waiting to be made.

He checks the time on the fancy clock at the center of the station, patiently awaiting his train's arrival.

"It's time."

The local train—the only one on schedule for this stop that isn't a constellation connector—arrives at the station. Indeed, the Regalia takes charge of non-constellation-connector locomotives too, as long as they're within the confines of their stations. Every train, in that way, is just another cog in their order—their Enthalpy.

All other local trains, once lucky enough to make an appearance at the Regal Station, were out of commission for years, by then. This local train, being the last one in commission, is famously and affectionately referred to by cultured Semperians and foreigners as the "**Lagtrain**."

Its next stop, Ferro City, is where the annual sacrifice for the Tomb of Somber Selection is held every year, without fail.

The building itself is a marriage between mausoleum and tower, presenting itself as an eerie mess of Babylonian downfall—a fitting and famous tale from Earth, more commonly known as Terra. Legends of the tomb's construction detail an ancient race of Semperians who yearned for contact with the Sovereigns. They sacrificed their own and built the tomb with those bodies, all for the chance that they may catch their gaze.

In the end, they garnered enough notoriety to win the Sovereigns' blessings; and thus, the angel's presence began to bless the highest height of the Tomb of Somber Selection, its energy extending into every corner of Semper.

Even beyond that, it always seems to have a mind of its own—to have a particular appetite for its ~~food~~ nominees. Coincidentally, they—the rest of the nominees—and Gabrius casually board the Lagtrain, riding it all the way to Ferro City.

It's a ride as calm and slow as the falling snow outside, and as "quiet" as the next ride on a local train, but it holds an entire novel of words worth of meaning for Gabrius and everyone else inside.

'It's lonely, but it's nice.. like this. It's kinda

liberating.'

A few hours pass, and the Lagtrain finally reaches its destination. Its passengers, a mix of timid and confident, exit from the warm arms of the Lagtrain and into the coldness of the winter city.

Some look like they're about to burst into fearful tears. Some look like they're ready to conquer the angel itself. Gabrius, in his usual fashion, is far too conflicted to feel just one of the two. It usually mixes into regret that way. It's all too complicated for him to comprehend all at once.

'Why didn't I just walk here? Shoulda taken my sweet time…'

"Yo, Gabe," calls an acquaintance of his, breaking his train of thought. "You ready?"

"Uh.. yeah," he awkwardly shrugs.

"No goofy gestures today, Lagtrain? You tired, or sum?" asks aother acquaintance.

"Nah, but we gotta lock in," he replies, flinching at the nickname.

As soon as their banter develops, everyone else grows confident enough to talk amongst each other.

"There's no way we're all making it out alive, right?" a young adult in glasses chimes.

"No way, because I'll be the only one left!" a muscular, middle-aged man chimes.

"Can't we all just work together?" queries a small, skittish child.

Chaos ensues amongst the sacrifices, fear frantically prancing above each of their heads. Gabrius only watches as everyone's world unravels before their very eyes as chaos consumes them.

'They're all gonna die at this rate…'

[…]

Phase 5: Aria

[Countless「permutations」later…]

Gabrius and Blue shoot waterguns at each other in the middle of a public park, some of the splash reaching nearby children. Mothers complain at them, but for the most part, they don't care too much. They just move out of the way and continue their battle elsewhere.

"See, I told you we could make Nunc a fun trip!"

"Sure, but I still *hate* doing Calliope's chores."

"She's just being nice, showing us around or whatever."

"She is *not* a tour guide! Bro, you know those stories about like… people who accidentally ended up.. um.. doing the mafia's dirty work, when they thought they were just doing a bunch of odd jobs for quick cash?"

"*Pfft*, yeah?"

""Cause those are actually the vibes I'm getting right now," Gabrius comments, giggling in between words.

"Brohoho, no, that's fair though!" Blue remarks, laughing to himself.

Gabrius aims water directly into Blue's mouth as he laughs, turning him into a sputtering mess. Blue retaliates with a beam of water toward Gabrius's eyes.

They chuckle and chortle like idiots, enjoying themselves until the clear, clarified sunrise dawns on them. It captivates them like never before. They've never gotten this good of a view before.

Gabrius and Blue, mesmerized, pause their battle and sit in the grass.

"Yo, you should take a picture."

"What's a picture? You mean like.. make a painting?"

"Nah, don't you know? Hold on."

Gabrius rummages around in his pockets, pulling out an entire—

"It's called a camera! Super duper cool (and useful). Ordered it from eBuy yesterday, while you were out getting groceries." Gabrius extends his arm, handing Blue a sleek, black box.

"Try it. Just aim the cylinder end at whatever you wanna remember, and click the blue button—yeah, right there—on the bottom. You can see what you're taking a picture of on that display right there."

"Uhh… alright?"

Blue holds the alien technology in the palms of his hands. He feels as if he possesses an esoteric, almost forbidden form of power. He feels 'high as hell.'

He focuses the camera on the sky, waiting for a train of any kind to pass him by.

"Why do they only use trains for space? Wouldn't like… a plane.. be faster?"

"Yeah, but that's reserved for Regality."

"Aw, bruh—"

The sound of a stream engine tearing through the sky suddenly waltzes its way into their ears; a clear omen of the constellation connector. Blue reacts to the rhythm, snapping a satisfactory shot of the passing train.

"Didja get it?"

"Hold on, lemme… uh… is it supposed to do that?" Blue asks, pointing to the screen.

The high-tech display oscillates between a grainy distortion of space and…

Perfection.

An excerpt from "Mourning Morningstar's" fictional novel, Daughter of Daylight.

It was then that Aurora of Borealis saw it—a likeness like no other: ***Perfection***.

Everything felt like nothing before its general paramountcy. It was the highest height there was to see in this lonely world of hers. It was the absolute ***Truth***.

The moment it graced her eyes, she went blind, for the domain of what she saw became restricted to that one, singular thing. She wanted to keep it, and for it to remain known only to her. She wouldn't let anyone else go as far as to even sense it.

No, it verily was hers. That was the ***Truth*** of the matter.

"So, this was what's been hidden all along…"

She inspected it for much longer than she needed to. She simply wanted reasons to waste time interacting with ***Perfection***.

"I wonder…

…if anyone would see this similarly."

"Oh, huh? D-definitely not…"

"Why does it look so… cool? I literally don't have words for this."

"'Cool' is… uh… definitely a word to describe it."

The train is the spitting image of Blue's wildest dreams. It's everything he loves about life itself, in his eyes.

"Can I keep this photo..?"

"Y-yep," Gabrius stutters, giving a thumbs-up. "You can keep the camera too if you want. It gives me weird vibes, not gonna lie."

"Hoho yeahhh... This is super duper awesome. You know, if I didn't know any better, I'd have thought I saw the thing in this photo, before; like... in another life."

"Uh... I don't know how you're thinking that, but I can kinda agree for some reason."

"Yeah. Wait, where'd you say you bought this from?"

"eBuy, but the seller was pretty shady-looking, no background or anything. I think their username was... 'AurBor.'"

[...]

Nova fiddles with her fake halo, dangling from the oldest, tallest tree in the

Episode ?? — Therefore, You And Me

He sits in his room, so peaceful and pretty. His chest vibrates with warmth, the beating venue within his chest throwing a party like never before. Light bounces off of the snow and copies itself onto his gray walls. He thanks the snow for all that it's done.

All that it's done.

"All that is done."

The yellow of the world escaped Earth's atmosphere, already in search of answers. He knew something was amiss, but he couldn't quite tell what.

The cold vacuum of space crackled with energy, as a streak of yellow burned across its immense distance. Its destination? No one knew, but the prospect was always something to revel at.

It freely passes over the atmosphere of a warring planet, Fūjin, piercing the clouds and crashing elsewhere. Its arrival goes unnoticed, however, as per the sound of intergalactic warfare easily drowning it out.

"Press onwards!" commands an armored visionary, his squadron rushing forward with unmatched ferocity.

Both sides of the war are equally-matched in every way possible, and have been so for centuries. It's been widely seen as a proxy war between opposing ideologies in the Regalia, though neither side could ever attain the upper hand.

Each available visionary in the local star system was dutifully selected for various roles in the separate chains of command depending on their abilities, and a singular mediator stands at the top of each army.

Without reserve or reason does the war stand to be fought in the modern age. Of course, such discernment is beyond the Regalia.

Two, young soldiers stationed along the sidelines chat about nothing of supreme significance, hoping to whisk away their worries with whatever they can barely bake in their meandering minds. They both hail from opposing sides, but that's far from enough to stop their rendezvous.

"How's the rationing going for you guys?" one soldier, adorned in red and white, asks. Cool confidence precedes his presence.

The other, decorated by green and blue coolness, replies, albeit in a slightly embarrassed tone, "All of our supply lines are being cut off by your sponsors. What about you guys?" Frustration falls on his shoulders.

"Same with us. I think the Regalia's getting better with internal affairs," the collected one sarcastically says.

"Their Novus Ordo initiative sucks shit."

"*Multiple taxes* on starlight? Please!"

"That shouldn't even be a thing *to* tax!"

"Well, you can't blame 'em too much. They took a pretty big hit after losing their war…"

"Hell if I care! They should've

"You'd think Princesa Nova has Princep Ord on a leash."

"She probably does!"

The two laugh royally at the state the Sovereigns are in; though, their laughter dies down. They collectively sigh, shaking their heads at the methodless madness taking place.

"Want some water?" the frustrated friend offers, holding out a flask.

The other nods, grabbing it intently. As he's gulping gallons down, he catches something in his periphery.

"Hey, I'm sure that's a shooting star!" the collected soldier excitedly shouts.

The frustrated soldier squints in the direction of the astral phenomenon. "Huh? I thought all of them burnt out…"

"Not an actual star, dude! Just make a wish!"

"*Ahh*, alright!"

An obvious thought passes through both of their minds. Honestly, it would be impossible not to tell what was going through their minds. Not a word is spoken between them.

The shooting star they see disappears from their view, crashing into the remote landscape. The impact is immense enough to split the eternal night for a second or two. It only frightens the two comrades, everyone else on the battlefield unchanged by its appearance.

"You thinking what I'm thinking?" the calm soldier inquires.

"Duh," the rowdy soldier concurs.

A dim, yellow light glows in the darkness some hundred meters away. The two ready themselves for a lengthy sprint.

They cautiously carry their rifles with them as they prop themselves up, silently cutting across the eerie entresol. As they make their way closer to the site of interest, their bodies begin slowing down. Time dilates at an exponential rate, and space warps around the intense center of gravity the meteor conveys.

The closer their corporeality comes to the interdimensional discharge, the lesser their already-bereft wills cling onto their consciousness.

A gilded cage surrounds the centerpiece of calamity with an approximately 100-meter radius. A virtuous voice emits from within the golden barrier, echoing for miles and miles.

"..Eh? What am I doing here?"

The two soldiers look at each other, dazed. The rowdy one shouts back in a curious voice, "Who are you?"

"I'll only know *who* **if** I know *why*."

"*Who* does this guy think he is?" the calm one whispers under his breath.

The downtrodden desolation of the battlefield surrounding the yellow emission warps wrathfully, without regard for the impossible. Loud footsteps fill the duo's ears, thumping dutifully as would a marching band's drums.

"I heard your wish, boys. I'll bring that peace, **since** you asked nicely."

"Wow, real generous of you," the calm soldier says.

"*You* can end an entire war?" the other soldier snarkily raises.

"If a thought is brought, **then** it is not for naught."

"What's that supposed to me—"

The glowing yellow catapults into the stratosphere, ensnaring the attention of all as its light blinds everyone and disrupts the flow of battle.

『You are able to use the skill "Whiteout."』

Snow falls like starlight and scatters to the wind. Some of it is caught in the eyes of the countless warriors, now reduced to mere onlookers.

A voice now appears in the two soldiers' heads, who are frozen in place by fear of this being's power. They huddle where they originally were, intently listening to the yellowness.

"Watch, **if** you can see."

The atmosphere grows frighteningly cold. A crystalline coldness. The complex patterns of each snowflake continuously contort to form impossible geometry. Upon contact, some minds are melted whilst others are revitalized. The rubric that heads their outcome isn't black and white, but derives from their fate most directly.

"What the—"

"—Hell?"

Chaos churns in their stomachs. Bodies can be heard hitting the ground, one by one. The freezing temperature feels no different from blistering heat.

"Fuck, who is this guy?"

"Concentrate all fire on the yellow light!"

Every ounce of magical unicorn bombardment is hurled his way, ready to eradicate anything it touches.

『You are able to use the skill "Dimensional Shift."』

Nearly reaching him, they disappear into an invisible wall.

"What the—"

Yellow halfheartedly punches forward into the invisible wall, leaving devastation behind him. Of course, he makes sure not to kill anybody in his efforts. He'll happily stay a pacifist in a messy situation like this.

"Retreat!"

"Fall back!"

Everyone on both sides flees from the field, leaving only the two that summoned him remaining.

"Uh… thanks?" the frustrated fellow shouts strangely.

"Are you some new Sovereign?" the serene soldier questions quietly.

"*A… Sovereign?*"

"You know, those big guys in the sky with crazy powers?"

"They keep everybody 'safe,'" frustration permeating his tone.

"*Sovereign… isn't that..?*"

Yellow's face contorts in confusion. He feels *that* title shouldn't exist at all, but nothing in his linear logic or myriad memories can explain his baneful bias towards it.

"Who would go by that title..?"

"Wow, you're really out of the loop. This guy must've missed every weekly Regalia Summit or something."

"Well, they're either the people in charge of the Regalia—which people started calling Enthalpy—or Entropy."

"Hey, except for that one lady at the head of Entropy—"

Yellow takes off immediately, almost as if in pursuit of those Sovereigns. No trace of determination plays on his face, but rather one of pained disappointment.

"He's abnormally short."

"I was just about to say that!"

『You are able to use the skill "Memory Management."』

"Ha.. Wait, why did—"

"—Everyone leave..?"

『You are able to use the skill "Dimensional Drift."』

Yellow mutters to himself, journeying his way through the cosmos. Each planet grants him new answers, though his dilemma began branching off into smaller questions.

Ajout, the planet of abundance.

"Sovereigns of Enthalpy collectively watch over all of Creation and keep everything in order," says the old man, whilst Yellow carries his groceries. "Sovereigns of Entropy, however, constantly oppose their rule. They keep no form of rule over anyone, since their only goal is to dismantle Enthalpy… and to cause chaos everywhere they go."

"Hmm…"

Ánesi, the planet of convenience.

"Entropy? They're awesome, but pretty violent too," the lady comments, the two of them seated at hair dryers. "I'd be a fan if they didn't try to wreck everything with some kind of order to it."

"What is their purpose in doing so?"

"They have this 'Chaos Theory' thing that they're trying to elevate," she shrugs. "They refuse to elaborate any further, though."

The lady looks beside her to glance at Yellow, curious about his disposition.

"Wait, you have no hair..! Why're you even—"

Lantana, the planet of vibrancy.

"Enthalpy has an airtight grip on the entire omniverse, with the power of some ancient prophecy that they keep to themselves," a carefree gardener nods, watering their plants with Yellow. "Everything that happens only does so with its consent."

"*Everything?*"

"Well, that's unless you're one of those legendary 'calamities.'"

"'Calamities?'"

"Creation's Calamities? You've *never* heard that one bedtime story?"

"I'm afraid not, but could you enlighten me?"

"Ahh, well…"

Long before our cities came to be, as well as our responsibilities, our customs, and our wars, they have always been in every way present.

「Creation's Calamities.」

Not much is known about them, besides the fact that they were a product of both humanity's and another, mysterious force's efforts.

"That's pretty much the gist of it. Word is that the Regalia is trying to gain total control over their story too, though. Super duper paranoid, I'm telling ya'."

Wisteria, the planet of scholars.

"What?! You're the guy that ended the war on Fūjin—" an observant onlooker yelps, before being cut off.

『You are able to use the skill "Memory Management."』

Right, he might want to fix that too.

Yellow languidly lays on a sailing comet in the middle of nowhere. Perhaps he should speed things up a bit. He feels as if he's running out of time to find his answers. The more he presently learned, the more he understood what terrible forces await him and his fellow colors.

The Robloxian Realm, the metaverse of innovation.

"What the…"

Gaggles of children can be seen tending to monstrous greenery, the stench of the kids overpowering the fancy fragrance of their gardens.

[insert more references here for later]

Finally, Earth, the planet of discord.

Yellow scribbles indecipherable caveman drawings into a notebook he stole from some blocky guy in blue. He attempts to make sense of everything he's learned so far, especially the power of this world: Lišānu.

Lišānu, the most ancient theory, is the driving force of the world. We humans, today, know it as「Sol」. Expressions are everywhere; but, when imbued in living beings, they carry a volatile flow of power.

Its two divisions, Išid and Emūqum, both directly derive from the nature of one; also known as Milieu and Resin. Išid—Milieu—relates to their innate nature.
Emūqum—Resin—relates to their adaptive nature.

One's Milieu is completed by [redacted]

One's Resin is completed by [redacted]

The closer one reaches to [redacted], the closer one reaches to [redacted].

He's definitely stumbled upon forbidden knowledge of it, but learning it was worth it. It really was.

『Lišānu activation . . . Failed!』

Sadly, he fails to find any use in it.

Yellow sets his sights elsewhere, moving his pencil towards…

"Sovereigns… A schism… And a prophecy… **So**, where are the bastards responsible for all this..?"

Yellow looks at the big ball of blue and green, sitting atop Mons Huygens. Above is the infinity he has traversed, clearing every corner he turned to find any answer lying around. Of course, there's still more to be had. Though he's reluctant to go back to Earth, he knows he'd find more answers here. Albeit, there's only one answer he truly wants.

"My 'sketch' is there, isn't he?"

Episode ?? — Self-Inflicted Achromatic

A soft, starry piece plays peacefully. There's no ordinary structure to it. It's repetitive, but thought-provoking with its variable key changes and dynamics.

It plays on without any real purpose in mind. Like an idea without follow-through. Like a sketch without color. Then, it abruptly stops.

A crowdless theater claps unreservedly, shouting chantingly for an encore.

A boy, living an endless dream, stands at the center of it all. Not the stage, of course. He's just clapping the loudest.

Center stage belongs to someone indiscernible. Someone he can't see. His vision fails to focus, only making out a strange silhouette. The silhouette is a far cry from "familiar."

The cheering stops, and the next piece begins. It all sounds the same. Some senseless daydream.

He smiles tryingly, but can't find the energy to truly cheer them on. He awkwardly scratches his neck, miffed about the whole thing. Still, he watches.

Dumbbells weigh on his eyelids as his boredom reaches its peak. He blinks. The light outside has turned to night.

The show is over. Nobody else is in the room besides him and the performer, though they don't even pay a glance to him.

They sit on the edge of the stage, crying softly.There's somehow a melody in it, eerily similar to his piece. He tilts his head, confused. He silently makes his way to them, trying to reach out a hand. He isn't seen at all, however.

"..."

Rain arrives, easily filling up the black void with white noise. It silences their silence, but adds to it all the same.

A dazzling moonlit sky shares its shimmering sonata with the two, reaching them in both melody and meaning. It plays peacefully, with no real meaning in mind. That's its meaning.

The performer sighs, rising from their spot and aimlessly wandering around the venue. He steps outside, so the boy follows. The boy tries to mutter something about using an umbrella, but he's completely ignored. Therein, they go without any umbrellas or protection, leaving them soaked in an instant.

The boy gasps, remembering where they were. Meanwhile, the performer checks their phone for the time whilst speeding onwards. The boy shakes his head and remains close behind.

The performer begins typing something in his Notes app, unperturbed by everything.

{It's 11:56 at night. I'm here at Tokyo Garden Theater, seemingly headed to Ariake-tennis-no-Mori Station.}

{Light rain's falling, and the neon lights are glowing on the ground—it's kinda dreamy. 🌌}

{Time to wander through Tokyo in the rain. 🌧️}

The relentless pitter-patter of the rain and the judging stares of umbrella-holding strangers prompts the performer to panickedly pull his phone away, leaving it lifeless in his hand before tucking it away. They only focus on the cityscape surrounding them and the boy now, blurred faces and neon resonance swallowing him whole.

The boy feels himself slowly sinking into the lights. The radiance. Ever-alluring. He tries to point at the silly scenes being shown on the screens, but the performer avoids giving him any attention.

The performer's eyes squint at the vivid, livid luminosity. The ever-changing signage. People would trade their world away for one night like this, but they never cared for it.

Their lazy eyes gloss over everything, but stop at the odd, watery reflection eyeing him from below. He kicks up the puddle, continuing onwards.

They make their way into the nearest station, just barely making it for the final train.

"*All aboard!*"

They skid into an empty car, falling into it. They lie on the floor, exhausted from the rush.

Bounded for Shinbashi Station, they'd have a rough time waiting their eleven stops 'till Shinbashi. Afterwards, what awaits them is even more walking 'till homebound. The thought of that killed them. They couldn't even care to sit on a seat and enjoy the scenery.

A shared daydream swirls softly in their eyes. The whole world's eyes averted from his. The weight burdening his eyes lifted. He wished to live in this world forever.

He could feel the atmosphere around him lightening. If there were people, they'd all be smiling. Happy people. Things like that would never come around for him, however.

His bubble bursts, and his shoulders sink deeper.

At the same time, an unanticipated halt stops the train. The lights rapidly flicker, only to go completely out after a few seconds.

Every single second feels like an hour. Every sudden noise sounds like a bomb. One comes from the other cars, followed by some few screams. The two frantically scramble to stand, distressed by the encompassing tenebra. An ominous roaring can be heard in the remoteness.

The performer flashes his phone into the darkness. As they do so, however, their eyes focus on the notification they'd just received. They raise an eyebrow, disturbed.

[...]

A few days ago, an earth-shattering calamity struck, and the blue sky bled red. A wave of irreversible heat, then cold, and lastly pure chaos.

From it, the stars returned to the night sky, after being absent for millenia. They didn't carry the same glow as before, but their luminescence was steadily returning.

Coincidentally, bizarre reports of "monster" sightings began popping up worldwide. Pictures were provided, yet nobody believed them, besides those that'd seen them in person.

The Regalia could only deny their existence at first, seemingly to keep everyone calm. Eventually, however, their broadcasts became more urgent, to the point where nobody knew what to really believe.

[...]

"Monsters" appeared in Tokyo. Around their area, in fact.

"..."

They hurriedly scroll through the different posts, bearing witness to eldritch abominations man should've never seen. The boy peeps over his shoulder, jumping up and down to see.

A certain word catches both of their eyes; one that they both saw on the news.

Entropy.

The ruin of eternity.

The bane of Creation.

Why would they come here? Nobody knows. Perhaps something was drawing them there. Maybe someone.

In that brief moment of realization, shattering glass ensnares their ears. A grotesque cephalopod as big as a small car bursts through, squeezing its way in. It's an unholy combination of a crab and a squid, two things the performer and the boy hated.

It ferociously leaps towards the boy without any warning. The boy throws up his arms in terror. The monster phases right through his body, though, still pursuing someone—the performer.

The boy sighs, remembering something. The performer stands motionless until the boy touches his shoulder. The boy whispers something, and the performer shakes his head to snap out of whatever spell he was under. The performer slides out of the way, grabbing a fallen pole of metal.

The performer wedges it into the beast's singular eye, the same, distant roar from before now ringing directly in their ears. It falls over, fumbling from the pain.

The two jump through the already-broken window and climb atop the locomotive, running as fast as they can across it. To their dismay, more roars trail behind them, all of which are of different origins.

They leap off of the train and onto the tracks, hurrying to somewhere safe. Their flamelets of hope are quickly snuffed by the appearance of a gigantic, ghastly ship, sailing silently above the clouds.

[Meanwhile, inside of the ship…]

A faint glow emanates from the captain's cabin. From it plays a haunting melody, echoing through the entire ship.

«Once upon a time, there was a man,» sings a soft voice, speaking only to herself, «a wandering soul;»

On her desk lay laminated papers of esoteric origin, their true nature only known to her. The inscriptions of ancient sigils—Vaulted Vernacular—line the documents from head to toe.

«Lost in the realm of our kingdom.»

The sigils light into a golden text, rescrambling to form coherent sentences. Words and letters float around her like a dyson sphere, though she starts siphoning all of their energy.

«They say he was a king who fought a great war.»

She rests her head on a closed fist, her head tilting as she sees a sea of neon down below.

«When the dragons came into our kingdom and burnt everyone with a roar.»

The ship rumbles with rapturous roars of fracas, the crew having engaged in their bombardment of Earth.

«Once upon a time there was a kingdom, a beautiful one.»

With the raise of a hand, the captain seals the steel door shut, so she can finish her incantations in peace.

«Surrounded in the darkness of an ancient war.»

Ancient chords are revived, resurrecting forgotten history alongside them. She grins gladly, happily absorbing this knowledge.

«They say there was a king, this wandering soul;»

The song rages on, a crawling crescendo coming through the cracks of the ship and out into Tokyo.

«Who's cursed by a demon, forever, to watch his own realm rise and fall.»

The golden text imbues itself within the captain's essence, her body now glowing with divine vitality. Her focus would be sporadic, but her spirit would get the job done.

[...]

A hymn heard from above travels down, and soon after a lady in red and pink.

Her attire is ragged, holes protruding her royal-red overcoat, but not her silken-white undershirt. A peony heads her long, messy, Neapolitan-hair, which lists lightly over her left eye. The rest of her body is covered in dark nylons, save her face. Her eyes, painted a pearly pink, shift shakily about in excited anticipation for the unfolding events.

A humanoid figure descends drearily, looking out into the vastness of Tokyo. She seems to be with the monsters.

Her glassy gaze scans every human in the vicinity, and then the performer. She seems more than delighted by their presence after analyzing them.

«You must be the one of the kids SHE prophesied of!» she laughs. «Thank goodness I found you first.»

An intense pressure befalls the two, forcing them to kneel before the lady's authority.

«Come, Ethandros. You weren't meant for this world in the first place.»

The boy glowers at the lady, rectifying his stance. He grabs the performer's shoulder, allowing him to stand.

«Defying the power… of a Sovereign..?» she ponders with a crazed smile. «You really are the stuff of legends.»

The lady slashes at the performer, but the boy blocks it. To her eyes, an immutable wall stands firmly between her and the performer.

«Eh..?»

The performer, Ethandros, was an empty husk. Constantly viewing his own life from a third person perspective, his physical self was more of his subconscious than anything.

The boy, Ethandros, was a very special thing of nature, or an invisible spirit of sorts. It could temporarily bring his senses back to him upon contact, being the personification of his consciousness.

The boy slaps the performer on the back of their head to wake them up. The performer's eyes widen, and the boy's eyes become his. He opens his mouth to speak, but his voice can only croak out a cracked response.

"What prophecy are we talking about?" Ethandros aimlessly asks, his throat burning. "You've got the wrong guy."

«Of course not.»

Ethandros sourly shakes his head. He knows he can't win against a Sovereign, but just maybe he could…

"..What do you need me for?"

«HER prophecy, the contents of which won't be disclosed.»

"Uh-huh… You're a Sovereign, right?"

«Yes..?»

"Well, why don't you become my「afflatus」?" Ethandros offers, outstretching his hand.

[...]

An afflatus, a position only attainable as a Sovereign, is an ameliorite's guiding light towards [redacted]*; therefore, they're given a sizable boost towards their full potential.*

On the downside, such a contract gives the Sovereign total control over their ameliorite, giving the latter no free will whatsoever.

If accepted, whether via handshake or written agreement, only the contractee can end the agreement. This remains true even in a rare case that the contractee is the ameliorite, and ignores the clause revoking the ameliorite's free will.

[…]

«I wouldn't dare fall for a trick of such low caliber.»

"You speak like you're above it, but you really aren't," he smirks, laughing off her intimidating confidence. "You want the influence of my Sol, don't you? Or, at least a small share in it?"

«I..?»

"If you had it, you could potentially overthrow the Regalia by yourself, couldn't you?"

«…»

"No need for any prophecy when you can just do it all by yourse—"

Without warning, he's knocked down by the blast wave of a controlled explosion. The energy blast rings incessantly in his ears.

The bridge begins to collapse, and the train falls through the cracks. Ethandros frantically crawls away from the wreckage, albeit in vain.

He falls from grace, descending into the cold, hard ground. The boy braces the performer's fall, quickly exiting his body and allowing the performer to land on him.

The malevolent lady pursues him, unsheathing a rapier from its scabbard. The boy exits the performer to roll him out of the way, reentering immediately after. A large crater defaces the space his body once was.

«I don't need to bring you back alive, you know. Bringing you back to life afterwards is an easy fix.»

She pulls her sword from the concrete, thrusting it at Ethandros. The boy resurfaces again to save Ethandros, but the captain reestablishes her Sovereignty, catching him off guard. The rapier hangs above his chest in an almost taunting fashion.

«Do you have a guardian angel protecting you, or are you awfully auspicious? ..Wait, that's the other one—»

The boy recovers, grabbing the blade and throwing it into the water nearby.

«Guardian angel it is..!»

Her eyes flash a corrupt mauve, and she suddenly seizes the boy by the neck.

«A peculiar plight. How unlucky for you!»

She throws the boy back into Ethandros and vehemently stomps on his chest, winding up her other leg for another stomp.

"You're with Entropy, aren't you?"

A golden glow envelops her legs. Her mind spins uncontrollably. Her center of gravity is displaced. Where was she? Which way is up?

"Hmm, the Maven of Miasma, Mallor, is it?"

Mallor is thrown aside into the water, a huge splash submerging the surrounding area. She bursts out into the air, her rapier in hand.

Yellow can be seen floating above the broken bridge.

«Yellow, the First Drifter. You finally made it,» she snarls, pointing her sword at him. «Where are the rest of your friends?»

"Hopefully finding their sketches, **though** I'm not sure," he says, giving a hearty thumbs-up.

She rolls her eyes, readying herself. «I fear that this is as far as you go, then.»

"Maybe, **but** are you faster?"

«Wha—»

Yellow teleports to and grabs Ethandros's hand, gripping it tightly. Ethandros gazes in confusion, but nods understandingly. In the next instant, the two appear above Mallor.

『You are able to use the skill "Dimensional Screen."』

The roaring rain halts mid-air. A kaleidoscopic set of watery walls form around Mallor, encasing her in an invisible prison. Before she can break free, she disappears into the ebb and flow.

Ethandros wobbles a bit, startled that they were standing on nothing. Yellow tilts his head, observing him curiously. 'He looks like a half-baked baguette.'

Meanwhile, the water rises and pools into Yellow and Ethandros's ambit, creating a catastrophic whirlpool around them.

"What's with those dead eyes? She didn't beat you that badly, did she? Are you really my sketch?"

"Huh..? Sketch?"

The whirlpool intensifies. The rushing water turns to white noise. The soft, starry piece plays on once more, but with a clear course this time around. Like the sketch had finally been colored.

"I'm the⌜color⌟that you're supposed to have."

Yellow tilts his head and stares into his sketch's soul. Ethandros is beyond uncomfortable. 'Why's he look all romantical and shit..?'

"But, I—"

"Not like that! I meant metaphorically!"

"..?"

Clear droplets reflect Yellow's shine, stealing the stars from the night sky. They all gather at the center of the whirlpool, floating between the two. Their atoms gather too, and Ethandros's body flows with「Perspective」.

"Is this a part of the 'prophecy' she was talking about?"

"Obviously."

Ethandros tries laughing this spectacle off, thinking it to be another one of his lifelike daydreams. "But, how could this—"

"Come, and you'll see."

『*Ψθμ αγε αβιε τθ μσε τλε σκιιι "Γεβιεςτιθη."*』

Episode ?? — Patterns

[Goodbye, [redacted]. May you rest in peace.]

Dawn's awnings shade the dying night. The rain passes Ethandros and Yellow by. A clear window of opportunity—a shifting panorama of the already-collapsed world around them—offers itself up to the two, but for what? They can't exactly remember why.

'I just need my sketch.' He could swear there was something else, though.

The sighs that Ethandros kept pinned to the walls have flown out of the room.

'But… will I find my way to you?' Yellow ruminates, watching the world fade to black. 'The memory configuration has already begun.'

Episode ?? — Elsewhere

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e

Episode ?? — Confusion

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e

Episode ?? — The Terminal

e

e

Episode ?? — Tutorial for this Little, Big Planet

e

e

Episode ?? — Shelter

“A man forged in steel, and whose name was written in gold,” he whispers.

e

Episode ?? — Look at the Sky

e

Green's eyebrows furrow as he fires up The Terminal, cracking his knuckles whilst he decodes the first tablet of «Sacred Texts» with the help of the Regalia's (stolen) software. Really, the process isn't all that complicated with such software, however. He presses a single button, leans over to grab a soft drink, reclines in his chair, and lets the program do all of the work for him.

【Processing request…】

【...】

【Success!】

[...]

Many millennia ago, starlight scattered the void like snowfall against the earth. Wandering eyes met that starlight with wonderment, praying for truly curious things from it. Those eyes belonged to the peculiar people of Earth, who lived rather peacefully amongst themselves; however, conflict roused itself from its slumber and sprinkled a bit of itself here and there.

Ergo, humans fought amongst themselves for billions of years, bickering beautiful beasts into existence. Those beasts worked under the guise of "emotions," tearing people apart all the same as it glued them together. Those beasts grew far beyond their creators,

becoming one with nature—with Truth—itself. Those beasts came to be known as Creation's Calamities.

【Creation's Calamities, also known as the Colored Crusaders, were the crux of The Somnium. They truly separated The Somnium from the other failed dreams of Truth. Beings of pure, unbridled chaos. Beings that shouldered the equilibrium of the world alone.】

【Calamity "The Most Incompetent God." Red, the most powerful mortal existence contained within The Somnium.】

【Calamity "The Knight of Twilight." Orange, the kingly servant of Red, and the right-hand man of righteousness.】

【Calamity "The First Drifter." Yellow, the esoteric essence of perspective wandering and watching the infinity of the omniverse.】

【Calamity "The Ancient Artificer." Green, the royal scientist who desired nothing more than innovation against monotony.】

【Calamity "The Stellar Liberator." Blue, the ever-persistent liberator of all, and the festivity that stays the stars' twinkling.】

【Calamity "The Lord of the Federation." Purple, the plaintive perspective that magnanimously monitors The End of All Things.】

Consequently, however, after the Fall of Foundation, they mysteriously, yet seamlessly ceased to exist. The world plunged into unfiltered monotony soon afterwards, and a deluge of despair began.

Stars fell, and Creation crumbled away as the crux of their lengthy existence disappeared.

Out of desperation to restore balance, a manifestation of myth became man. His true name was lost forever, though he commonly went by the alias "Delta." He developed the Thought Machine on account of his own tragedies, managing to revitalize the Colored Crusaders. However, unable to fully settle in at the moment of rebirth, they scattered like the starlight from so long ago.

Delta traversed the cosmos to reunite them, but uncovered the secret of this world—The Truth that trails those Calamities—amidst his trek.

[redacted]

[redacted]

[redacted]

【<SYSTEM ERROR> You do not possess requisite authority to witness『The Longest Dream』.】

[...]

Green frowned deeply, but before checking the error, inspects the dates of this composite file.

"This was from… centuries ago."

He shakes his head worriedly, wondering if this was all just some sick, preordained joke.

"Did this… already happen..?"

【<SYSTEM ERROR> You do not possess requisite authority to witness『The Longest Dream』. Termination sequence will begin shortly.】

Another error message pops up, carrying more urgency than the last.

"Huh..? Gotta be a fluke…"

『You are able to use the skill, "Reflection."』

【The Calamity "[redacted]" denies your access.】

Episode ?? — Had I Not Seen the Sun

"Grief doesn't just fade; it echoes. And this? This is what that echo sounds like."

"..."

"You can make it right, though."

e

Episode ?? — The Scientist

e

e

Episode ?? — Fire Still Flies

e

e

Episode ?? — Hated by Life Itself

e

e

Episode ?? — Rolling Boy

e

"Will I ever get to meet you again?" Green asked, his expression amiss.

Episode ?? — Set My Heart Ablaze

"Will I ever get to meet you again?"

That phrase roused the purple flower from his dreaded dormancy. His eternal winter. What was life like before that winter?

[Forever—possibly eons—ago…]

"I think I see something way off in the distance!"

"..You can see that?"

From the furthest edge their eyes could reach, an endless hallway of infinite starless space remained.

"Dad told me all about it. Said it was some unreachable horizon called 'Ultima Thule.'"

"How come we can see it, then?"

"According to some crappy legend, 'only those that realize their fate'—doesn't matter if consciously—'can manage to glimpse upon Ultima Thule.'"

"Crazy…"

“

[...]

“Sir, permission to speak?”

“Of course.”

“Where is the.. ‘adventurer’ you hired for your errands?”

“Delivering a message.”

“Then, why can I see him and the prince frolicking in a completely different direction?”

Red squinted his eyes, perturbed. There, his pageboy could be seen thrashing about in a far-off mountain range some miles away.

Red smiled faintly, nodding his head. “I’ve never seen my son more sociable around another person.”

“Though, he is supposed to be doing something rather important for you.”

“Let him journey,” Red said. “He serves a greater purpose. I can see it in his heart.”

[...]

“

"Will I ever get to meet you again?"

«...»

The brightness couldn't respond properly to the wistful boy. No response he could give would possibly satisfy him.

Episode ?? — Something Comforting

e

e

Episode ?? — Hollowness

e

e

Episode ?? — Viva La Vida

e

e

Episode ?? — Flying

e

e

Episode ?? — The Name of Life

e

e

Episode ?? — The Loneliest God

e

e

Episode ?? — Carnivore

e

e

Episode ?? — Echoes of the Empty Crown

e

The warrior turned to stone,

The maiden now of bone,

Together for eternity,

Shall never be alone.

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e

Episode ?? — Never

e

«Feels like you're getting closer to it.»

"What?"

«Freedom.»

Episode ??.5 — Dilemma

e

e

"What do people actually call us?"

"'Creation's Calamities,' or something like that…"

"That's pretty lame."

"Why don't we call ourselves something else?"

"Uhh… The Colored Crusaders!"

Everybody stops to stare at Red, blinking steadily. Green breaks the silence, giddily grinning.

"Sounds racist. I love it."

Episode ?? — Emblems of Extermination

e

e

Episode ?? — Ballad of Eternity

e

e

Episode ?? — Novus Ordo

e

e

Episode ?? — Error

e

And after losing everything (his dreamy disregard of reality), even half of his vision, the boy feels a warmth unlike any other, blinding darkness in his own mind.

Two arms envelop around him, familiar only when he was a young boy. So familiar. Wait. He hears a voice, driving him forward.

“Forgive yourself, won’t you?”

His blurry vision is suddenly overwhelmed by a bright, white light with a figure. Immediate clarity creates a new scene. A face. *Her* face. Her gentle smile—her delicate gaze—is piercing him.

He only stands there, looking at her, as she holds on for as long as this moment endured, regardless of how short it was.

And then he awoke.

A quiet waterfall streaks across his face. His body can barely carry him up, but it manages just barely.

He faces Nova with a clear expression, filled with sadness and grief from a lifetime he’s never even lived. He’s never felt so awake.

“I can use it now.”

【The Calamity “The King of a Kingless Realm” faintly smiles from beyond his enclosure.】

«Will you remember ***IT*** this time?»

Reminder to self: CHANGE EVERY PAST SEQUENCE TO PAST TENSE (i am stupid)

Legend (For **Dummies**)

‘Single Quotes’ — Internal Dialogue
OR nested quotation within double quotes
“Double Quotes” — External Dialogue
„Low-High Quotes” — Wonder Dialogue
<Chevrons> — Sacred Text/Vaulted Vernacular
OR nested quotation within guillemets
«Guillemets» — Sovereign Dialogue

[Square Brackets] — Flashback/Transition
(Circle Parentheses) — Omitted
{Braces} — Lost History

「Kagikakko」— Divine Introspection
『Nijuu Kagikakko』— Syzygy’s Stare
【】— System’s Notification/Red’s Reading